**Unwanted Entanglements**

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# Unwanted Entanglements

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Summary

A conversation in his class sets Adrien off on a trajectory of being increasingly concerned about what's going on between Mayura and his father.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

# Chapter 1

Adrien stared at his classmates as his brain desperately tried to make sense of what it had just heard. He *had* to have misheard. There was *no* way anyone would have just said that.

Oddly no one else seemed as confused as he did, so he had to point out the obvious, and hope the world would go back to making sense when they heard it, “You can’t say that, she’s a villain.”

“Yeah, a hot villain.”

Adrien looked around desperately for support and fixed on the only other person who looked vaguely disturbed, “Marinette tell them they’re wrong.”

She startled, but managed to say, “um, Supervillains aren’t really my thing.”

Alya elbowed her and said, “yeah, Chat Noir's your thing.”

Marinette glared at her.

Adrien wondered just now much of his night-time rendezvous with Marinette she had told her friend about. He wasn’t sure if he wanted to know or not. It was weird to think about them talking about him with absolutely no idea it was him they were talking about, and that made him wonder how Marinette *would* take it if she knew it was him under the mask.

Not that he could ever tell her of course. Ladybug would have his head if he did, and besides the absolute last thing he wanted to do was make Marinette a target for Hawkmoth. It *was* impressive how she’d never been akumatised but he was sure Hawkmoth could find other ways to endanger her to get to him if he wanted to.

“We’re not discussing Chat Noir,” Marinette said, breaking him out of his thoughts, “And no, I don’t like Mayura *obviously* but I guess purely from a design standpoint, she's got a pretty good aesthetic going.”

Adrien buried his face in his hands at this betrayal. She was supposed to be the sensible person in his class.

“I think Adrien's right.” Lila said sliding up to him, “I can’t see how anyone could look past what she and Hawkmoth have done.”

“Thanks.” Said Adrien, though he would have appreciated it more if she could have made her point it without basically pressing up against him, and tried to subtly pull away. “Anyway, it's *weird* you saying that about her. She’s an adult. It’s like you saying that my mom is hot, or Nathalie’s hot or something. It’s just wrong.”

The whole class seemed to be making a concerted attempt not to meet his eyes.

Eventually Nino sighed, “Dude, you know that people have celebrity crushes right?”

Images of his fanmail flashed in front of Adrien's eyes. He was *very* aware of that. It was flattering people liked him so much but it could be a bit much. He really didn’t want to know what was in the letters Nathalie didn’t let him read.

“Yeah, yeah I do.” He said flatly.

“Right, yeah of course you do.” Nino said, “Sorry I guess I wasn’t really thinking. I was just going to say it’s like finding a famous actress hot. It’s not that deep.”

As the son of a famous actress Adrien did not feel that reassured, and he *now* he just had to hope Nino hadn't chosen that example deliberately. That was not something he needed to know about any of his classmates, and it was actually kind of offensive to compare being a fan of her with being a fan of Mayura.

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“I still don’t get it.” Adrien moaned at lunchtime. He’d thought lessons would have put the idea out of his head but he just kept remembering it.  “What do people even see in her?”

Alya grimaced, “Based on the comments I get on the Ladyblogger a weirdly high amount of men seem to think they can,” She made air quotes “turn her back to the light side.”

“How do you know they’re men?” He asked.

“Trust me. They’re definitely men.” She said sounding tired.

“So people think she’s redeemable?” He said eager to exploit any possible avenue to defeating the villains. He’d never seen any sign that Mayura had any qualms about what she was doing himself. She seemed devoted to Hawkmoth and their cause. Though he guessed maybe the men on the internet *did* have a point. If she *wasn’t* devoted to Hawkmoth then maybe she wouldn’t involve herself in their fights.

It seems pretty unlikely to work as a strategy though. They had no idea who Mayura *was,* so it’s not like they could try to set her civilian identity up with someone, and even if they could find someone to volunteer to do it, he doubted they’d succeed, given she’d have no reason to waver from Hawkmoth. Besides they didn’t even know what sort of guy she’d like apart from apparently tall and evil.

Alya had a hundred yard stare on her face. “Some of them, others, well let’s just say I block a lot of comments on there. I know she’s evil but I don’t feel comfortable having that sort of thing up there.”

Adrien wasn’t really sure exactly what she was implying but he could tell it was bad from her tone, and his friend’s reactions.

Marinette frowned, “No I agree with you, that’s not right.”

Nino slung an arm around his girlfriend hugging her, “Is it getting that bad again?”

She sighed, “I have seen *so* much I never wanted to see.”

Marinette bit her lip in concern, “Um, people don’t say that sort of thing about Ladybug do they?”

Adrien hadn’t even considered that and he struggled to stop the sheer fury he felt from showing on his face. Apparently all that having to repress his emotions at home *did* count for something. He still wanted to go to the house of every single person who had ever dared to write something like that about Ladybug and cataclysm their computer.

Alya groaned, “I have a policy against any sort of sexual comments about Ladybug and Chat Noir, they’re not adults.”

He hadn’t ever thought about the fact his *own* alter-ego might get that treatment too, but he cared much less about that than he did about it happening to Ladybug. He did wonder if maybe he should be less flirty in public with her though. He didn’t want to put ideas in people’s heads.

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Nathalie looked up when he popped his head in the Atelier door. “Did you need something Adrien?”

“The printer isn’t working, can I use your one?”

“Sure.”

As he walked past her computer to retrieve his homework he noticed the news website up on half of her screen, with a huge photo of Mayura and Hawkmoth emblazoned over the top, and the conversation in class earlier came back to him in all its horror.

There was a more pressing issue though. “There’s not an akuma attack is there?”

“What?” Nathalie looked between him and her screen only then seeming to realise what she was looking at.  “No. Sorry I was just looking at this write up of their attacks to see if we should be overhauling the house’s security.”

“Right.” With the worry about missing an akuma attack gone his brain was now fully able to return to its awkward screaming.

Apparently this was fairly obvious.

“Is something wrong?” Nathalie asked.

“Sorry, just a weird conversation in class today.”

For some reason this caused his father to look up from his screen, “You wouldn’t have to deal with that if you went back to home-schooling.”

Adrien forced himself not to roll his eyes. The last thing he needed was a lecture about developing bad habits. “Going to school is worth the cost of having to deal with weird conversations about Mayura being hot.”

Nathalie choked on her coffee, and then started on a coughing fit so extreme Adrien was concerned she was going to run out of oxygen.

“Do you need a thump?” He offered weakly, unsure what to do. He’d offer her a tissue but she’d already taken one from the box on her desk.

She shook her head as much as she was able between coughs.

His father who had ran over once it was clear she wasn’t going to just stop looked equally as lost as Adrien for what to do, but he had started gently rubbing her back.

Finally Nathalie eased up and took a sip of water from the glass on her desk.

“Are you ok?”

“Fine. Coffee went down the wrong way.” She wheezed out.

Adrien was about to make his apologies and leave, not least because of how his father was glaring at him, as if he’d made Nathalie choke deliberately, when she managed to get out “You don’t do you?”

“What?” He said, lost for a moment before he grasped her meaning, “Oh, think Mayura’s hot? No way. I like *Ladybug* like a normal teenager.”

“Oh good. That’s good.” She said, though her voice still sounded strained from her coughing fit.

“Yes, Ladybug is much more age appropriate.” His father added though it sounded like he was forcing the words out through gritted teeth.

It made Adrien wonder, even though maybe it was just as simple as his father not liking the danger Adrien would be in if he dated Ladybug, “Wait, do *you* like Mayura?”

“That’s ridiculous.” He snapped, but blush staining across his cheekbones told a different story.

Nathalie’s face had gone carefully blank and he realised that this must be an awkward conversation for her to be stuck in the middle of. The last time he’d tried to bring up the idea of liking someone to dig around into what was happening between her and his father she’d said it wasn’t an appropriate topic for her to discuss with him.

Sometimes he still wondered about the two of them despite both their denials. Nathalie's concern over his father certainly *seemed* more than just what she was paid to do sometimes, and if she did have feelings for him then hearing that he liked Mayura was probably the last thing she'd want out of her day.

He tried to downplay the issue, "Just saying, I don't get it, she's evil, and she's pretty vicious, so I don't get why anyone other than Hawkmoth would like her but apparently you're in lots of company if you do."

He was still thrown by everything Alya had said and he vaguely wondered if he should ask Nathalie if she knew any comment-moderation software he could recommend to her but he could tell this wasn't the right time.

"I don't know why you're so shocked Adrien, Mayura's an attractive women, and she has style, which is more than can said for the heroes, and you can't say she's not impressive. It's not surprising she has admirers."

How people kept missing the point that Mayura was *evil* he did not know. She should *not* have admirers, and how his father could watch one of their fights with her and have his takeaway be that she had style he could not, ok actually that *did* sound like something his father would do. Being more interested in someone's outfit than in the person underneath wouldn't be a new thing for him.

Stupidly though Adrien still pushed the issue, even though he knew he probably didn't want to hear the answer. "But you're not one of them?"

His father's frown deepened. "I don't know where you've got this recurrent idea that I'm planning to replace your mother, but you can forget it."

Adrien wasn't sure that was the denial his father thought it was. What he'd actually asked was just if he thought she was attractive, which his father hadn't actually answered. Instead he'd brought up the idea of being in a relationship with her of his own accord which was frankly disturbing.

Instead of pointing this out he just shrugged and said, "Good. We don't need to give Hawkmoth any more reasons to target us."

Even if the idea of having someone seduce Mayura away from Hawkmoth *wasn't* impossible he definitely wasn't volunteering his father for it. Even if he guessed that he might be Mayura's type physically given he wasn't a dissimilar sort of build to Hawkmoth. It wasn't going to happen though. He refused to consider the idea of having Mayura of all people for a stepmother. He wished he *had* been right in his suspicions about his father and Nathalie-*that* would have been a much safer place for his father to start showing interest in women again.

Anyway he was sure it was fine. There was no reason for his father to meet Mayura at all seeing as he barely left the house, and even if he did there was no reason she'd be interested in him. He loved his father but he wasn't exactly an emotionally available person, so he'd hardly offer something to distract Mayura from Hawkmoth unless she was really into the idea of free clothes or something. Or money he guessed, but he figured that if Mayura was

motivated by money she could have used her Miraculous to acquire some quite easily *without* trying to steal his and Ladybug's.

Besides when he'd left the Atelier his father still hadn't taken his hand off Nathalie's back, so whatever *he* might claim Adrien wasn't convinced there was nothing there after all.

# Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Sometimes, Adrien thought, it really did feel like fate was out to get them.

Not that he could *ever* regret being chosen as Chat Noir and meeting Ladybug but he could have done without the reminder that walls were no barrier to Hawkmoth's akumas and that his father was just as vulnerable to akumatisation as anyone else in the city so soon after his naive thought that at least his father's reclusiveness meant he was unlikely to ever meet Mayura.

Rationally Adrien knew people couldn't help being akumatised, and that they couldn't be held responsible for what they did when they were, but that was much easier to remember when the person in question wasn't his father, and when said person didn't keep *flirting with Mayura.*

He hadn't been sure that was what he'd been seeing at first. He'd wanted to believe he was wrong. The Collector *was* overdramatic and theatrical, how he pulled her in to whisper to her and offered her an arm before they leapt a particularly large gap could have just been that.

Then he *kissed her hand,* making Mayura flush a darker shade of blue and yeah ok Chat Noir was theatrical too and he wasn't going around kissing anyone other than Ladybug.

Ladybug clearly shared his feelings because she made an incoherent noise.

"You're seeing this too then?" He groaned.

"I'm not sure *what* I'm seeing." Ladybug said, "I know akumas twist their victim's feelings around, but we've never seen something like *this* as a side effect before. Do you think Hawkmoth's getting more powerful or something?"

"I *hope* not." Chat Noir said but then their conversation got cut off when Mayura's sentimonster attacked again and they had to get back into the action.

As the fight went on all he could think was that this was so much worse than the last time his father had got akumatised.

The property damage, and the chasing after his Miraculous he could shrug off and blame on Hawkmoth, but he couldn't use that explanation for *this*.

Hawkmoth was hardly going to command someone to flirt with his partner. Unless he knew that Adrien was Chat Noir and that it would throw him off his game then it was all completely pointless, and he *couldn't* know Adrien's identity because if he did he could make much better use of that information than akumatising his father and having him make advances on Mayura.

So Hawkmoth had no good reason to do this and he had good reasons *not* to do it given he was pretty sure they were partners in more senses than just supervillainy based on how they acted.

Which left him with the disturbing option that this was all his father.

Ladybug yanked his arm down, and pulled him behind a chimney, “Chat! Don’t throw your staff. Remember what happened last time?”

“Oh. Sorry. Yeah, bad idea.” Fantastic. Now he looked like an idiot in front of Ladybug. “Sorry, this whole thing is just *weird.*”

“Yeah, you can say that again.” Ladybug said, “Even Mayura seems distracted, if this is some game she and Hawkmoth are playing then getting our Miraculouses doesn’t seem to be their normal priority today.”

“*Game?*”

Ladybug blushed, “I don’t know, I thought maybe this is a weird thing they do together for you know, fun. He doesn’t akumatise adults very often, maybe they’re taking the opportunity.”

Adrien stared at her. In all the explanations he’d considered and disposed of he’d never considered that it might be *Hawkmoth* flirting with Mayura through his akuma, just using his father as a conduit. That was weird, and horrid, and yeah only something someone as uncaring of other’s feelings as Hawkmoth would do, and it made him feel faintly dirty to think of it. “You think *Hawkmoth’s* making him do this?”

“What other explanation is there?”

Of course Ladybug didn’t have the knowledge Adrien had of his father’s attraction to Mayura, but admitting that was both embarrassing and impossible to explain how Chat Noir would even know that.

And maybe Adrien was doing him a disservice anyway. For all he was convinced *something* was going on between his father and Nathalie he was still devoted to his mother after all. Just because he might agree Mayura was pretty didn’t mean there was anything more there.

Adrien himself was quite capable of noticing someone was pretty without actually falling for them. Even when he tried to convince himself to try moving on with Kagami he’d known that Ladybug was the only girl for him. Just not being blind and seeing that girls like Kagami and Marinette were pretty didn’t mean he’d start hitting on them if he ever got akumatised. Or at least he *hoped* he wouldn’t. Maybe he should just concentrate on not being akumatised.

“Yeah, I guess you’re right.” He admitted in defeat. “That is just *so* wrong though.”

“They *are* supervillains.”

As the fight went on he wondered if Ladybug had a point creepy as it was.

If this *was* someone dug out of his father's psyche by his akumatisation then why Hawkmoth hadn't put a stop was something he couldn't understand *at all*.

If someone else was acting like that with Ladybug *he'd* intervene immediately, and they weren't even dating.

"Hey," he yelled at the Collector, "If you like Mayura so much why you don't just collect *her?*"

Much as encouraging him to trap anyone in his sketchbook seemed like a cruel idea he figured that it was alright when the person in question *was* a supervillain.

His adversary paused for a second and looked considering. "My dear Mayura *would* be the jewel of my collection." Then he shook his head, "What's the point of having everything without someone to share it with?  No. I think I'd much rather add you."

Adrien dodged the sudden swipe he made at him, and went back to ineffectually trying to knock the book out of his hand with his staff without it coming into contact with said book.

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The flaw in the idea that all of this was Hawkmoth's doing was that if it was then Mayura shouldn't look so thrown at the situation, and she did. In fact she didn't look at *all* like someone that had expected any of this at all.

Adrien wasn't sure how he felt about that.

He didn't *want* her to flirt back, but sometimes the panic that flashed across her face when the Collector did or said something a little too clearly interested made Adrien feel uncomfortable that his father was making her feel like that, even though his father couldn't help anything he was doing, and Mayura was a terrible person.

Maybe Hawkmoth thought this, and how uncomfortable it was clearly making Mayura was price worth paying for the akuma, and he just couldn't be bothered to try to command the akuma to stop. It wasn't like he had any other moral qualms. Maybe he shouldn't be surprised that Hawkmoth was a terrible partner as well as a terrible person.

It didn't seem like a winning strategy though. When Mayura leapt off a building to the street below she seemed so surprised at being caught in The Collector's arms that she hadn't noticed she'd dropped the pencil that controlled the amok.

Adrien was too frozen in his horror at how her mouth had opened slightly and she was staring into the Collector's visor and his face was tilted down towards her and the visions of where

this might go next to take full advantage of the situation.

Thankfully Ladybug was less distracted by the situation and managed to retrieve the pencil and at the sound of it snapping both villains looked up and went back on the attack.

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“Interesting tactics.” He remarked to Mayura, now she’d been forced to return to fighting up close and personal.

She sighed and suddenly looked very tired, “Trust me. This is all Hawkmoth’s doing.”

“That’s kind of disrespectful of your boyfriend,” He pointed out.

“My, he’s not.” She shook her head, “I don’t even know why I’m talking to you.”

“Yeah, Hawky’s usually the talkative one of the two of you.”

“Please don’t call him that.”

“Who’s going to stop me?” He pointed out, “Seems like he’s done *way* more embarrassing things to you.”

Mayura wasn’t able to meet his eyes, “I’m sure none of today is deliberate.”

“Seems kind of a tough thing to do accidentally.” Adrien pointed out, and then he decided to take a risk and attempt to find out the truth, “Unless you’re having some sort of affair with Gabriel Agreste or something.”

Mayura tripped and fell off the roof.

He wasn’t really sure if that was a positive answer or a negative one.

Hopefully it was a negative one. His father neglecting him in his grief, or for his work was one thing. Being neglected so he could go off and have some *thing* with Mayura was quite another.

Mayura doesn’t seem to be moving, and he climbed down after her and told himself that it’s just because that’s what a hero would do, and it wasn’t because his father might be in love with her.

When he nudged her shoulder she started and rolled over and up into a crouch looking admittedly understandably frantic.

Pushing past his reservations about attacking an injured women he swiped at her with his staff but then she managed to spring sideways.

“So is that a yes or a no?”

“What is *wrong* with you?”  She said, “That is *not* what is going on here.”

“What *is* then?”

“I don’t know!” She somehow managed to shrug between dodging his staff, “I was concerned about whether the Collector would know to leave me alone. I guess this was Hawkmoth’s solution.”

“I wouldn’t really call what he’s doing leaving you alone.”

“I realise that, yes.”

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“I think Mayura’s weakening.” He told Ladybug.

“Do you think we can take advantage?” She said, “*He* seems pretty protective. Maybe if we strike at the right time we can get both of them.”

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Not for the first time Mayura was struck by a coughing fit, and not for the first time he wondered exactly what was going on with her, and why she wanted their Miraculouses anyway.

Ladybug caught his eye, and he realised what she meant and quietly generated Cataclysm. It wasn’t very chivalrous to take advantage like this but he figured Mayura'd be ok, as he used his staff to propel himself so he could cataclysm the ledge she was standing on.

Mayura didn’t seem to notice how it was crumbling and how the he’d gap he'd created widened towards her but the Collector looked up and ran over, catching her and pulling her back onto firm ground.

Ladybug took advantage and grabbed the sketchpad he’d dropped to hold onto her and freed the akuma and purified it before he could notice.

For a moment after his transformation dropped his father still clung to Mayura then she seemed to realise the situation and shook off his hold and fled.

His father blinked at them, “What happened to me?”

“You were akumatised.” Ladybug said.

"*Again?*" He asked, "What happened? Is my son safe?"

Adrien couldn't help but enjoy being his father's first concern. He knew he cared for him, he *did*, but it would be nice if he could show it sometimes outside life-threatening situations. Or in situations outside life-threatening situations which didn't include refusing him from going out with his friends for his safety anyway.

"Adrien wasn't caught up in the attack." Ladybug reassured him, but then she hesitated, "You um, might want to look up footage from it though before you talk to anyone. Especially reporters.

He frowned. "Why? Everyone knows akuma victims aren't really in control of what they do."

Ladybug looked uncharacteristically awkward and if it was literally anyone else Adrien would have intervened and broken the uncomfortable news for her but he couldn't tell *his father* what had happened.

Ladybug took a step back from his father, "Your akumisation was kind of flirting with Mayura?"

His father stared at them both. Then he finally seemed to process what they'd said, "I *what?"*

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Adrien returned from feeding Plagg some camembert. Nino had texted that Mlle. Bustier had let them out of class early since it wasn't worth trying to finish what they were doing after the time they'd lost to the attack so he had a little time before he had to head home.

Just as he'd hoped Ladybug was still there.

He sat down next to her, "Strange day right. Who acts like that? Even akumatised?"

*"*He kind of reminded me of you actually." Ladybug said.

"Me?!" He yelped, "*How?"*

"I'm pretty sure you've tried to pull some of those moves."

He couldn't help making a face he was fairly sure his father would tell him off for, "I am much more smooth than that my lady."

He *was not* having his courtship of Ladybug compared to what on earth was happening between his father and Mayura. Not that anything was happening. But even having the idea used as a comparison was just *wrong.*

"Keep telling yourself that Kitty." She said swinging her legs off the edge of the roof, "Seriously though, that was weird. I literally never would have put the words "Gabriel

Agreste" and "Romance" together in my head. Except *maybe* for some of his early collections."

"Gabriel Agreste can be plenty romantic." He defended his father, "he just…doesn't really have the chance to be these days."

"I guess." Ladybug said though she still didn't look convinced, "I suppose he must have been different when his wife was around."

"He *was."* He stressed, "He was a completely different person with her. You've seen the painting of her in her Atelier."

"uh, yeah I did." She said, staring at him, "Do you know him?"

"Uh, I know people that work with him." He said. It wasn't technically a lie. "So I hear things. Like about how there's the statue of her in the garden too, and trust me that's just the start. He'd do *anything* for her. He basically fell apart without her there. I mean that's *kind* of romantic."

Ladybug looked at him, and he didn't want to make sense of the expression in her eyes. "I don't think that's romantic Chaton. That's just sad."

"Yeah, I guess it is."

She put her took his hand, "He should be looking after his son. I mean he's lost his mother too hasn't he? That's what *I'd* want if I was in Emilie Agreste's place. Not multiple shrines to me."

He wasn't surprised. He knew Ladybug was a good person, and of course she'd want that.

Not that his mother wouldn't want that too-she'd always been able to pull his father away from his work and into spending time with them, but she'd probably wouldn't mind the multiple shrines either. After all she'd posed for the paintings, and the photos, and the stature. He didn't know how to explain to Ladybug though that it wasn't just some function of his father's grief but a pre-existing part of his parent's dynamic.

His father had enjoyed capturing her in art, and she'd enjoyed him immortalising her, and honestly Adrien *got* that otherwise he wouldn't have bought so much Ladybug memorabilia, but that *definitely* didn't feel like something he should say to Ladybug.

"You do know that right?" She said confirming his feeling that he shouldn't have said anything more.

"Sure Bugaboo," he said pasting on a fake smile, "I promise to be a completely present and active father to our future kids."

She let go of his hand and stood up, "Chat! You can't just say things like that. I like someone else! And we're *way* too young to be thinking about kids."

"Ok" He said, "I promise to be there for *my* future kids. Can I say that?"

“Yeah, yeah you can say that.” Ladybug said sitting back down by him, “Chat, *is* everything ok with your family? I know you can’t say anything that would identify you but I *do* worry.”

“Everything is,” he sighed, “It’s not great, but we’re just going through some difficult times. We’ll come out of it.”

They *had* to. Preferably not in a way that netted him Mayura as a stepmother though.

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Nathalie opened the door when he got back from school and while there wasn’t anything he could *quite* put his finger on he thought she looked a little bit more frazzled than usual.

“Adrien.” She smiled slightly manically, “You’re back.”

He looked past her to the Atelier door.

“Is my father alright?” He asked, “I saw the Akuma attack on the news.”

“Of course you did.” She said flatly, “It’s better that you don’t disturb him today. There’s food in the kitchen. I thought you might want a snack?”

Somewhat unsure at why all of this was happening he followed her in there, and then found himself mechanically chewing on some Nutella and toast while Nathalie stood by him and asked him about his school day.

It wasn’t bad *exactly.* It was nice for someone in the house to show an interest in his day, and he deliberately tried to make school sound as good as possible in case she was asking because she was planning to report back to his father on this.

When he finished he expected Nathalie would leave him to his homework but she hesitated, “Do you need anything else? Help with your homework?”

She was acting very odd. Not that it was unusual for Nathalie to help him with his homework, she did it more than his father ever did, but generally he’d ask her, or maybe she might ask if he was clearly struggling in front of her. She didn’t just volunteer out of nowhere.

Suddenly it all made sense to him, “You’re trying to avoid Father aren’t you?”

Nathalie’s posture become impossibly straighter, “Of course not. That would be inefficient. I’m just trying to fulfil my role by helping you to of the best of my abilities.”

A rush of pity for the woman in front of him went through him. While he still didn’t really know what was happening between her and his father they were definitely friendly enough that she can’t have enjoyed seeing him making a spectacle of himself with Mayura.

*He* found it awkward and he barely saw his father these days. He couldn't imagine seeing someone all day and being forced to imagine them with one of Paris' supervillains.

"I guess you could help me with my English?" He offered in sympathy. Hopefully if he gave her an excuse then his father's annoyance would be split between the two of them, so he wouldn't be *that* badly cross at either of them. Plus, he might want the space too. Adrien certainly would it that was happening to him.

Maybe he *shouldn't* try to escape Nathalie's supervision and check in on him right now.

---

Adrien rolled out of bed that morning before his alarm and rushed to the shower, putting on the clothes he'd laid out yesterday when he finished.

Once he'd done he glanced at his phone and strolled out of his bedroom in triumph. Nathalie wouldn't be here looking for him yet so he had a chance to talk to his father first.

He tried the Atelier first. It felt *slightly* less daunting than trying his father's room. Thankfully he was already up and dressed at his on his podium.

He didn't acknowledge Adrien's entrance.

"Father?"

His father looked up suddenly and Adrien wondered if he'd just assumed it was Nathalie entering earlier.

"Adrien. Why are you here?"

"I wanted to check you were ok, after yesterday."

He softened slightly. "I'm fine. You know akuma victims barely remember anything."

"I know." Adrien said, "But yesterday,"

"Was all Hawkmoth's doing. I can assure you I'd never pursue Mayura like that in my right mind. I wouldn't betray your mother like that."

Honestly any thoughts of it being a betrayal of his mother had been the last thing on Adrien's mind but now his father had brought it up he couldn't help but think if his father was going to move on that she *did* deserve him to pick someone better than *Mayura.*

"Sir," Nathalie stuck her head in the door, "Have you seen," She stopped on catching sight of him, "Adrien what are you doing in here? You should be eating breakfast."

His father looked back down at his screen, "Could you escort Adrien out? We've finished our conversation."

He headed to the doors under his own power before he could be thrown out, but he *did* notice a shoebox on Nathalie's desk with a post-it note with her name written on in his father's handwriting.

"Did you need a new pair of shoes or something?" He asked at while eating his breakfast carefully watching Nathalie for a reaction.

He couldn't detect anything more than confusion from her.

"I wasn't aware I did." She said, eyeing him if *she* was trying to understand him, "Why?"

"There was a shoebox on your desk with your name on."

She stilled then put down the coffee cup she'd been drinking from. "You shouldn't look through other people's things Adrien."

"It was sitting right there."

"Your father must want me to return a pair to our suppliers." She said, "Now you better hurry up, or you'll be late for school."

That was the end of that, but Adrien wasn't convinced by her answer and resolved to keep a watch out for her turning up in a new pair of shoes. He thought *flowers* were the usual apology present but then maybe Nathalie would find flowers impractical. His father knew her better than him.

And an apology present meant he must have some reason to apologise to her, and that meant that maybe Adrien *did* have an alternative to Mayura he could push his father towards.

Then he realised that it was quite likely Nathalie might have been the Collector's first victim for a second time around and it could have just been an apology for that, and that *that* might have been why she was avoiding him last night and he deflated slightly.

Chapter End Notes

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# Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

People's stares weren't exactly a new thing for Adrien. It came with the territory of being a famous model. Usually though people at school were either used to him being there, or didn't care, so he just *knew* that the eyes he could feel on him today were because of yesterday.

Even the chatter in his class quieted as he walked in. Other people in his class had got through *actually* being akumatised with less reaction than this.

He could see the laughter in Nino's eyes, when he approached their row.

"Don't start." He warned him.

Nino held out an earphone, "I made you an 'I'm suffering because my dad's dating a supervillain playlist'."

Adrien slumped into the seat, "He's not dating Mayura. He was *akumatised*."

"Well, yeah but when most of us get akumatised we just go on rampages across the city, we don't hit on the supervillain we're doing it with."

"We don't know that," Adrien lied, "Akuma victims don't remember much, for all we know plenty of them flirted with Hawkmoth before Mayura was on the scene."

Nino stated at him in horror, "*Why would you put that idea in my head?* Gross."

Alya leant over and patted him on the head, "it's ok, I've *never* found any evidence of that happening."

Adrien took a deep breath and tried to channel Chat Noir and say something he wouldn't usually say because he *had* deserved it, "I'm not apologising."

Nino did not seem as shocked by this as Adrien expected.

"Ok." He said, "*Maybe* I deserved that a little, but come on, if your dad wasn't your dad then you have to admit it *would* be hilarious. He's all pretentious and acts like any emotion is below him and then when he gets akumatised he immediately hits on Mayura?"

"We shouldn't laugh at Akuma victims." Alya said, "but it *is* a little funny."

"Didn't he say I was a bad influence?" Nino said, "but he's the one fraternising with supervillains."

Adrien clutched at me hair, uncaring about if he was messing it up, "he's not *fraternising.* He was akumatised."

He had an upsetting premonition that he was going to be repeating that a lot today. Maybe he should ask Plagg if his Miraculous gave him a sixth sense.

Thankfully the conversation was ended by their attention being distracted by Marinette running into the classroom just on time by the skin of her teeth, and then Mlle. Bustier's entrance a second later.

---

Lila came over to their table at break, "I just want you to know that *I* at least know that Akuma victims aren't responsible for what they do, and if you need to speak to anyone without judgement I'm here."

"Um, thanks?" He said, "But I'm fine. Really."

Much as he understood Lila's wish to have friends and establish herself in a new school, and it was a horrid thing to think when she was trying to be nice, he sort of didn't really want to be one of them. There were lots of other people in the class who didn't know about her lying. He wished she'd try to befriend one of them instead.

Once Lila wasn't looking at them Marinette rolled her eyes, and then blushed when he saw her doing so. He couldn't really blame her. He'd be cross if he'd been the one she'd try to expel but Marinette seemed to be able to be polite at least with Lila so he guessed she wasn't too torn up about it anymore.

Nino made a face, "I know she's trying to be nice but she *does* know you're not the one who got akumatised right?"

Adrien tried to put the best possible face on it, "Maybe she wants me to pass it on? She did *convince* my father to hire her as a model."

Nino muttered, "I don't think it's your dad she's interested in."

He decided to pretend he hadn't heard that.

"I'd forgotten she did that." Alya said having apparently actually not heard her boyfriend, "How did she do that anyway? Not that she isn't pretty but your dad doesn't exactly issue invites to your house? How did she even meet him?"

"She talked her way in I think." He said, "Apparently you just have to offer to help with my schoolwork?"

Honestly he still wasn't sure how she'd done it. Nathalie was very tight-lipped about the whole scenario.

"She's good at that." Marinette piped up "I'll give her that much."

Alya frowned, “Marinette,”

“What?” Marinette said, “She was acting like she’s the only person who’s ever been akumatised here.”

“Huh,” Nino said, “You kind of have a point.”

“I guess with how unusual the rest of her life is she forgot that that wasn’t.” Alya said but she did sound uncertain, “Let’s not talk about her anyway, I don’t want to argue.”

His phone went. Unsurprisingly it was Nathalie rather than his father. The message though, he couldn't decide if that was surprising or not.

“You ok?” Nino asked.

“Er, Nathalie’s told me not to come home for lunch.”

“How bad a mood is your dad *in?”*

“He seemed ok this morning.” He said because he *had*, “But Nathalie said he just saw the news so.” He shrugged, and did not envy Nathalie the time at home alone with his father.

“D-did you want to come back to mine for lunch?” Marinette said.

Adrien stared at her. This was something new from her. It must be a sign that Marinette was more comfortable being friends with him now.

“Not that you have to or anything!” She continued, “But if you wanted to get out of here and didn't want to go home. You could. Come to mine.”

“That sounds like a great idea.” He accepted, “Come on guys let's go to Marinette’s.”

Alya took Marinette’s arm and pulled her ahead of them out the door. He looked at Nino as if he’d offer an explanation but nothing was forthcoming.

---

“Talking about news,” He said as they walked there, “What are your commenters saying about it Alya?”

Alya looked between Nino and Marinette who were both shaking their heads frantically.

“I think it’s better that you don’t know.” She said.

He was about to argue that, and then he remembered all the fanmail Nathalie didn’t let him read and the one time he’d snuck one of those, and maybe she had a point and he’d leave it for now.

Chewing on an absolutely heavenly croissant Adrien couldn't remember why he didn't go to Marinette's more. Oh right, his father wouldn't approve. Sometimes at times like this he missed his Maman, after all she'd always been the ones to organise his playdates with Chloé. He was sure she could have convinced his father to let him go to Marinette's.

Though had she been here he might have never gone to school, and then he never would have met Marinette. Or Nino. Or Alya.

The others were distracted by Alya's phone but they were all *refusing* to let him look at it. He didn't fight it too much because after from his earlier realisation he wasn't sure the wanted to, even if they were just on usual news sites. He'd seen enough of his father and Mayura up close and personal yesterday.

Marinette detached herself from the group, "Are you ok?"

"Just weirded out by all of this." He said, "But look it's fine. You know what akumatisation is like, it doesn't really *mean* anything."

He'd been repeated that to himself mentally since yesterday.

"I-I don't know anything much about akumatisation," Marinette said, "But I'm sure you're right. It's probably nothing."

"Exactly. Just because he thinks she's hot it doesn't mean he's interested."

Nino choked on his crossiant, Marinette dropped hers onto his plate, and Alya put her glass down on the table so quickly he was fairly sure she'd down it to stop herself from dropping it.

"He *what?*" said Nino sounding far too shocked for someone who'd basically been teasing him about that all day.

"He said she was 'attractive and had style' which is pretty effusive for him."

Alya was staring into space. "This is a total scoop and I can't post it unless I want to see so much I don't want to see in the comments and submissions."

"Since when do you and your dad even have conversations like that?!" Nino said.

"*I* was just telling them about school," Adrien defended them both, "It's you lot who brought up the question of Mayura's attractiveness!"

"Technically none of us were the ones to say it." Nino pointed out, "But I'm going to be more careful about what I say now. I didn't think you and your dad even *talked*."

“Look anyway,” Adrien said trying to change the subject, “Even if he *was* interested it’s not like anything would happen. I mean you saw her. It's not like Mayura was interested, and I’m sure she’s very busy being a supervillain and doing whatever it is she does when she’s not attacking Paris.”

Alya looked up from the screen of the phone she picked back up, “She wasn’t into it at the start no, but I don’t know some of the later photos look awfully cosy.”

Adrien had a really unfortunate feeling he knew exactly what moments she was referring to.

“In the middle of a fight, it’s easy to fall into that sort of thing then, look at Ladybug and Chat Noir.”

“Yeah,” Alya said, “And we *know* there’s something going on between them so I don’t think it helps your argument.”

“I don’t think we know anything’s going on between Ladybug and Chat Noir.” Marinette said.

He almost asked her how she knew that but then he remembered how he’d commiserated over being unlucky in love with her as Chat Noir.

“All that shows is maybe she enjoyed The Collector flirting with her. That doesn’t prove anything, lots of people flirt with people without it meaning anything,” or people in the fashion world did anyway, “and it doesn’t mean she’d be interested in my father when he’s just himself.”

“I don’t know.” Said Nino. “Your dad *does* seem like Mayura’s type.”

“*How?”*

Nino started checking off his fingers, “Tall, mean, doesn’t like teenagers, makes everyone scared of showing their emotions, secretive, likes butterflies, hates me….it’s *all* there.”

Alya laughed at him, “It’s a bit big-headed to claim Hawkmoth hates you. I don’t think anyone other than Ladybug and Chat Noir are even on his radar.”

“Hey, my father *does not* hate you.”

The three of them looked at him sceptically.

“He just doesn't like you,” Adrien said weakly, “and he does have good points.”

“Like what?” Nino says.

“um,” Adrien started and frantically tried to find something that was true, and that they'd believe and appreciate, “He, um, he does want what’s best for me. He’s just bad at it.”

The others looked between each other awkwardly.

Nino took pity on him, “I mean I guess he’s successful? *That’s* something he doesn’t have in common with Hawkmoth.”

Alya had a thoughtful look on their face, “They’re both determined though, and ambitious, and single-minded. I guess your dad’s just better at it than Hawkmoth.”

“Hey, my father’s a better person than Hawkmoth.”

“I guess,” Nino said, “Unless it turns out Hawkmoth’s secretly a great dad, in which case it’s kind of going to have be a toss up then I guess do have to give that much to your dad on the basis he doesn’t attack Paris constantly, but seriously that is a *really* low bar to clear. You know that?”

“Could you imagine being Hawkmoth’s kid though?” Alya said, “Now that’s an interview I’d love to get.”

Marinette looked pale, “I hope Hawkmoth doesn’t have children. That would be horrible.”

“Yeah me too.” Adrien said. It would really mar their defeat of Hawkmoth if it turned out they were depriving some kids of their father, even if it was all their own fault, and even if he was sure that Hawkmoth would be a terrible parent.

Or rather that Hawkmoth *and* Mayura would be terrible parents because he hoped there wasn’t anyone else in Paris that would procreate with *Hawkmoth.*

---

“Dude, cheer up.” Nino said as they walked back into school, “I was joking earlier. Mayura is *so* out of your father’s league there’s no *way* you could end up with her as a stepmother.

Adrien didn’t see how that followed at all, “*She’s a supervillain.* If anything my father is totally out of her league.”

The others were uncomfortably silent.

“…you’re saying that because he’s rich right?” Alya said.

“I’m saying it because he’s not evil, and anyway you lot were the ones saying he’s more successful than Hawkmoth. She’d be lucky to have him.”

They continued to say nothing, and Adrien felt offended on both his father’s behalf.

“All I’m saying is that he’s the better option.” Adrien pointed out.

“Anyone has to be better than Hawkmoth right?” Marinette said.

“I guess he did put her in an awkward position yesterday. Alya conceded.”

---

Ready to salvage the Agreste family honour in romantic situations Adrien stopped by the desk of the only one of his friends who actually knew his father, “Chloé help me!”

Chloé popped the bubble of bubblegum she’d been blowing, “Sure Adrikins. What with?”

“Tell them my father totally could convince,” his mind skated over word choices before he landed on, “Mayura to date him if he wanted to!”

She blinked, “Not what I was expecting you to ask but yeah, obviously.”

Unfortunately this didn’t seem to completely convince his friends.

Nino shifted under Adrien’s vindicated gaze, “Um, you have seen them both right?”

Adrien wasn't really sure what that meant but Chloé seemed to because she rolled her eyes, and twisted her gum around her finger.

“Duh.” She said, “I’ve probably seen both of them more than any of you, and firstly you’ve clearly never seen Adrien’s mother, and secondly loads of couples my parents know look like him and Mayura together would. Like not blue though.”

“See,” said Adrien.

---

Adrien craned his head to see what Nino was doing under his desk, “Are you Googling my *maman?*” his hissed.

Nino was saved from replying by Mlle. Bustier calling on him to try to solve a maths problem.

It probably made him a bad friend that for once he wasn’t that sympathetic when Nino got it wrong.

---

He looked down at where Nathalie was sat further down the dinner table while he did his homework at one end. His father hadn’t emerged from his Atelier since he’d come back from school so Adrien figured this was as safe a time as any to ask her.

“Nathalie?” Adrien asked.

She looked up, “Yes, Adrien?”

“I know my father thinks Mayura’s attractive but, do you think he *actually* likes her?”

“No.” She said and went back to tapping at her tablet screen.

That was a substantially shorter response than he’d been expected. Even from Nathalie.

“No? I mean it’s just,”

“Adrien,” she interrupted, “I can guarantee you with 100% certainty that your father is not romantically interested in Mayura.”

He known Nathalie basically all his life and weirdly, if he understood her at all, she did seem to actually believe what she was saying. Which was good because if *anyone* knew about his father having some secret thing with Mayura he was pretty sure it would be her but it didn’t really answer, “What was yesterday then?”

She sighed, “Frankly I have no idea, just don’t bring it up to him. The media coverage has been…difficult for him.”

“What about you?” He asked. It couldn’t be easy seeing everyone talking about his father and Mayura.

“Yes, there have been a lot of phone calls, but that’s my job.” She said, and he couldn’t tell if she’d deliberately misunderstood him or not.

“So you think it was all Hawkmoth’s doing then?”

“That would seem to be the only answer.” She said.

“What did he get out of it though?” Adrien said, then admitted, “I’ve been trying to work that out, and I just can’t.”

“It’s a mystery to me too.” Nathalie said suddenly sounding very tired, but she stood up and walked over to him, “I know it must have been distressing to watch but I promise you that your father is committed to your mother as ever.”

“I don’t mind my father moving on,” Adrien tried to explain to her, “I know she’s not coming back.  If someone can make him happy again, can bring back the father I remember, then I *want* that for him. Please don’t think I don’t. I just object to it being Mayura.”

What reaction he’d expected from Nathalie he didn’t know, and he didn’t get much of one, but he knew he *hadn’t* expected her to take a slight step back from him and swallow.

“That’s very good of you Adrien, and I can definitely reassure you that you don’t need to worry about Mayura but,” She paused, “I can’t tell you there’s someone out there who could make your father happy. *He’s* not ready to move on, and I don’t know if he ever will be.”

That was about as bad as confirmation he wasn't going to be expected to welcome Mayura into his family could get. She might have meant to just tell him his father wasn't going to move on romantically but it sounded like he wasn't going to move on from his current frozen state at all.

And that was worse than Adrien had thought really, because he'd always hoped that things would improve, especially with the sporadic bits of affection his father had offered him recently, and yes, offered Nathalie too.

"Anyway," Nathalie added in a lighter tone, as if he was a much younger child she was trying to distract, "Meeting someone would entail your father leaving the house, and I think we both know that barely happens."

"He wouldn't *have* to." Adrien pointed out.

Nathalie seemed to shut down again, "Please don't suggest to your father that he try online dating."

Annoyed as he was at how this time she was obviously ignoring his hints deliberately he still almost laughed at that image. "Yeah, I'm definitely not doing to do that."

Why she was being deliberately obtuse now he wasn't quite sure. If she was uninterested then she'd just tell him. So that suggested she *was* interested, but based on her other answers she thought his father wasn't. Which he wasn't so convinced of, but then he also wasn't as convinced that his father definitely wasn't interested in Mayura, and he knew which of the two of them he preferred, so maybe he was seeing what he wanted to see.

He really hoped he wasn't though, for Nathalie's sake, and his father's and his own.

---

Just before bed he transformed to check in with Ladybug. She'd left a message on his staff and he smiled on seeing the communication then his smile dropped when he actually read it.

"I know we said it was Hawkmoth but do you think Gabriel Agreste and Mayura might actually be interested in each other?"

Adrien resisted the temptation to throw his staff across the room.

Chapter End Notes

.....and I'm back from angst town

Also I have a ML tumblr now for fic queries/prompts/etc

# Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

in which no one handles this well, except maybe Ladybug

Nathalie seemed to be eyeing his breakfast with faint disgust as she went through his schedule. He looked at how she was holding onto the marble countertop. Then he considered the heavier than usual amount of base make-up she was wearing.

“Are you not feeling well?” He asked.

“Just a headache.” She said. “Hopefully the paracetamol kill kick in soon.”

From the wince she made at the call emanating from her tablet he didn’t think she was lying about that at least, but she picked it up and took the call anyway.

“Seriously, there isn’t anything more wrong is there?” Adrien pressed once she was done. Nathalie never used to get sick at all, and now she seemed to constantly be getting coughs and colds, and she’d almost seemed about to faint a few times.

“Just age.” Nathalie said. “Have you all your homework?”

Looking at his folders he realised *didn’t* actually and he ran off to get it.

“It’s not a lie.” He heard her say to the Gorilla as he left the room, “I used to be able to get away with drinking that much on a weekday.”

---

School wasn’t too bad. Or it wasn’t until break.

“um, Adrien?” Alya said. “Can we talk? In private?”

Adrien was confused but followed her outside.

“I know everything with your dad must be really tough for you, and I know Mayura’s a villain, and I know some of those other commenters were out of line but if you keep starting fights like that I'm going to have to block both your accounts from the Ladyblog.”

Now he was even more confused. “What are you taking *about?”*

“Last night”

“What are you *talking* about?” He repeated, completely and utterly lost.

She silently passed over her phone and showed him a commenter’s post history.

Adrien looked at the comments written by someone who sounded halfway deranged, and apparently wasn’t too good with their spelling or grammar either. Especially in later posts. They’d started off seeming to lay out the reasons why Mayura and Gabriel Agreste were clearly not a thing, but their posts had seemed to devolve off topic over time.

“This wasn’t me.” He looked up to find her watching him.

“I *do* actually believe you.” Alya said, “But if it’s not you then I *definitely* don’t think you need to worry about your father and Mayura.”

“Um, Alya?” He said, “I think I’m missing something? What has any of this got to do with my father and me?”

Apart from the obvious of course.

“I traced the IP address. The posts came from your house.” She said.

Adrien read over a post that described his father of being “utterly blind and incspable of taking other people’s emotions into account.”

“I don’t think this was my father.” He said.

Alya frowned, “I mean I did kind of think it sounded like more like a woman but no one else lives in your house right?”

He decided not to tell her the number of times Nathalie overnighted at their house had increased until she’d basically moved in.

“Why did you think it was a woman?”

Alya took the phone from him, “Some of the posts are a bit, well look at this one for a start.”

Adrien looked at a post where the poster castigated people for thinking Mayura was anything particularly attractive, rather than just blue, and telling them they all had some weird fetish, and that they walked past women who looked like Mayura on the street all the time, and didn’t notice them at all, and maybe that those of them who weren’t weirdo-rapists should pay attention to the women in their own lives and not one that wasn’t accessible.

He wasn't really sure why Alya thought that sounded like a woman generally but it *did* sound like something a specific woman who was currently being ignored for Mayura might say.

“I think I might know who it was.” He said, “I’ll uh, pass on your message.”

Nathalie had apparently taken his father’s flirtation with Mayura far worse than he’d realised.

---

“Nathalie, are you ok?” he asked when he got home because he had a feeling that asking if she was jealous of Mayura wasn’t going to go down very well.

“Fine.” She said.

That didn’t really leave him many inroads.

“Um, just so you know, you’re just as pretty as Mayura.”

“Thank you Adrien.” She said but she didn’t really sound particularly thankful. “I like to think so, yes.”

He wasn’t sure if that was sarcasm, even though he couldn’t quite see how it could be, and really there was nothing he’d like better than to not have this conversation but he *really* didn’t want to have Alya block their IP address. The Ladyblog was useful for Chat Noir to have access to *and* it had all the best photos of Ladybug.

“Did you know one of my classmates runs the Ladyblog?”

Nathalie’s knuckles went white as she gripped her tablet tighter.

“Adrien.” She said. “I’m going to say something extremely unprofessional to you, and give you some important life advice.”

“OK?”

“Don’t post on the internet while drunk.”

“Ok.”

“And um,” She said, “Don’t look at the comment section of that website. It’s a cesspit. Your friend needs to get an adult to moderate it for her.”

“Yeah, I think she’s considering that.” He said.

“And, don’t mention any of this conversation to your father. Ever.”

---

When Adrien managed to catch his father coming out of the Atelier that evening he thought they might have a chance to talk about all of it. Or all of it except for the bit Nathalie had asked to keep secret at least.

Instead his father caught sight of him, stopped, and turned around and went back in.

After that Adrien didn't dare try knocking at the door.

---

As the days went on calmed down at school as everyone mostly moved onto new gossip. Especially as both Hawkmoth and Mayura seemed to be keeping a low profile and sending out their akumas and amoks without going out themselves.

He'd discussed it with Ladybug and the others at school but they hadn't really found a satisfactory explanation for this change in tactics.

The best they'd come to was that maybe Mayura had been too embarrassed by the incident with the Collector.

It *would* explain why the staff at a magazine that had gone big on that story seemed to be a current focus for the villains' targets.

Whether that meant the flirting had been Hawkmoth's fault and he was trying to apologise to Mayura, or that he was concerned he didn't have full control over his akumas and that was why they weren't making physical appearances he wasn't sure.

---

Everything did not calm down at home. He'd literally never seen Nathalie and his father so awkward around each other.

Adrien wondered if his father had seen the blog posts too.

Of course he couldn't *ask* him because that would involve his father actually being around to ask.

---

"Come on Plagg," He implored his Kwami, "Eat quicker."

Plagg glared at him around the camembert he was eating and Adrien could admit that probably hadn't very helpful. He needed to get back out there and fight though. Ladybug needed him.  This newest akumatisation, Facestealer, was a tough one to fight.

Neither of them wanted to get close to him in case he took *their* faces, and that wasn't just because of any vanity. Judging by how his victims kept getting in the way they seemed to lose their sight with their faces.

The sound of a scream getting cut off round the corner suggested that opponent's presence and he took out down the street in the other direction at a sprint.

Somehow he'd screwed up because he found himself face to face with the very person he was trying to run from.

Then Mayura jumped in front of him, and Adrien was terrified she'd worked that he was Chat Noir and waiting for his kwami to recharge but he realised a second later that she'd landed facing Facestealer not him.

"No." She said to Facestealer. "Not him.  Not this time. Go after Ladybug."

"You're not in charge of me." He said.

"Who said I was talking to you?"

"What?" His opponent started then stopped as Hawkmoth's glowing mask appeared over his face, "What's so special about Adrien Agreste? Alright Alright I'm going."

Mayura didn't turn around but he could see her relax.

"Run home Adrien." She said, "This isn't a good place to be today."

"Why save me?"

"Call it a whim."

What she'd never know is that by saving *Adrien* she'd actually saved *Chat Noir* and essentially guaranteed her and Hawkmoth's defeat in this particular battle.

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"So." Ladybug said when she sat next to him on a beam of the Eiffel Tower after patrol. "Mayura saved Adrien Agreste today."

"She did." He admitted, trying to sound calm and ignoring the swirling in his stomach that had been going on since it happened. He felt odd, as if he'd walked into a parallel universe where everything was just subtly different.

Mayura having some weird mutual attraction with his father was one thing. He could almost get that. He'd had some *weird* dreams lately that had led his to the inescapable conclusion that he might still be attracted to Ladybug if she was a supervillain, even if he wouldn't love her without everything that made her her. So he could kind of get it.

Mayura apparently caring about Adrien-him was another thing entirely.

“Did you see if she said why? I was too far away.” Ladybug said.

“She called it a whim.” He said, “Purrsonelly I feel a bit put out that if she was going to choose a super hot blonde teenager to save she chose him rather than me. It's like all those times I fought her counted for nothing. I really thought we had a connection.”

As hoped his performance *did* bring a smile to Ladybug's face, “Chat, I'm pretty sure that Mayura saved Adrien because of his dad, not because he's better looking than you.”

“You think Adrien Agreste is better looking than me?!” They literally had the same face. Except for the eyes. Maybe Ladybug didn’t like the cat eyes. Wait. There was something more important here, “You think Adrien's cute?”

She liked Adrien. She liked *him.* The more boring version of him, but *him.*

“He’s, I,” Ladybug spluttered, “He’s a model, of course he’s ridiculously good looking.”

“But do you *like* him?”

“He’s a really great person. Of course I like him.”

Hearing her say that made him feel all warm and fuzzy but he had to know, “Do you like him, or do you like *like* him though?”

“I” Ladybug’s tone turned accusatory, “You said you knew people who worked for his father. Do you know people that work with Adrien. *Do you know Adrien?”*

“Um,” He wasn’t sure how much he could safely admit or how much he could hide without making it obvious he was hiding something, “Kind of?

“You can’t tell him!” She said.

“So you *do* like him?”

“Seriously Chat he *cannot* know.”

“Why not?”

“He can’t know *Ladybug* likes him. What if he wants to date Ladybug? What would I do then?”

“Then you’d date him?” He said confused as the issue, but knowing he wasn’t going to like what she was going to say.

“I can’t date him as *Ladybug.* Firstly it wouldn’t be fair to him-he doesn’t even know me.”

Sometimes he really hated their secret identities and that he couldn’t tell her now that he totally did.

“He just thinks of me as the Hero of Paris, he can’t actually like me, and what if he offered to date me because he felt obliged because of everything I do? No. The only way I can date him is if he asked out civilian me.”

“I don’t think,” Adrien started but Ladybug kept talking.

“And secondly I could never endanger him like that. We’d never be able to keep it a secret, not when we get enough paparazzi attention separately. Hawkmoth would probably target him. I could get Adrien *hurt.*”

He wanted to say that Adrien could take care of himself. He wanted to say that Adrien fought Hawkmoth all the time anyway. He wanted to see she wouldn’t believe how touched Adrien was at hearing someone want to put him first when his own father was barely even acknowledging him at the moment.

Instead he said, “Date him as a civilian then.”

Ladybug laughed, “You make that sound so easy.”

“I’m sure you’re just as cute behind that mask. He’s an idiot if he turns you down.”

Ladybug shook her head, “We’ve supposed to be talking about his father and Mayura, not about Adrien and me.”

“I would much rather talk about you and Adrien.” He told her. She could have no idea how true that was.

“How are you so ok with my liking Adrien?” Ladybug said, “I can’t believe I’ve been saying all this to you, it’s so insensitive of me.”

“It doesn’t bother me.” Adrien said and she’d kill him if she knew how true that was, “I just want my lady to be happy. If Adrien Agreste would make you happy I’ll do all I can to help. He sounds much better than that other boy you liked.”

“Other boy?”

“The one who wasn’t interested?” and he still couldn’t understand how he could not be unless Ladybug had just completely misunderstood the situation somehow. Maybe that boy didn’t know Ladybug was interested and was too shy to approach her or something.

Well it was his loss, and Adrien’s gain.

“*That* other boy.” Ladybug said, “Yes of course. Obviously I’ve moved onto crushing on Adrien. That’s what’s happening here.”

“Well, I’m here if you ever need to talk about Adrien.”

“What we *need* to talk about is Adrien’s dad.”

“Do we have to?”

“Yes.”

“Ok. I can see he might be an obstacle to the whole dating Adrien plan. Actually,” he had a horrifying realisation, “he probably definitely would try to interfere but I think we could work around it.”

“I meant about him and Mayura.”

Unfortunately he guessed she had a point. This was probably one of the distinctly non-fun parts that came with being a hero.

“Alright then,” He conceded, “What did you want to say?”

“There *is* something going on between them isn’t there? I wondered before but then it all calmed down, and I wrote it off as just an akumatisation thing, but with today it can’t be can it?”

“You’re probably right. Though I don’t see *how* there could be anything. People would notice if Mayura turned up his house. *Adrien* would notice. And it’s not like he leaves the house to go to her’s. That would definitely be noticed.”

“You think Adrien doesn’t know then?”

“I’m certain Adrien doesn’t know.” That was about the only thing he was certain of. “He was just as confused at what happened with Mayura today as the rest of us.”

“I guess you’re not supposed to introduce people you’re dating to your kids until it’s serious?” Ladybug said.

“I don’t think. That is. They can’t be actually dating. They couldn’t keep that a secret. They’re both too recognisable and well known.”

Ladybug’s gasped, “Mayura’s too recognisable, but Chat, what if *she’s* dating him as a civilian? That would make as much sense for her and him as it would for me and Adrien.”

That opened up a whole new kettle of fish but, “No no he can’t be. He’s not dating anyone. The only women he interacts with are clients, and other people for work, and even most of that is virtual.”

“We can’t know that.” Ladybug said, “He’s very private, they could just be keeping it quiet. It’s not like I could even blame him for that.”

“Keeping it from the public is different to keeping it from Adrien though,” he pointed out, but the disquieting thought occurred to him that after all he barely saw his father. For all he knew maybe he was spending time with Mayura in all that time he was supposed to be working.

“Adrien might not know she’s Mayura. He might not even know she’s more than a friend.”

“No, Gabriel Agreste doesn’t really *have* friends. Just business partners and colleagues.” The only person that he might say managed to count as both was Nathalie and she *definitely* wasn’t dating his father unless they had some weird definition of dating where you both tried to spend as little time together as possible when you were supposed to work together.

“You were the one who was defending him last time,” Ladybug said, “Why are you so convinced this is impossible?”

“He’s still not over his wife’s disappearance” he sighed, “Just ask Adrien. He’s not in a place to date anyone.”

“Oh,” Ladybug said, “I thought maybe…” She trailed off.

“*Wait.* Do you *want* him to date Mayura?”

She threw her hands in the air, “Sort of?”

“*Why?”* That made no sense at all. He understood why she was interested in what was going on but he just could not get why she’d actually be in favour of it, “You can’t *want* Mayura as a stepmother-in-law, think how difficult family events would be.”

He’d ignored her earlier message but it really was starting to seem like for some reason she was invested in this idea.

“I could handle it!” She said, “Wait, no. I mean what are you talking about, you can’t just make assumptions like that!”

Personally he thought that was less making assumptions and more the logical endpoint of his father dating Mayura and him dating Ladybug. “I’m just saying, if you’re dating Adrien, and she’s dating his father,”

“I’m not dating Adrien!”

“Not yet!”

Ladybug stared at him, “You are really confusing me today.”

“You’re confusing me. I can’t understand why you’re so invested in Mayura’s dating life.”

“Because, and trust me, I can’t believe I’m saying this but, I think Gabriel Agreste is a good influence on her.”

“*What?”*

“She saved Adrien today. We’ve never seen her care about a civilian before. Maybe if she’s got people to care for and protect she won’t be as interested in whatever she and Hawkmoth are trying to do. If she’s doing it for Hawkmoth’s sake she might even stop.”

“Are you saying she’s *cheating on Hawkmoth* with M.Agreste?” That seemed deeply unlikely to Adrien. With how offended his father had been about the idea of betraying his mother even

though she was gone he really didn't think he'd help someone else cheat on their partner. Even if the partner in question *was* Hawkmoth.

And anyway if dating Ladybug would put in danger then his father having an affair with Mayura would definitely make him a target for Hawkmoth, and with how overprotective he was he couldn't see his father doing that.

Though it might explain all the upgrades to the security system.

"I don't know!" Ladybug said, "I'd thought she and Hawkmoth were a thing, but I'm rethinking that now obviously."

Adrien stared out over Paris. He was supposed to be a hero and he *liked* being a hero. Being Chat Noir was one of the best parts of his life. But he'd never thought heroism might mean trying to set his father up with a supervillain.

He bet this didn't happen to other superheroes.

Ladybug didn't say anything either and they sat in silence for a bit.

Then he heard a noise below him and when he leaned over to look, there were the two supervillains they'd been discussing the whole time.

Ladybug pulled him back into the shadows as their enemies went on unaware below them.

"Are you sure there's even anyone here to see us?" Mayura said, "I don't understand why you didn't just come out to one of the fights and do it there."

Both he and Ladybug looked at each other in concern. That Hawkmoth might have tactics or powers other than akumatising people wasn't something they'd thought they needed to worry about.

"We couldn't afford that type of distraction." Hawkmoth said, "The heroes would be sure to take advantage. This is safer, and I tipped off a photographer."

Adrien wondered if they should try and take advantage now but Ladybug was still holding him back apparently interested in what they had to say.

"Isn't *that* dangerous?"  Mayura said.

"They think they're going to catch a glimpse of Ladybug and Chat Noir," he said, "They meet up here often enough."

"Ah, so *that's* why here. I thought it was a bit stereotypical."

"*That* my dear Mayura is the point." He closed the gap between himself and his partner, "This is supposed to look romantic."

Mayura took a step back and looked at her feet, "Maybe this is a bad idea."

“We can’t have the rumours going around you and Gabriel Agreste.” Hawkmoth reached out and took her hand, “You know that.”

He assumed that it was just Hawkmoth didn’t like the idea of his partner with another man, but he still couldn't help but feel a bit reassured that no one entangled in this situation wanted talk about it.

“I know, but this, I don’t know if we should do this,” Mayura said, but she let him pull her back towards him, “With our goals, isn’t this a betrayal of those?”

Ladybug’s hold on him tightened and his ears pricked up quite literally. Learning Hawkmoth’s final goals would be quite a coup.

Mayura was close enough now that Hawkmoth reached over to caress her face with his other hand, “It’s just acting, she’d understand that.” He said, “It’s not real. We’re not doing it as *us*. Just follow my lead, like we practised in the lair.”

Then he lowered his head to kiss her, and Hawkmoth might have taken the lead but it looked pretty real to Adrien.

Especially when Mayura curled her leg around him, and his hands went to her hips to lift her up off the ground. That was a new way to used their enhanced strength he guessed.

“Huh,” Ladybug said, “That split in her skirt comes in handy for more than fighting.”

Adrien looked at her askance, wanting to know why she would point out *that.*

Despite the dark he could just about tell her face was now much closer to the colour of her suit than it had been before.

“I meant for manoeuvrability” She said.

The two supervillains separated after much longer than Adrien thought was really necessary and Mayura said, “Do you think that looked convincing?”

Considering their foreheads were still pressed against each other he wasn’t sure how she could think it didn’t.

Hawkmoth didn’t answer her immediately, and while Adrien hadn't actually seen him in person that many times, his whole body language seemed different to how he'd ever seen him in a fight.

“I think.” Hawkmoth started, and that unfamiliar emotion on him started to look like uncertainty, “If we leave now it should plausibly look like we're going somewhere more private.”

That seemed to convince Mayura because she disentangled her legs from around him, and he gently placed her back on the ground. Hawkmoth’s hands lingered on her hips but she reached down and took one in her hand and at this he released his other hand.

“Let’s go.” Mayura said and the giant moth Sentimonster of theirs appeared out of nowhere and they climbed onto it.

It did, Adrien supposed, explain how they'd seemed to get hear out of nowhere when there were no buildings around to jump down from.

“I guess there goes our chance of following them.” he said to Ladybug.

“After *that* maybe it's a good thing we can't.” She replied sounded slightly dazed, “I don't want to know what else we might walk in on.”

“What *was* did we even just watch?”

“I don’t know. Why did he call it *acting?”* Ladybug frowned, “The rest, maybe they are in a relationship and just wanted to make a show, and maybe she just had stage fright but why were they talking about it not being real?”

“It looked pretty real to me.” He pointed out. He wasn't quite sure how he felt about that. Logically that should be good. Hawkmoth and Mayura could sort out their issues and get together, leaving his father and Nathalie free to work out their relationship without any involvement from Supervillains.

Something was off about it all though, and maybe it was just his lingering gratitude for her intervention earlier, or maybe all that talk about having her for a stepmother had got to him, but while Mayura *had* seemed pretty into the kiss itself he didn’t think her earlier nervousness had been faked, and that made him uneasy, as if maybe he should have stopped it somehow.

“I guess there goes your idea of hoping she’d chose M.Agreste.” He said trying to ignore that unease.

“I don’t know.” Ladybug said, “Something odd is going on here.”

# Chapter 5

Unfortunately while checking his phone at breakfast *had* meant he'd been able to check if Hawkmoth and Mayura's little show had made the news he wasn't able to see how or if his father had reacted to it.

Nathalie at least seemed pretty unbothered by the situation. Or at least he couldn't notice anything much different about her apart from that she seemed a little distracted compared to normal.

Giving up on the adults in his life, his decided to focus on his own life. Or to be more pertinent, *his and Ladybug's lives.* She liked him, and she was willing to date him. Except she didn't know that. Or she knew that but not that he knew that.

Their secret identities made things complicated.

And that *was* the problem. Ladybug had said the only way this would work was if Adrien dated whoever she was behind the mask, and the whole point of everything was that he didn't know who the love of his life was behind the mask.

All he could think of was doing was him-as-Chat encouraging Ladybug to approach him-as-Adrien as her-non-Ladybug self.

Which could backfire if some other girl approached him but he was *fairly* certain he'd only be interested back if it was Ladybug.

Or so he hoped.

At least he knew neither Lila nor Chloé were Ladybug.

Most of the other girls he knew were paired up anyway. Sometimes he couldn't help but feel envious at that.

He loved school, and he loved what he had with Ladybug, and he didn't resent his friends and their relationships at *all.* Even when Nino abandoned him for each Alya. It was just that sometimes he'd like to have that for himself too.

To have a relationship with someone he could just hang out with normally. Or as normally as his father would allow him. To have someone he could talk to. To be someone's most important person.

His conviction that he wasn't bothered by his friend's relationships was tested by him finding Nino and Alya making out in his row when he got in.

"*In the classroom?"* He said, waiting for them to stop before taking his seat.

"This," Alya said, "Is important journalistic research."

“Are you inventing a new euphemism?”

“You know what those are?” She asked, as she finally stepped away from Nino.

“I was homeschooled not completely shut off from the outside world.”

Nino raised his eyebrows, “You kind of were. You literally said *Chloé* was your only friend. Also I've seen your house.”

“I had the internet, and television, *and* I did sports over the years ago it's not like I never met anyone. And I went to stuff with my parents. I do know what a euphemism is. Journalistic research is just a new one on me.”

“Ok, but it was actually a very important experiment.” Alya said passing him her phone to show him pictures of Hawkmoth and Mayura, “*See.”*

Huh. He could kind of see that their pose was sort of reminiscent of that, but he really did not think that made it better. Maybe for someone who hadn’t watched it in person in hiding it was easier to see it was something other than really awkward to watch but, “I see the inspiration but I remain confused as to the how that lead to you making out in the classroom.”

He guessed Alya would report on the photos but he didn’t think that needed her to recreate how they were standing.

“We’re settling an argument.” She said, “Rose thinks that they needed their superstrength to get into that pose, and Myléne thinks anyone can.”

“Really?” he said looking back towards the cluster of girls at the back of the class who just shrugged at him. Obviously Chat could pick Ladybug up. For that matter Ladybug could pick *him* up which made him feel funny inside but in a good way, though it wouldn't really be helpful in that position with their height difference. Ladybug wanted to date *Adrien* though, and now he was kind of interested in whether Adrien could pick up Ladybug or civilian-Ladybug.

“It might be possible.” He said, answering his own thoughts as much as talking to his friends.

He had some pretty good arm muscles from fencing and everything else he thought.

“It's harder than it looks.” Nino said.

“Maybe Alya's just too tall.” He said unthinking, before he realised that might be rude, “Sorry Alya! I mean you’re a totally normal height! Your height is fine!”

“It’s ok Adrien.” She said looking amused, “I get what you meant. Nino and I don’t have Hawkmoth and Mayura’s height difference. You and Marinette would make better a better test case.”

He found himself looking round for her, “Where’s Marinette anyway? Do you think she’d let me try and pick her up?”

“Yeah,” Nino said, “Yeah, I’m pretty sure she’d let you, but you know she *never* gets here before the last possible moment.”

Nino was right, and he concluded that maybe that was a good thing, because he wasn’t really sure why he’d been so ready to try that with Marinette albeit without the kissing because he wasn’t about to kiss someone who was neither Ladybug nor interested in him, when he was supposed to be focusing on *finally* getting his chance with Ladybug.

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“So,” Alya said, “If you have time before you go for lunch, then Marinette said she’s happy to try it out with you.”

Standing next to Alya Marinette seemed to be doing a pretty good impression of a tomato.

“She doesn’t have to!” He said. “Don’t feel pressured to do it.” He tried to reassure her.

“I don’t mind.” Marinette squeaked.

That didn’t really convince him that she wanted to do it, but if she’d decided to do it then it seemed rude to keep asking her if she was sure, and he *really* wasn’t sure what he was supposed to do now that Alya had asked him on her behalf.

He hadn’t been *going* to do it because of everything with Ladybug, but it seemed rude to tell her no and he didn’t want to hurt her feelings anymore after what he’d already done to her as Chat Noir.

This didn’t have to be anything. It was just an experiment. He could totally just pick Marinette up and let her wrap her legs around him platonically. It would be fine.

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It was not fine.

First he almost dropped her, which was bad enough, but then he’d managed to brace her against the row behind her and she’d gasped and he’d thought he’d hurt her, but she’d said she was ok, but none of that was as bad as the current moment.

Because Marinette had really really pretty eyes.

He’d *known* that obviously, but it was different staring straight into them at this angle.

They might possibly even be prettier than Ladybug’s but that was a really hard comparison to make without both girls there in front of him.

And she was looking at him all expectant, and he thought she might be expecting him to kiss her, and *worse* he thought he might want to kiss her, and maybe if this had happened before yesterday he would have because Ladybug was always encouraging him to move on, but now he knew Ladybug liked him, and he'd encouraged her to pursue him and he didn't know what to do.

Anything he could do felt like he was treating either Marinette or Ladybug or both of them wrongly.

He still found himself leaning in towards her as if he was watching a film of himself doing in in slow motion.

Miraculously his phone went and stopped him. It was probably the Gorilla letting him know he was outside. Usually he let Adrien slide on punctuality but if it got to a point where Adrien might be in trouble with his father or Nathalie then he was good at letting him know.

"I," he blinked as if that would break the spell her eyes were casting on him, "I have to go."

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"You should have just kissed her." Plagg said, once no one else was around on the way to the car.

"Not helpful!" Adrien said, "Especially if you're saying that because you want to steal her parent's cheese."

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He hadn't meant to admit any of it at home but because he obviously looked upset enough that Gorilla stayed with him for lunch, and Adrien felt like he had to admit it all.

"I just," he buried his head on the table, "don't know what to do."

His bodyguard patted him on the back supportively.

"No one told me love was this complicated."

"No one tells any of us that," Nathalie's voice came from the doorway, "Is Adrien alright to go back to school?"

The Gorilla shrugged, and left Adrien to answer the question himself.

He groaned, "How much longer until I have to?"

“Not that much time,” She looked at her watch, “Though I suppose I could call you in sick if I had to.”

“All that complaining about school and now he wants to skive off?” His father said.

“Sir!” Nathalie span around, “I didn’t mean,”

He waved it off. “I trust your judgement with Adrien, but I need you back in the Atelier now, we’ve a problem with the fabric supply delivery. What’s wrong with him anyway?”

Adrien was delighted to hear he ranked below a fabric supply problem.

Nathalie and the Gorilla looked between each other, as if they weren’t sure what to say.

“I think Adrien should tell you himself.” Nathalie said, as if she hadn’t just dropped him in it. There was no *way* his father could understand Adrien’s situation. He’d probably just tell Adrien he should concentrate on school and not on girls. “I’ll deal with the fabric problem.”

“Nathalie.” His father said warningly, as she passed him on her way out.

She stopped, “It’ll be fine sir. You can handle this.”

A look passed between them and not for the first time Adrien wished he understood *why* his father has some nebulous *thing* with Mayura when Nathalie was right there as an alternative.

His father sighed but came and sat next to him, and Adrien realised the Gorilla had followed Nathalie’s example and exited from the other door of the dining room.

Traitors both of them.

“So what exactly is the problem?” His father said.

“There’s this girl,” Adrien started and he swore his father rolled his eyes but he pushed on, “and I love her, she’s the love of my life I think and she likes me too, but there’s obstacles to us being together but I’ve just discovered a way it might be possible.”

“I see.”

“But, there’s this other girl-a friend, and I like her and I like being with her and she’s really pretty too, but I didn’t think it was anything more than that but then I almost kissed her, and if the first girl wasn’t there, I’d ask her out and I think she’d say yes, but I don’t want to betray her, but I don’t want to hurt this girl either, or lead her on or,”

“Adrien,” his father cut him off and he prepared for whatever he was going to say, “If you’ve found out you can just tell me. There’s no need to try to make up some story to talk about it.”

He had not been prepared for that, “Found out what?”

“Nothing.” His father said hurriedly, “Are you actually saying all of that happened to *you?*”

“Yes?” Adrien couldn’t think *why* anyone would think he’d make something like that up. “Wait. Did you think I was talking about you and Mayura? Something *is* happening there?”

“That’s,” His father swallowed, “That’s none of your business. And I think you should hold back from going any further with *either* of those girls until you’ve decided what you want, or you’ll only have cause to regret it. Trust me.”

It wasn’t bad advice but Adrien wished he knew if his father was just saying that because he didn’t want bad publicity, or didn’t want Adrien to date, or if he really thought that was the best course of action. Though those last two words had the ring of truth.

“Do really think that?”

“I’m not in the habit of saying things I don’t think. So yes. Now shouldn’t you be getting to back school?”

Adrien stood up with no little ill grace, wishing he’d taken Nathalie up on her offer quicker.

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Thankfully the Gorilla let him stay in the car until the final possible moment when he had to run into school.

He did his best not to meet anyone’s eyes on his way into class.

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“Um, Marinette?” He asked after class, “Could I talk to you? In private?”

She nodded, and followed him round to an empty classroom. Adrien wasn’t sure they were allowed to be in here but he didn’t want anyone to hear any of this.

“About earlier. I” He sighed, “I’ve just realised I might like you, I mean I *knew* I liked you as a friend, you’re a great friend, but as more than that.”

Marinette was starting to smile and he felt awful.

“But, I can’t act on that,” he said and saw her face fall, “Because I’m in love with Ladybug, and it wouldn’t be fair to either of you if I dated you. Because you’re a fantastic person and you remind me of her a lot. Not because you’re both really pretty, but because you’re both kind and smart, I mean I have no idea how she works out her ideas for how to use her Lucky Charm sometimes, just like I don’t know how you come up with your designs,”

“They’re not that special.”

“They *are.* Both my father and Audrey Bourgeois praised them, and I can tell you few people can say that.”

He’d gone off topic.

“But, anyway, it’s not fair for me to use you as a Ladybug-replacement when I still want her.”

She made an incoherent noise, and just as he was about to apologise again she said, “I wouldn’t mind.”

“What?”

“I wouldn’t mind being used as a Ladybug replacement.”

“Uh, Marinette, did you hear my whole thing about how it wouldn’t be fair?”

“Ok but,” She said, “You don’t really know Ladybug. Couldn’t you just give us a try?”

“I’m sorry.” He said. “I just don’t think it’s a good idea.”

He fled the room before he could say anything more.

He heard a crash from instead the classroom like she’d kicked the wall, and he realised he’d really messed up. Maybe he shouldn’t have said anything.

---

In his defence Adrien hadn’t meant to eavesdrop. He’d meant to go in and ask Nathalie for help with his homework, but the door had opened a crack when he’d gone to knock on it, and he’d seen her get up from her desk to walk to, he presumed, his father.

He probably should have gone away then, but he thought he’d wait and see if it looked like she was going to be busy for a long time.

“I’m sorry, sir.” Nathalie said, “It’s not working, your name is still being brought up in all these articles about Mayura.”

Now the idea of not listening was impossible. He *had* to know if something was going on, and at least it was a distraction from his *own* dating issues.

“Let me see,” his father said, then there was a pause as he must be reading through whatever she was showing him. “Well, it’s early days yet. With time it should die down.”

“*Can* we wait for that?”

“I don't think we're in danger from it, but continue to monitor it, if necessary we might need to provide a little more reinforcement.”

“Yes sir.”

“And calm down Nathalie. I don't blame you. I know you gave it your all. Perhaps my own performance was,”

“You were very convincing.” She said, “I don’t think that was the problem.”

Unfortunately at that point he must have leant on the door a little too put because it opened and both their heads snapped in his direction and they took a step away from each other.

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That night when he transformed Adrien had a message from Ladybug on his staff.

It said, “DID YOU SAY SOMETHING TO ADRIEN???”

He decided to put off answering that for now.

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Of course Hawkmoth decided to attack the brand party he went to the next day ruining the one benefit of it being a Saturday and him not having to see Marinette by forcing him to see Ladybug.

At least she was too preoccupied with the akuma to talk to him much.

He was fairly sure she was cross with him though.

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Mayura gave a little wave, from the bannister she was sat on a higher floor, and he went after her letting Ladybug deal with the akuma.

By the time he got up there though she’d disappeared.

“Looking for me?” She said from behind him, and he twirled around, raising his staff.

“Oh, I wouldn’t do that.” She said, “Or who’s going to call my sentimonster off from these panicked civilians.”

He looked between the magic mirror she'd created and the group of people it had hemmed up against the wall. Including his father who had been downstairs last he'd seen.

"What do you want?"

"Your ring? I thought we made that very clear. Or her earrings I suppose but I doubt you can give me them from up here."

"I'm not giving either of them to you!"

"Is that so?"

The pink wash of Ladybug's magic swept over them and they both looked down.

"*Really?"* Mayura said, "That quickly?"

"Sure you can take both of us?"

Mayura held her hands up and headed over to her sentimonster, and then inexplicably she recalled her amok and it disappeared from existence.

Her plan became clear when she grabbed someone out of the crowd of frightened people and pulled them in front of her.

Of course it *had* to be his father because this was his life.

"Let me go now," She said, "Or I'll throw him off this edge."

Though there was some advantage to this entire mess, "Like I believe that. Didn't you save his son?"

"I've a soft spot for children." She said, and he wanted to scoff.

She climbed up onto the bannister balancing precariously and pulled his father up with her.

"Do you want to trust that I won't drop him?"

Her smile was slightly manic, and he *didn't* actually, despite whatever he thought was going on. After all if Mayura was a normal person with normal morals she wouldn't be working with *and kissing* Hawkmoth.

"OK, you can go."

She jumped back onto the landing and a breath Adrien hadn't know he was holding released itself.

Until Mayura dragged his father out the window she'd chosen as her escape with her. That really *hadn't* been what he was going for.

Unfortunately Mayura might be evil but she wasn't stupid. It did put him off following her when there were plenty of other things she could throw his father off.

“I can’t believe she kidnapped him to his own home.” Ladybug said, as they watched his father and Mayura through the Atelier window.

“Maybe she didn’t want to lead us to hers?” He suggested, “We don’t know where she and Hawkmoth are based? And I guess she just wanted to get away.”

He’d have been more concerned if it wasn’t for the fact that his father certainly didn’t *look* frightened, even though she was in the process of tying him to Nathalie’s chair.

“Why not just dump him and go?” Ladybug said.

“Who knows?” said Adrien, “Maybe she’s worried he’d trap her inside with the security systems.”

“Shouldn’t that keep people out? Not trap them in?”

“It works both ways.” He admitted ruefully.

His father looked down at something and his glasses slipped down his nose but Mayura carefully slid them back up his face, and the two of the locked eyes in what Adrien could only describe as having a moment.

This might actually be worse than watching Hawkmoth and Mayura kissing had been.

“I don’t think he was actually in danger.” Ladybug said.

“I’m starting to agree with you.”

“Can we get in without using the door?” Ladybug said.

“Adrien’s window’s usually open.” He told her. “He should still be at the party.”

“Of course it is.” Ladybug muttered, “You and I are having words after this. Let’s go.”

“OK?”

“Why are we?” He started once Ladybug climbed in his window but she held up a finger to her lips.

“I want to talk to her.” Ladybug said.

“Hello Mayura.” Ladybug said, as she opened the Atelier door.

The supervillain jumped, “Stay away I’ll,”

“You don’t have to act in front of us.” Ladybug said, “We can keep your secret if you’re not ready for Hawkmoth to know about the two of you, though you know we’re *definitely* not going to try and rescue M.Agreste from you in the future.”

Mayura and his father looked between them betraying that they clearly weren’t just kidnapper and hostage. Especially as it almost looked like *she* was waiting for *him* to speak.

“It’s not like that.” Mayura said eventually.

“What is it then?” He asked.

“It’s” Mayura sighed, “Complicated.”

“Right.” He said, “Because you’re still in love with Hawkmoth?”

Mayura face didn’t move, but her hands clenched into fists, “I,”

“She doesn’t have to answer that.” His father said, from his seat, and that seemed to remind Mayura of the situation and she went to untie him. She focused on the knots and deliberately didn’t look at Ladybug or Chat Noir and it seemed fairly clear she wasn’t going to offer any answer.

“Ok, ok,” He said, “I’m not trying to ruffle any feathers here. I just think you need to work that out before you do anything more with him.”

“I don’t think Hawkmoth’s just going to stop sending out akumas while I try and sort all this out.” Mayura said, and the causticness of words made Adrien think that maybe Ladybug *did* have a point after all and whatever *did* tie her to Hawkmoth it would actually be possible to detach them.

“Maybe he should.” His father said as he stood up once she’d freed him. “I mean, maybe you should ask him to.”

Mayura stared at his father, and her quiet “What?” would have been almost inaudible if it wasn’t for the enhanced hearing he had as Chat Noir.

“Why do you help him?” Ladybug said.

“What?” Mayura said, this time at a normal volume.

“Hawkmoth. What do you see in him? This whole thing, it’s *his* goals isn’t it. Not yours.”

“I can’t tell you what we’re doing this for.”

“It’s something pretty bad then?” He asked. It was easy to get distracted by everything going on between his father and Mayura, and Hawkmoth and Mayura and forget that she was trying

to take over the world or something.

“It’s not a bad thing.” She said, “Whatever you’re thinking is probably wrong, but it’s not my secret to tell.”

“It’s something personal to Hawkmoth then.” Ladybug mused.

“I’ve said too much.” Mayura said with her panic clear on her face, and if it was anyone else he’d have tried to reassure her but in the circumstances he wasn’t really should that was the thing to do.

He was saved by having to do anything when his father took a step closer to her, and put his arm around her. Apparently unaware of Chat Noir’s hearing abilities he used the moment of his face being turned about from Ladybug and Chat Noir to whisper to her, “It’s ok. You’re doing well.”

Looking between them he suddenly wondered if *his father* knew what Hawkmoth’s goals were. If Mayura had confessed them to him, and if so what it meant about him that he’d kept her secret.

“What’s in it for you then?” He asked, wanting some reassurance that if Mayura *was* going to be part of his life then maybe she wasn’t that bad a person.

She seemed to look past him, “I want to give him what he wants. I want to, fix things. Make them right.”

“Oh, you really are in love with him aren’t you?” Ladybug said sadly.

“It’s not like that.” Mayura said for the second time that evening and it didn’t sound any more convincing than it had earlier, “What we’re trying to fix, it’s my fault.”

“What?” His father said looking down at her, “No it’s not.”

He *definitely* knew what was going on.

“Part of it is. You know that.” She said, and shook her head when it looked like he was about to speak, before turning to look back at them, “And, you two you don’t know what he was like before.”

“What you’re going to tell us Hawkmoth used to be a really nice person?” Adrien scoffed. There was only so much he was willing to believe.

*“*He *was,* or no nice isn’t the word I suppose, but if you saw him with the people he cared about you’d understand. He’s *dedicated* in a way people claim to be but I’ve never seen before, and he’s creative, and he just has these ideas, and he can tell you the most ridiculous things and make them sound possible because they *are* possible for him, he’s just able to achieve whatever he puts his mind to and it’s exhilarating being caught up in that. Or it was. Before.”

His father was looking at her oddly and he couldn't blame him.  It couldn't be easy hearing someone you liked talk like that about someone else. Which he realised, he'd kind of done to Marinette, and this wasn't the time to be thinking about that but it was really bad.

"Before he kept failing at getting our Miraculouses?"

"There's that." Mayura smiled "But it's not just that."

Ladybug shifted awkwardly. "You know if you want to stop we'll protect you."

"I can't." Mayura said, "I have to keep going."

"Just think about it ok?" Ladybug said.

"You're letting me go?" Mayura asked.

"For tonight." Ladybug confirmed.

She didn't look like she believed them but she edged out the Atelier door anyway past them anyway.

"Would you really?" His father asked.

"Really what?" Ladybug replied.

"Protect her? Forgive her for everything?"

"We're not liars. We'll do what we said we'll do" Adrien said, "Though I *do* question your taste."

"You couldn't understand." His father said, "You don't know anything about what she's really like."

"Tell me then," He said desperate to understand the attraction past the physical and guessing Chat Noir might have more of a chance of an answer than Adrien did.

"Chat Noir," Ladybug started.

"She's the most loyal and caring person I've ever met."

Adrien wasn't really seeing it.

His father must have felt he wasn't convincing them because he said, "She'd do anything for him, and he doesn't deserve it at all."

"*That* I can believe," He said.

"Come on," said Ladybug, "Let's go."

His father followed them out into the hall turning off the lights behind them.

Of Mayura there was no sign, but he literally almost walked into Nathalie on sitting on the floor. “Na-Mlle. Sancoeur are you alright? Did Mayura do something?”

“Mayura?” She asked, “No I was just looking for M.Agreste.”

“On the *floor?”*

“Dizzy spell.” She smiled weakly, “It seemed safer to sit down than fall down.”

“Do you need help?”

“I’ll handle it.” His father said, and shooed them out the door.

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He waited for Ladybug to speak once they got outside. “I have to get home before I’m missed,” She said, “But I *do* need to speak to you. About this *and* about whatever you said to Adrien when I asked you not to.”

“I didn’t exactly,” he started.

“I don’t have time now,” Ladybug said, “Meet me on the Arc de Triomphe tomorrow night at 11?”

“I can do that.”

# Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Thankfully neither Nathalie nor his father seemed to spot anything odd in how long it had taken him to get back from the party, and the Gorilla had promised not to mention that he'd had to wait for Adrien to reappear there.

What the Gorilla actually *thought* Adrien was up to he wasn't really sure but so long as he didn't seem to suspect he was Chat Noir *and* he kept covering for him then he was more than happy to go along with it.

The next day for one of the first times ever he was actually glad his father didn't seem likely to spend any time with him for non-Chat Noir related reasons.

Though this technically *was* a Chat Noir related reason in a way.

And really his father *should* have tell him if he was, actually Adrien didn't know exactly what his father was doing with Mayura except for the fact that it apparently included staring into each other's eyes, him defending her, and her confiding in him, and at least half-hugging and probably more.

Which, that had to be some sort of romantic relationship didn't it?

Especially with how little his father sought out physical contact from *anyone* except Adrien, his mother, and sometimes Nathalie.

Though honestly Adrien could have done with a heads up even if his father was just somehow friends with Mayura.

Which still didn't make any sense, because it didn't explain how or why he had met her. He'd considered that maybe she'd sought him out after the incident with the Collector. She could have been looking for an alternative to Hawkmoth with how conflicted she'd sounded about him.

But that didn't seem right to Adrien. Somehow, *impossibly*, last night their connection had seemed like something longstanding. Not in its current form maybe because whatever happening now definitely hadn't been happening before. His father's shock when at hearing about his antics when he was akumatised *had* been real. That *could* has been when *this* started. He could have known her though and that would have explained the awkwardness of that first conversation about her.

All the reasons he'd brought up to Ladybug for why there couldn't be anything between them still stood though.

Really though what it showed was that he just didn't know his father very well at all, because he'd not had any idea that any of this was going on. That his father was close to *anyone* outside this house.

He couldn't imagine his mother could approve. Nathalie certainly didn't seem to.

Personally he didn't really know what he felt about it.

Mayura was a bad person. That much was inconvertible. Hawkmoth might have been all she made him out to be but she should have found a way to help him that didn't include encouraging him in his supervillainy.

She'd saved him though. He trusted Ladybug would have won and brought his face back anyway, but that didn't make what she'd done meaningless. It fitted with the description his father had given, the description she'd almost unwittingly given of herself, as someone who cared for people very deeply and would do anything for those people.

And apparently *he* was one of them, even though he'd never met her as Adrien before last night.

He didn't know how he felt about that either.

So really it was best that he didn't have to look his father in the eye until he'd sorted out how he felt about all of this.

Especially as his father didn't know that Adrien knew about any of this.

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"Look, I told you should have just kissed her."

"And I told you that wasn't helpful." He'd needed to talk to someone about what Ladybug had said, and what had happened with Marinette but Plagg *really* wasn't the best confidante on this subject. "How could I look Ladybug in the eyes after doing *that.* I can't go around kissing both girls."

"You could."

"*Plagg."* Adrien implored him wishing that his kwami wasn't his only option. He started trying to text Nino but it was impossible to write anything and not betray he was Chat Noir.

Plagg took a bite of cheese and chewed it unrepentantly, rather than trying to defend himself.

"I don't know if this is just a difference between humans and Kwami's," Adrien said, "Or if you just had some really terrible former holders but you just can't do that."

"Why not?"

“Why not? You just can't. That would be a horrible thing to do. They'd both be furious with me if they found out and they’d be right to be.”

“Ladybug’s already furious with you anyway.”

“Exactly!”

He needed to talk to someone else. Someone *human.* Someone who knew about secret identities, and how they made dating much harder. Someone who’d dealt with that.

He needed, he realised, to talk to *Mayura.*

If she was going to be part of this family then he had every right to ask her.

Only he had no idea where she was.

His father though, he just might.

He almost walked out the door to find him before he remembered that *Adrien* didn't know about his father and Mayura, and *Adrien* couldn't have this conversation.

He transformed into Chat Noir and jumped out the window to climb round the house to find another to climb in instead.

---

The only flaw in his plan was that to ask his father where Mayura was he actually had to find where his father was which turned out to be easier said than done.

First he tried the Atelier because that seemed the obvious place, but he wasn’t there, or in the living room, or in the dining room.

He didn’t *really* want to look in any of the upstairs rooms but given that he’d already transformed and started looking it seemed silly to give up now.

He did knock on the windows on his parents’ bedroom before he looked in. That really wasn’t how he’d want to discover what Mayura looked like de-transformed. There wasn’t any response to his knock though and when he managed to get up the courage to look inside the room was dark and empty.

He hadn’t really been in there since his mother disappeared and what struck him was how very unchanged it was, with her perfumes and make-up still sprawling across her dressing table as if she’d only just put then down.

It had always surprised him how messy that counter looked with the preference for minimalism and the drive to present a certain appearance to the world that both his parents shared but he’d always thought it brought some life to that room. Now though it seemed to do

the opposite sucking energy in like a shrine, and he almost hoped that this thing with Mayura *would* work out and his father could move on.

Giving up he considered his options. It felt unfair to bother Nathalie when she wasn't working, especially because if she was in her room here and not in her own apartment it must have been because she still wasn't feeling well after her dizzy spell last night.

He felt guilty for not checking on her earlier but she always seemed very awkward when he tried to make sure she was feeling ok when she was sick.

Adrien had always enjoyed being fussed over when he was ill, and it was one of the things he missed about his mother, because his father certainly didn't go in for that being too concerned about getting ill himself, but it was possible that maybe Nathalie didn't share his feelings and honestly did dislike people seeing her when she was ill.

Though oddly she *did* try sometimes to do what his mother had done for him when he wasn't well, though it was difficult with the demands his father made on her time, and she always seemed unsure about what to do, or maybe what she should do. That was one of the things that had made him so willing to see what he'd thought were the signs of his father's interest in *her*, because maybe then she'd feel more confident to do more.

Except that wasn't happening because, and he was still trying to process this, somehow his father *seemed* to have chosen Mayura of out of everyone in Paris.

Mayura who he was trying to find right now.

So he climbed over to Nathalie's window, and after having looked everywhere finally found his father, sitting on her bed. Nathalie herself looked to be asleep, and now Adrien really did feel guilty for not checking in on her earlier because if *his father* was watching her sleep to confirm she was ok then she really must be not well.

He knocked at the window, and his father looked up and opened it letting him in.

"I'm sorry to disturb you M.Agreste," he started.

"It's fine," his father dismissed him, "You didn't disturb much as *someone* is pretending to be asleep rather than talking to me."

"Um," he said dumbly, "Are you sure she's pretending?"

She looked pretty asleep to him, and he couldn't imagine *Nathalie* refusing to talk to his father. Even when they'd been avoiding each other after he got akumatised she'd never have ignored a direct word.

"Yes." His father said, "What do you want anyway? Where's your partner?"

"She's not here. I'm," he hesitated feeling kind of silly, "looking for Mayura actually. I thought you might know where she is?"

There was a slight stutter in the rhythm of Nathalie's breathing and he wondered if his father was right about her faking sleep, even if he couldn't understand why because what on earth could she be so certain she didn't want to discuss?

Except of course for his father's relationship with the very women he was looking for. That made things awkward.

"I'm not betraying her." His father said, "And she's not going to betray Hawkmoth. If you want their Miraculous then I can't help you."

"It's not about *that*, it's um, personal."

"Personal? What sort of personal business can you have with Mayura."

Even with the aura of confidence bestowed on him by being Chat Noir he couldn't stop his hand going to the back of his neck sheepishly.

"I, uh, she's dating you right?"

"We're not dating."

Adrien ignored this. "OK, but I mean she was with Hawkmoth before right?"

"No."

"But, last night what she said, she's in love with him isn't she? And that kiss, *it* seemed pretty passionate."

Even if it had had all that strangeness of both of them claiming it wasn't real.

His father pinched the bridge of his nose in a familiar gesture of exasperation, "That doesn't mean, why do you care so much anyway?"

"So it turns out being a superhero actually really complicates your love life? I thought Mayura might understand the whole identity thing and the being torn between two people thing."

"Being torn between two people?"

"You and Hawkmoth."

"Ah. That." His father sighed, "Come on, let's leave Nathalie alone."

Adrien followed him downstairs, "Are you taking me to Mayura?"

"She's busy at the moment." His father said as he opened the door to the living room.

"So, um what are you doing then?"

His father sat down and motioned for him to do the same, "I suppose," he said unable to keep how distasteful the idea was off his face, "I could speak to you about these…romantic issues

of yours."

*"You?"*

"You could try and sound less shocked, but yes, I have a son who's having issues of his own at the moment. I guess I could use the practice."

That was actually kind of sweet, and it was probably for the best his father never discovered that this wasn't actually a practice run.

"So," Adrien started, "I don't know if you know but,"

"I know you like Ladybug." His father cut in, "I'm fairly certain the entire world does."

"Right. So, the other day I discovered that she likes who I am behind the mask."

"That would seem to make things very simple."

"Except because of Hawkmoth I can't actually tell her that's me. And she says she can only date that me as *her* civilian self, and I don't know who that is!"

"I see."

"And I encouraged her to pursue me, but then one of my school-friends and I got in this weird situation, and that made me realise I liked *her,* but I told her it was better we stayed as friends because I'm still in love with Ladybug, and I think I've ruined things with her now, and now Ladybug's mad at me and I don't know what to do."

"When you say a weird situation do you mean you almost kissed her?"

"Yes?"

His father stared at him, "and, please let the answer to this be no, but would you describe Ladybug as the love of your life?"

"Yes?"

"Adrien." His father said flatly.

"What about him?" He tried to deflect it.

It didn't work. "Adrien Alexander Anselm Augustin Athanase Agreste detransform this instant."

"I'm not Adrien." He tried again. Ladybug really *was* going to kill him.

"I really think you are." He father slumped back against the couch, "I'm officially an idiot."

"Um," Adrien said completely at a loss at how to deal with this. He'd expected permanent house arrest, or his father to take his ring, or or some sort of punishment. Not *this*.

“How on earth didn’t I see this?” His father said, “How did we never catch you on the security cameras? My god, I considered it. I saw the *ring,* but I let myself be convinced otherwise when I saw,” he shut his eyes for a moment and shook his head, “someone dressed as you whose face I never saw. I urgh,”

He stood up and went to the door, and yelled “Nathalie, get here now.”

“It’s not her fault”

His father turned to look at him. “What?”

“It’s not her fault you didn’t know.”

“I didn’t think it was,” He stuck his head out the door, “*Nathalie.”*

Just then, his staff went, and he fumbled it open to see a message from Ladybug.

“I have to go,” He said edging towards the windows, “There’s an akuma.”

“What? No there can’t be.” His father said and went to re-arrange his cravat in some sort of nervous tic, “There can’t be,” he said again sounded more certain.

“There’s *something.”* Adrien said, “I have to go.”

His father looked at him, and Adrien waited for the refusal to let him leave the house that he was expecting but all that happened was that his father’s eyes widened and so quiet he wouldn’t have heard it if he wasn’t transformed uttered, “Nathalie.”

Then he almost shocked Adrien to the roots of his soul when he said, “Go on then.”

---

Adrien was still reeling from how much better his father finding out his identity had gone than he ever could have imagined, when he got to the fight.

“Don’t let yourself get caught in the cloud,” Ladybug said out of breath, “It freezes everything it touches and I mean *everything.*”

Watching the trial of icy devastation including human figures frozen in place with icicles dripping off them he could well believe it.

“That’s a sentimonster isn’t it,” he said remembering his father’s words, “Where’s the akuma?”

“Apparently Mayura’s going it alone.” She said

“But last night, I thought,” he trailed off feeling unjustifiably betrayed. He’d *known* Mayura was a villain. He should never have started thinking that maybe he and her could be part of a happy family together.

Ladybug scowled, “We made a mistake apparently.”

---

“*Why are you doing this?”* He screeched at Mayura when she got between him and his attempt to pull Ladybug to safety, from where she’d got pinned in place, as the cloud approached.

“You couldn’t possibly understand,” Mayura said, “I *can’t* give up.”

“Yes, you can.” He implored her, “You’ve a real chance of being part of a family, and you’re throwing it away for *what?*”

“I don’t” She said, “I really don’t and that’s why I have to do this.”

Ladybug must have seen some other way out because she threw her yo-yo straight up, and then was pulled up by its string moments later.

His eyes followed her up and “*Hawkmoth?”*

That made Mayura look up too. Strangely she didn’t look happy to see her partner-in-crime.

Though maybe that made sense because Hawkmoth didn’t seem to be fighting Ladybug. In fact it looked like *he’d* been the one to pull her to safety.

Adrien took advantage of her momentary confusion to pull away, but that brought Mayura’s attention back to him and she advanced again.

Hawkmoth jumped down behind her, “You have to stop this.”

She didn’t look away from him, but they all knew who she was replying to when she said “Why would you ask me that? I’m doing it *for you.*”

“Maybe I don’t want you to,” Hawkmoth said even as she managed to pull Adrien’s staff out of his hands, “Mayura *stop.”*

He grabbed her from behind and pulled her back away from Adrien, but once her first burst of shock was over she started to struggle against him, “I don’t care that you know about my feelings now,” she said.

“Well I do. *This* is why I wanted to talk about things.”

She kept fighting him, “I don’t care what you think you want, you don’t really want that, and I’m not betraying her.”

“*How would you know what I want when you refuse to talk about it*?” He managed to trip her over, but she pulled him with her so they both fell to the ground.

A hand on his shoulder startled him, but it was only Ladybug. “Should we do something?”

Adrien consider the two villains still struggling with each other on the ground, “I think they’re handling each other.”

“I am so confused.”

“Me too.”

“I thought Hawkmoth was the one in charge, and Mayura was the one we might be able to convince to join us.”

“Me too.”

Hawmoth managed to pin Mayura down, “You’re stopping this right now, and we’re going home.”

“Give me one good reason why.”

Then Hawkmoth shattered his world by saying, “Chat Noir’s Adrien.”

Ladybug squeaked.

Mayura’s head snapped towards, him and her voice wavered as she said, “Our Adrien?”

Hawkmoth's expression seemed to soften, “Yes.”

Suddenly she started to struggle against Hawkmoth again, “No, no no you said he wasn’t, he couldn’t be.”

“He is.” Hawkmoth said, “Ask him.”

Mayura stilled and looked at him and Ladybug, “Adrien?”

“Afraid so.” He said as he took a chance and dropped his transformation. With his father having told Hawkmoth there seemed little point in denying it anymore, and Mayura *had* defended him before, and they weren’t any closer to defeating this sentimonster than they’d been at the beginning.

It worked. The freezing cloud shimmered out of existence as Mayura revoked her amok.

“Get off me.” She said to Hawkmoth, “I need to think. Alone”

“Mayura,” he sighed as he stood up, but she didn’t wait for him to finish and ran off.

Hawkmoth looked back at Adrien and Ladybug and then ran after her.

“You’re Adrien Agreste.” Ladybug said. “Chat Noir is Adrien Agreste, Adrien Agreste is Chat Noir.”

“Uh, yes?”

“You didn’t *say* anything to Adrien. You knew I liked you because you *are* Adrien.”

“Yes?”

Ladybug’s eyes suddenly widened, “You told me to date you as a civilian when I didn’t know who you were and you knew that!”

He had to work to follow that but, “Yes?”

“You!” She pointed to him, “You’re not as nice as person as I thought you were! I never thought Adrien Agreste would do something like that.”

“What was I supposed to do?” He said, “Tell you *not* to date me? You know you’re the only lady for me.”

He felt bad the moment he said it when he remembered Marinette, but he’d *chosen* Ladybug over Marinette. That had to count for something.

Ladybug just started laughing.

“What’s so funny?” He said, hands on his hips.

“Oh kitty. Trust me. You’d get it if you knew the truth.”

“What truth?”

She stared into her eyes, and he was momentarily distracted by how she had very pretty eyes. Just as pretty as Marinette’s actually.

“Sorry?” He said when he realised she was talking.

“You really need to learn to pay attention,” she said but there was an amused fondness there, then her voice turned sterner, “I said you made it *very* clear that you weren’t interested in me Adrien, so I think we should both accept we’re just going to be friends.”

“What?” He croaked, “When?”

He’d never have rejected Ladybug, *he wouldn’t,* they had a connection, he knew he’d like whoever she was behind the mask and besides the only person he could be considered to have rejected was-was someone who reminded him of Ladybug, and had identically pretty bluebell eyes, and wore her hair in bunches too, *and* had been disappointed with him just before Ladybug had messaged him to ask what he’d said to Adrien, and, “*Marinette?”*

It came out embarrassingly like a yelp.

Ladybug froze and grinned fakely, “What a silly idea.”

“*Please* be Marinette.” He implored her.

“You *want* me to be Marinette?” She asked, and *that,* that sounded like she could want a yes.

“Of course I want you to be Marinette. Do you know how conflicted I’ve felt when I realised I liked her but I still liked Ladybug? And *worse* I liked her for a lot of the same reasons I liked Ladybug, and how could I know if I liked her for *her* or just because she reminded me of Ladybug? You being Marinette would be the best thing that could ever happen to me.”

Ladybug stared at him with her eyes wide. “I need to talk to my Kwami.”

Then she ran around the corner leaving Adrien stood lost by himself.

Or almost by himself, the laughter of his kwami reminded him.

“Nice one kid.” Plagg said, “Got any cheese?”

Adrien dug some gruyere out of his pocket, and Plagg sniffed at it in distaste but started chewing on it anyway.

“I can’t tell if you were being sarcastic.” He said.

Plagg looked up from his cheese, “You’re a suspicious kitten aren’t you?”

“I feel like I should have been more suspicious honestly.” He said.

“That feels like it would be tiring though,” his kwami said, “and your life is tiring enough.”

“Yeah, maybe.”

“Look it’ll be fine.”

“You think?”

“Trust me. Hey, everything else has gone way better than I expected today.”

“Yeah, me too actually.” Adrien still wasn’t sure exactly what had happened earlier but his dad had let him out after discovering he was Chat Noir, and Mayura had stopped fighting him after discovering the same, and both of those *had* to be good things.

That in itself made him feel uneasy. Like he was still waiting for the other shoe to drop.

Then Marinette reappeared around the side of the building with the little red Kwami he’d briefly meet when they’d ended up with each other’s Miraculous in the confusion fighting Refleka.

“Marinette,” he breathed out.

“Hi Adrien.” She said.

He ran to her and swept her into a hug, “I’m so glad it’s you.”

“Me too!” She said.

“Oh my god.”

“What?”

“I rejected you, for you, *twice.*”

“I rejected you for you as well!” She said, “I can’t believe it!”

“Told you we should have told them.” Plagg said.

“You know why they couldn’t.” Tikki pointed out.

“Yeah, well, Hawkmoth finding out turned out to not be a disaster.”

“Hawkmoth finding out about *Adrien.* We have no idea what he might do if he discovered Marinette.” She floated over to him, “You can’t let him know Adrien.”

“I won’t” He promised, “I’ll do whatever’s necessary to keep Marinette safe.”

Marinette looked up at him scrunching her nose cutely, “I don’t want you to do that.”

“What do you mean?”

“Don’t tell Hawkmoth my identity obviously, but don’t sacrifice yourself for me. It’s hard enough watching you do that when you were just Chat Noir. I couldn’t bear it if you did it now I know you’re Adrien too.”

“It’s be ok. Bugaboo,” He reassured her realising her slightly so he could see her face better, “I’m not going to leave my girlfriend alone.”

Marinette blushed, “Am I your girlfriend now?”

“Uh, I hope so? If you don’t mind?”

“I don’t mind. I’d *love* to be your girlfriend” She said, “Though I am still cross at you for the other day.”

“I’m very good at grovelling” he told her.

“Well, in that case,” She rose up on her tip toes and kissed him and he completely forgot about the rest of the world for a little bit.

Chapter End Notes

Guys, I am only like halfway through the identity reveals and I'm exhausted. Why did I think this was a good idea.

# Chapter 7

Adrien still felt on cloud nine as he and Marinette walked down the street hand in hand. Ladybug was Marinette, and *she'd* agreed to be his girlfriend. Next to that he was almost able to forgive Mayura for what happened earlier, given she *had* given up on discovering it was him. Right now he felt like *everyone* he knew deserved their happily ever after including his father and Mayura. He was even willing to be forgiving of Hawkmoth seeing as he'd saved Ladybug earlier.

The two of them paused at the sounds coming from the alley between some houses. He wasn't sure if that was someone choking or retching or what exactly but it did *not* sound good.

"Come on," Marinette said, "We should see if someone needs help."

He nodded and they ran up into the alley, only for Adrien to come to a sudden stop almost causing Marinette to trip over when he saw what was happening.

Nathalie was sat on the ground making the worst hacking coughs that he'd ever heard since his mother's illness, and he only had a moment to process of the incongruity of her *here,* inexplicably out on the streets when he'd left her in bed, and sitting on a footpath like that didn't clash with the disgust for germs she'd had as long as he'd known her, and to worry for her because those coughs did not sound good at all, before all of that was superseded by his shock at the person next to her.

For kneeling down next to Nathalie, and supporting her, and telling her it was all going to be ok was *Hawkmoth.*

For once Adrien honestly did not know what to do.

Hawkmoth might helped them in that last fight with Mayura for reasons known only to himself, and apparently his father trusted him enough to tell him Adrien was Chat Noir for reasons only known to *him*, but that didn't mean he automatically trusted Hawkmoth now.

In fact if he'd been *told* about the situation then he still would have immediately said that he'd run in and confront Hawkmoth and rescue Nathalie, but he couldn't deny that the scene he was *seeing* didn't really look like Hawkmoth was a threat to Nathalie at all.

Nathalie certainly seemed totally unbothered by the fact that the arm around her belonged to the supervillain who'd been terrorising Paris.

Admittedly with how much she was coughing maybe she was just concentrating on *breathing* and thought it pointless to worry about that when she wasn't able to do anything about it.

That idea was soon proven wrong when her coughing fit came to an end and Hawkmoth took the chance to pull her up to her feet. Rather than fighting this she let him do it, and once they

were up even reached over his shoulder with her own arm so they were essentially standing in a sort of embrace with her face lying against his upper chest.

Hawkmoth then either pressed a kiss into the top of her head or whispered something into her hair, and still Nathalie didn't react.

Though she did seem a little out of it honestly. At some point standing up her eyes had fluttered shut, and honestly standing up seemed a bit of a misnomer for what she'd done, which was more like falling into Hawkmoth's arms.

Even more he could see the Supervillain was pretty much taking all her weight at the moment. That she could stand upright on her own accord seemed dubious.

"Have you *drugged* her?"

Marinette squeezed his hand seemingly as lost at what was going on as he was.

Hawkmoth's head snapped around to look at him and *maybe* that hadn't been his best plan. Though then again, it wasn't as if *he* couldn't transform. After all Hawkmoth knew who he was. He should have let Marinette run out of sight so *she* could though before he'd called their enemy's attention to them.

"Adrien." Hawkmoth said flatly and something in the irritation in his bass tone was familiar and *not* from fighting him.

"Have *you*?"

"What would it matter to you if I had?"

"Because she's," my father's assistant, but while Adrien had never thought much about their relationship before that sounded weak for someone he saw more of than his father, "basically part of my family."

Based off the events earlier today it seemed like that might actually matter to Hawkmoth.

He thought Hawkmoth's eyes widened in surprise but because before he could speak, Nathalie asked "Adrien?"

Her eyes opened but she didn't seem to focus on him.

She mumbled something but Adrien couldn't make it out.

Hawkmoth's response of "No, we're not back yet. I'll handle it." He could just hear.

Nathalie seemed reassured by this because her eyes fluttered shut again, and she let her head fall back against Hawkmoth, and Adrien swore to god that she almost seemed to snuggle into him, and he wondered again if she somehow, impossibly, trusted him.

Then again that almost made a sort of sense. His father had been able to contact Hawkmoth so apparently his secret relationship with Mayura extended to more familiarity with

Hawkmoth too than Adrien and Marinette had realised, and if his father was caught up in something with the both of them, then of *course* Nathalie would be too.

Or. Perhaps his father *hadn't* told Hawkmoth. Perhaps he'd told *Nathalie* Adrien's identity and *she'd* told Hawkmoth?

"Be that as it may, this isn't any of your business." Hawkmoth said.

Marinette let go of his hand and stood up straight, "It is if you're hurting her."

"Sorry, who are you?"

"My girlfriend Marinette." Adrien put in, "But that doesn't matter, what matters is what you're doing to Nathalie."

"Your girlfriend? Since *when?*"

Adrien glared at Hawkmoth narrowing his eyes. He didn't think it was as successful usually as Adrien as it was as Chat Noir but it seemed to work on Hawkmoth.

The supervillain gave up on waiting for Adrien to answer, and answered him instead, "I haven't drugged her. She's not well. I'm getting her *help."*

"Right." Adrien snorted, "Because you're so well known for doing that, and you're doing that *now* are you?"

"I *was,* until you interfered. And I helped you and your," Hawkmoth trailed off uncertainly, "other little girlfriend earlier didn't I?"

He *had* but that still didn't make him feel comfortable with the situation. He looked over at Marinette expecting her to say something. He was so used to Ladybug taking the lead but now she seemed to be letting him make the decision.

"What are you doing?" He asked confused as to why Hawkmoth seemed to be trying to change his and Nathalie's positions.

"What does it look like?" Hawkmoth said looking pleased as he managed to completely pick Nathalie up.

"I can't let you take her."

Hawkmoth snorted, "I'd like to see you stop me." Then his tone softened, "It's alright Adrien, she's not in any danger from me, I'll return her quite unharmed."

Adrien still felt unconvinced. Nathalie *seemed* happy to go with Hawkmoth, but he still wasn't actually sure she knew who she was with.

"Why take her then, are you going to try to ransom her from Ladybug and me?"

Hawkmoth looked down at Nathalie, looking almost fond, “Now that *is* an idea, but no. Not this time.”

“*Then why?”*

“Your father seems set on taking Mayura from me, why shouldn’t I do the same?”

“That’s not really, he and Nathalie aren’t together, I don’t think it’s fair to punish her for what he’s doing.”

“No, she shouldn’t have to suffer for that.” The villain agreed, “Don’t worry, I can promise you on whatever you want that I won’t hurt her.”

Adrien was still unsure what to say. He didn’t want to attack and make Hawkmoth drop Nathalie.

“Why not let Adrien take her then?” Marinette said. “We could get her the help she needs.”

Hawkmoth eyed Adrien dubiously and Adrien wanted to point out that as Chat Noir he was perfectly capable of carrying Nathalie. Even if the fact she was taller than him might make it a little different.

“Mlle. Sancoeur and I need to talk.” Hawkmoth said, as he backed away from them.

“About what happened earlier?” Adrien asked, still unsure.

“That’s part of it.”

The movement seemed to jolt Nathalie back to some awareness, “Adrien, it’s ok.”

He’d have felt significantly more reassured by that if he was sure she’d actually been awake for the earlier part of there earlier conservation.

Marinette put a hand on his arm and whispered, “I think we should let them go.”

“What?” Adrien asked, “It’s *Hawkmoth*. You can’t trust him.”

“I don’t. But I trust him with this much.”

Adrien looked back at Hawkmoth, “If you hurt her, or if you don’t return her I will hunt you down, and cataclysm you.”

Hawkmoth swallowed, “That’s fair.”

“Are you sure we should have done that?” Adrien asked Marinette. He knew everything seemed topsy-turvy these days but it didn’t seem very heroic to let Hawkmoth go off with someone.

“Honestly? I’m not sure.”

Adrien stopped. He trusted her, he’d trusted his life to her plenty of times, but surely she couldn’t have just said that. “Why did you say to let him go then?”

Marinette blushed, “Didn’t it sort of look to you like they were a couple?”

Adrien blinked as the entire scene replayed in front of his eyes in a different light, how comfortable Nathalie had been with Hawkmoth’s hands on her body, that snuggling into him, his concern over her, those fond looks. Even that joking comment about taking Nathalie in recompense for Mayura.

“Oh my god.” He said, “They kind of did.”

“Are you ok?”

“I just, my father and Mayura together was bad enough. Now there’s Hawkmoth and Nathalie *too*? Why is my home life *like* this?”

“I’m really sorry Adrien.”

“Do you space for me to move in?”

“I’m sure my parents would find some! Actually, um, did you want to go back there now? We could steal something from the bakery if you were hungry?”

Adrien *was* hungry, and he didn’t want to part from Marinette but, “No, I think I have to go home. I should tell my father what happened, and hopefully *he’ll* know whether we just made a terrible mistake.”

---

His father not being in the Atelier was starting to feel like something of a trend which was weird because for most of his life, even when his mother had been around, that was the mostly likely place to find him if he was in the house.

Honestly he couldn’t help but feel a little annoyed. His father *knew* he’d gone off to fight an akuma, and unless it had been Nathalie who had told Hawkmoth Adrien’s identity he knew that he’d sent Hawkmoth after Adrien too, so he’d expected him to be waiting for him.

Unless he was looking for Nathalie which would make a kind of sense because frankly he should have known that she’d inexplicably left the house. He might have missed Adrien’s escapes but it wasn’t as if Nathalie could climb out on of the windows.

When he left the dining room after ascertaining he wasn't there either and crossed back into the hall he found his father coming out of the Atelier after all. They must have somehow missed each other in passing earlier.

His father stopped and nodded in acknowledgement. "Adrien. It all went alright then?"

"Apart from Hawkmoth kidnapping Nathalie!" He said hoping to provoke some sort of response from the man who had probably sent Hawkmoth out there in the first place.

"*Did* he?" His father said sounded more intrigued than bothered at all by the idea, and Adrien struggled to reconcile this non-reaction with the man who'd seemed so worried about Nathalie throughout all her recent bouts of
illness.

"Aren't you even *concerned?*" Adrien said, "This is *all* your fault. If you didn't decided for some reason, that you had to seduce Mayura of all people then,"

"*Seduce?"* He spluttered. *"*Adrien Agreste I will *not* have you speak to me like that. I knew letting you go to school was a mistake. Look at all these ideas it's put into your head. *Seduce.* I didn't seduce Mayura, why would you even think that, what a ridiculous notion."

"What's going on with you two then?"

His father clamped his lips together.

"Don't I deserve to know that?" Adrien pointed out.

"It's none of your business."

"Isn't it?" Adrien said, and for some reason his father's reversion to pushing him away felt harder to deal with after the process he'd been making. "She and Hawkmoth know who *I* am now, and you seem to know what's going on, and I think Nathalie knows something at least, and I'm the only one in the dark and I don't even know for certain if I've been fighting my future stepmother or not."

"Adrien," his father sighed, "I can't explain everything to you right now but I *will* tell you. I promise. Mayura is…a friend, and Nathalie's going to be fine."

"Yeah, a friend, like Marinette was a friend."

"What?"

"Oh yeah, I have a girlfriend now."

"Wait. Which one?"

"Which *one?*"

"You told me you liked two girls. Twice. So which one? Ladybug or the school-friend?"

Adrien had introduced her to Hawkmoth as *Marinette,* and apparently his father spoke to Hawkmoth so he said, “The school-friend.”

“Oh.” His father said. “And you don’t regret it?”

“No.” He said because there was nothing else he could say without admitting the actual situation.

His father looked down at the floor, “Adrien, would you mind if I *was* to start a relationship with someone else?”

“With Mayura?”

“Not. Not necessarily.”

“I mean, apart from the whole supervillain thing, why on earth would I mind?”

“You wouldn’t feel, I don’t know, displaced?”

Adrien couldn’t help but raise an eyebrow, “Not really. I mean would you date someone who’d try and push me out?”

*Mayura* of all people had twice sacrificed a victory to keep him safe. Whatever deficiencies his father had when it came to picking potential partners he wasn’t particularly concerned that one of those flaws was picking people who wouldn’t care for him.

“And, you wouldn’t feel offended on your mother’s behalf?”

“No. I mean maybe if they were really terrible, but I don’t have a problem with the idea of you moving on. I’ve never had a problem with that. I want,”

“Me to be happy, yes you said that before.”

“And I meant it. Ask Nathalie. She can confirm that.”

“You’ve discussed the idea with her?”

He nodded. “After you got akumatised. She seemed to think you’d never consider the idea.”

“Did she?” His father said but he didn’t seem to expect an answer and looked towards the clock, “Are you all ready for school tomorrow?”

“I think so.”

“Right. Well. You should getting to bed.”

Adrien was tempted to argue. It wasn’t that late and he’d somehow got sidetracked from what he’d meant to ask about everything but his father clearly considered the conversation over and was heading upstairs himself.

“Father?” He called up after him.

He halted and turned, giving him the courage to ask. “Is Nathalie dating Hawkmoth?”

For a moment his father just stared at him. “I don’t believe so.”

“Is that the same way you’re not dating Mayura?” Adrien still had no idea how something *both* of them had ended up with his enemies but he guessed it made more sense if, as they seemed to, they all knew each other.

“Adrien. Just leave it.”

“How do you even know them?”

“I said leave it.” His father snapped, making him flinch back, “I’m sorry, I *will* explain but I can’t. Not yet.”

---

Adrien was almost in bed when his phone rang and he had to run across his room to where he’d left it.

He smiled when he saw the caller, “Hey Marinette!”

“Hi,”

His smile fell a little as he heard the awkwardness in her voice, “Is everything ok?”

“Not. Yes. Maybe?”

“Marinette?”

“It’s just, I was kind of distracted earlier but how did Hawkmoth know who you were? You’d have told me if you knew he’d discovered you right?”

Right *that.* “I’m pretty sure my father told him.”

“Your *father* knows? *How?* My parents don’t know and they actually,” She stopped herself.

“It’s ok. I know what you all think of him. Honestly it was kind of a fluke he worked it out at all, but I um, might have given it away a bit talking about you actually.”

“About *me?* Wait, about *Ladybug?*”

“No! I wouldn’t do that. It’s just I kind of freaked out about when I almost kissed you at school the other day?”

“You were almost going to kiss me? I mean I wanted to kiss you, but I didn’t think you were, *I am focusing on the important things Tikki.* Sorry Adrien, my kwami wants me to get back

on topic."

"Right so, I did that as Adrien? But then when I rejected you as Marinette I knew I'd messed up and after what happened with my father and Mayura the other night I thought *she* might be someone to speak to about it. Someone that knew about secret identities you know?"

"I love you but please do not go off talking to supervillains without me."

Adrien beamed, "You love me?"

Marinette made an inarticulate noise. "I didn't mean to say that! I mean not that I don't, obviously I really like you, but not in like some weird stalker way, like in a totally normal way to talk to your boyfriend of one day."

"Aw me too!" He reassured her.

"So, you didn't talk to Mayura?"

"No. My father said she was busy but *he'd* talk to me, and I was Chat Noir at that point but I couldn't really turn him down,"

"No I get that."

"And I didn't name any names or anything but he worked it out. And then Mayura attacked and I thought he'd ban me from leaving the house but he let me go, obviously because he was going to set Hawkmoth after her instead?"

"Right."

"Marinette?"

"Did he tell you that?"

"No? But it's clearly what happened?"

"You didn't ask?"

"I kind of got sidetracked?"

He could hear her sighing down the phone, and he made a mental note that he needed to do something *really* nice for her tomorrow.

"Ok, look we'll talk about it at school tomorrow."

"OK. See you then."

Nathalie didn't come to check on him the next morning. He chanced checking *her* room before he went downstairs but there was no reaction to his knock, and when he chanced pushing the door slightly there wasn't any yell to shut it either, so he chanced peering in.

He wasn't really surprised to see she wasn't there, but it *was* weird that her duvet and pillows were missing too. It's not like Hawkmoth would have taken her bedding. It must be off getting washed or something.

He chanced the Atelier too.

"Adrien?" His father looked up.

"Nathalie's not back then?"

"Ah. Not yet."

Something in that guilty refusing to meet his eyes made Adrien realise, "You're in contact with her aren't you? Or-with Hawkmoth? You *did* contact him pretty quickly yesterday."

"I have my ways." His father said.

"Are you going to tell me then?"

"I told you. You'll get an explanation when I'm ready."

"Right." Adrien didn't really feel reassured by that. He really couldn't fathom *how* or why his father and Nathalie had got entangled with Hawkmoth and Mayura in the first place. "But, she *is* alright? She doesn't need me to rescue her?"

"She doesn't need rescuing, no."

He couldn't find it in himself to leave it at that, "Are you *sure* they're not dating? It's just you seem weirdly ok with leaving her with Hawkmoth."

"You know she's not been well. If he can force her to take the rest she needs then I see no reason to meddle in the situation."

It shouldn't have been a surprise when his father had told Hawkmoth his identity but, "You really do trust him don't you?"

"As much as I trust myself."

He supposed that meant that he had to accept that Nathalie was ok, and that there wasn't any point pushing any further on that. It *did* make him feel a little better about the fact that Hawkmoth knew who he was.

"Can I trust him not to my Miraculous do you think? Only I know you were worried about me, *and* about Mayura when you told him who I was but it would be really dangerous for him to get it." Plagg had agreed to keep watch last night but Adrien knew that wasn't a workable long term solution.

This time his father *did* look uncertain. “I think you’re safe until Nathalie’s back at least.”

That was something he guessed, and aware of the time he changed topic, “So, uh, I was going to ask Gorilla if we could stop at a florists and get Marinette some flowers on the way to school, if that’s ok? I kind of owe her an apology.”

“That’s the girlfriend I presume?”

“Yes?” He wasn’t quite sure why that had come up sounding like a question. He was certain that she was, and of how important she was to him.

“That’s fine. He’ll know where we usually use I’m sure. Charge it to our account.”

---

“Woah, dude.” Nino said. “I can barely see you behind those.”

There was a minor possibility that *maybe* he should have picked a slightly smaller arrangement but Marinette deserved the *best.*

Adrien put them down on Marinette’s desk, and considered them again. They might slightly block people’s view a bit. Maybe he and Gorilla should have delivered them to her home instead. *Then* he could have given her a lift to school. That probably would have been a better idea.

“Do you think she’ll think it’s too much?” He asked.

“Wait-are *those* for Marinette? What when *that* happen?”

“Uh, yesterday?”

Alya learned forward toward them, “So you two are together then?”

“Yes.” He couldn’t stop beaming. “Finally.”

“Good.” She said, “I was about to have to throw them out the window if that was just an apology for rejecting her on Friday.”

“Yeah, that was bad.” Adrien said, “But I realised I was wrong, and now we’re dating.”

“So you and Marinette are together now?” Chloé asked having apparently come over to inspect the flowers, she made a production of inspecting her nails “I suppose there’s worse people you could have chosen.”

Lila paused by them, “Oh what a lovely bouquet Adrien how nice of you to,”

“They’re for Marinette” Chloé cut in, “She and Adrien are dating now isn’t that nice? I wonder if they’ll do a photoshoot together to announce it?”

“How nice.” Lila said, “You know I’ve always said they’d look great together haven’t I?”

Chloé rolled her eyes. Adrien was tempted to too, but Lila *was* trying to be nice.

“Yeah, I’m sure.” Chloé said.

---

How Marinette’s eyes became impossibly wider when she saw them made it all worthwhile. “These are for me?”

“I said I was good at grovelling.”

---

“Hey so, did any of you see anything of that last akuma attack?” Alya asked sending a shock of panic through Adrien as he realised he’d detransformed in public.

Marinette had gone pale clearly thinking the same thing.

Thankully Alya didn’t seem to notice even of their reactions, “I was trying to film it but I got stuck the wrong side of that cloud. It almost looked like Hawkmoth wasn’t fighting the heroes though? He and Ladybug seemed cordial on that roof?”

“Huh.” Adrien said, as he calmed down and realised that had he been caught on camera as Chat Noir it would have been headline news, and no one had said anything so they must have got away with it, “Weird.”

---

Adrien’s phone buzzed, and it was with some relief that he saw he had a text from Nathalie.

‘Just wanted to confirm I’m ok.’

He typed back immediately, ‘Are you back?’

‘Not yet.’

‘But he’s treating you right?’

‘Yes.”

He wondered, ‘are you two together?’

‘No.’

It was unfortunately impossible to tell if someone was lying in a text. She sounded like herself at least. It was possible that Hawkmoth was impersonating her but after everything that had happened it seemed more likely that this *was* Nathalie.

---

In the scheme of things going on with his father the fact that he didn’t even seem bothered by the idea of  Adrien taking Marinette out to a restaurant as part of his promised apology ranked pretty low, but that didn’t stop it being odd.  It was almost as if he was happy for Adrien to be out of the house.

The expected barrage of questions about he being Chat Noir, and how that had happened didn’t come either. That made a bit more sense considering how little his father seemed to want to talk about the Miraculous at all.

---

One of the many many advantages of dating Marinette meant no one thought it was odd when they snuck off together to discuss things.

She didn’t seem to have any better ideas of what was going on than he did though.

“And your father won’t tell you *anything*?”

“He keeps telling me he’ll explain later, but it never seems to be later. I guess maybe he’s waiting for Hawkmoth to return Nathalie but I’ve no idea when *that’s* going to be.”

“Hmm.” Marinette said. “And he *really* seems to trust Hawkmoth?”

“Yeah apparently.”

“It’s just weird, from the night we confronted him and Mayura I didn’t think he liked Hawkmoth very much.”

“That makes two of us.”

Marinette bit her lower lip looking uncertain.

“Marinette?”

“I don’t want to sound accusative but, are you sure your father couldn’t be Hawkmoth? Could Mayura have used his Miraculous to akumatise him?”

There wasn’t really a non-accusative way to say that. Adrien tried his best not to be offended. It *would* make a lot of sense but, “Why take Nathalie then? Hawkmoth knows we know my father’s at least in contact with him now, it wouldn’t make us more suspicious if he’d brought her back to the her room in the house. Or even her own apartment.”

“Wait, does she live with you or not?”

“Sort of? She has a room for if she has to stay late, or she and Father have an early flight or something, but recently she’s been using it a lot more.”

“Ok,” Marinette shock her head, “I think with everything I learn about all of them I have even *less* idea what’s going on, but I guess whatever’s going on with her and Hawkmoth is a sign that he and your dad are different people because otherwise were does Mayura fit in?”

Adrien felt uncomfortable as he remembered his father’s odd reaction when he’d tried to explain his feelings as Adrien. What had happened afterwards had stopped him from really thinking about it but he supposed it could be *possible* he could have interpreted it about being about Mayura and Nathalie, but which of them he’d thought corresponded to Ladybug and Marinette he didn’t know.

No, that didn’t seem right at all. *If* his father had mistaken Adrien’s romantic situation for his own then he must have thought Adrien was talking about Maman and Mayura. There was no way he could be this calm about Hawkmoth taking Nathalie if he liked her romantically.

“Yeah, that wouldn’t make sense.”

Marinette gestured helplessly, “*Nothing* makes sense. At this point the only thing that I’m fairly certain about is that your father isn’t dating Hawkmoth.”

“Yeah at least I have that.” Adrien looked at his girlfriend, “You didn’t seriously consider that as a possibility did you?”

She shrugged. “He agreed when Mayura called you “our Adrien,” I was trying to see if there was any way other than him being your father that explained that.”

Oh. “I assumed she was just referring to her and my father when she said ‘our’.”

“She could have been I guess.”

“Father?” he asked over dinner. “You’re not dating Hawkmoth are you?”

His father froze with his fork halfway to his mouth, then put it down, “I can guarantee you I am not dating Hawkmoth.”

“Good.” Adrien said.

He thought that was the end of it but after some time silently eating he asked, “Do you find it easier to imagine forgiving Mayura than Hawkmoth?”

“What?” Adrien couldn’t help but say.

“I said, do you find it easier to imagine forgiving Mayura than Hawkmoth?”

“No, I heard what you said. I’m just confused why you’re asking me that. Are you concerned about whether I’d be able to forgive Mayura? I think I could try to, she *did* stop attacking me when she knew it was me after all.”

“Forget it.” His father said.

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“So,” He said to Marinette as soon as she got into class, “My father is definitely *not* dating Hawkmoth I confirmed that much.”

“Was, was that question you needed answering?” Nino said looking at him as if he’d just said the sky was green.

Adrien tensed and wished he’d waited to say that in private. “I don’t want to talk about it.”

“I don’t think I want to ask about it.” Nino replied.

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“And Mlle. Sancoeur isn’t back yet?” Marinette asked, swinging her legs off the side of the building. It was still really weird to be able to hang out with her as Chat Noir and Ladybug without their secrets between them.

“Not yet.” He said, “She’s texted me a few times though, and I think my father might have talked to her.”

Marinette frowned, “How long has she been ill?”

Adrien tried to think, “A few months? It's hard to tell because it's not a constant thing. Sometimes she seems fine, and other times she's barely able to stand on her feet. And she tries to hide it from me as well. She never used to get unwell like this before this year though.”

“Hmm.”

“What are you thinking?”

“You know, when we saw them on the Eiffel Tower, and then when Hawkmoth stopped Mayura from attacking you she mentioned a “her”, and not betraying her. Could that have been Mlle.Sancoeur? Do you think *she's* what they're doing it for?”

“To cure her?” He asked, it *would* make sense, and if Hawkmoth and Mayura were doing it for *Nathalie* then that could explain his father's involvement but, “That seems excessive though. Why not go to a hospital?”

“Maybe it's magical.” Marinette said, “Mayura said it was partially her fault wasn’t it? We don't know how she and Hawkmoth found their Miraculous, maybe they meddled with something they shouldn't have and cursed her or something.”

“That world actually make a lot of sense.” Adrien said, “*and* if he knew then that world explain why my father had the Grimoire, and how he met Mayura. I bet Nathalie and Hawkmoth *were* together, and that’s how she could have got affected by any magic.”

“Or maybe she and Mayura were friends,”

Adrien thought that less likely after the incident with the Ladyblog though he now wondered if it had been her relationship with *Hawkmoth* rather than with his father that Nathalie had felt Mayura was infringing on. That would definitely make sense if she'd known that they'd been planning to stage that kiss. Especially with how not faked it had looked, but he decided not to bring any of that up to Ladybug. It was awkward enough thinking about his father and Nathalie’s romantic lives already.

“Whichever, but either way Nathalie got cursed, and they decided to steal our Miraculouses to fix it. And then my father found out because he's with Nathalie all the time, but he went along with it for her sake, and then he fell for Mayura. It all makes so much sense.”

Then another thought occurred to him, “If it's a magical illness do you think it could make people disappear out of existence?”

“I guess so,” Marinette placed her hand over his, “Why?”

“It’s just, Nathalie’s symptoms, they're like what my maman had before she disappeared. Maybe *that's* why the police never found any sign of her. Maybe it was magic. Maybe my father didn't find out afterwards. Maybe he was in on it from the start, and that's why he’s been so worried about Nathalie and so ready to go along with two supervillains. Because he's seen it before.”

“Oh Adrien.”

He could feel the tears in his eyes, “Why does that feel worse? I've *known* that she's not coming back, not after this long, why should the idea that magic wiped her out of existence make it worse?”

“It's not something you'd expect is it? Even with our lives.”

“Yeah I guess I tend to split things into Chat Noir stuff and Adrien stuff and she's always been *Adrien* stuff.”

“Come here,” Marinette said, and pulled him into a hug and he'd have thought that would stop him thinking about bad things but today it didn't work and his brain kept working, and he didn't even want to tell *Marinette* where it was going.

Because his father *couldn't* be Hawkmoth. He *couldn't.* There was no reason to think the holder of the Butterfly Miraculous could akumatise himself, and if he could then surely he wouldn't have caused all those rumours with Mayura, and anyway surely Adrien would have noticed.

But if what Nathalie had was what his mother had had then maybe Nathalie didn't catch it from what Hawkmoth and Mayura had done at all. She could have caught it from *his mother.* It could have been from something in the *house.* There was no way he could let Marinette in the house until he knew that it wasn’t.

And if that was the case then, well terrible as it was he *could* see his father paying Hawkmoth and Mayura for their reign of terror. If they’d been meant to save his Maman and then they’d not found their Miraculouses until it was too late for her but then Nathalie had got ill too he *could* see his father countenancing what they'd done.

*Especially* with that odd concern last night about whether Adrien could forgive Hawkmoth, which would make an *awful* lot of sense if he'd actually been asking if Adrien could forgive him.

And, putting one person above a whole city that sounded ridiculous, but now he had Marinette Adrien thought he could maybe understand it.

And the whole thing raised a different question too, “If her illness *is* magical do you think we could help? I know our Miraculouses aren't an option but, could we do *something?”*

Marinette released him and stared into his eyes, “I'll talk to Tikki and all the other Kwami’s. There *has* to be something, but Adrien we can't help them unless they ask for it, and agree to give up the Butterfly and the Peacock.”

# Chapter 8

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adrien paused at the light creeping out from under Nathalie's room door. It could be nothing but it certainly hadn't been there before.

He debated knocking but if it was Hawkmoth picking up her stuff or something he didn't want to give him the chance to escape, so he pushed open the door.

Nathalie was sat up against the headboard in her bed in pyjamas with her hair down and damp as if she'd recently showered, looking for all the world as if she'd just finished a normal day at work, and not as if she'd spent the last few days with the man who'd been terrorising Paris.

A rush of relief and excitement went through him. "Nathalie?!"

She looked towards the door, and seemed to stiffen as she saw him, "Adrien?"

She almost seemed surprised to see him which seemed the wrong way round really, but he supposed maybe it was strange seeing someone else other than Hawkmoth for the first time in days, "Hawkmoth let you go?"

He'd said he would, and he'd said she'd be unharmed, and his father had seemed to believe him but *Adrien* still hadn't really.

Nathalie shrugged, "For a certain definition, yes."

"What do you mean for a certain definition?" He asked walking over to the bed and sitting down on the end of it.

"Apparently I'm not allowed to get out of bed because I'm still," she made quotation marks in the air, 'kidnapped' until he's satisfied I'm well enough to get up."

"How does that even *work*?" He couldn't help but ask, "Is he watching you or something?"

"Something like that."

"So *Hawkmoth* is making you stay in bed until you feeling better?"

"Yes."

"Isn't that a *little* weird? Even for whatever is going on between the four of you?"

"The four of us?"

Nathalie seemed lost, so he hurried to clarify. "You, Hawkmoth, Father and Mayura."

“Right. The four of us.” She said, though he couldn’t quite read the expression on her face.

It seemed as good a time as any to ask the important question. “So are you and Hawkmoth together?”

“We,” Nathalie refused to meet his eyes and seemed to be looking around the room for an escape.

“I'm not judging you,” he actually was a little given everything Hawkmoth had done but if he *was* doing all this for her then he could understand why she'd stay with him, “I'm just trying to make sense of all this.”

“I can’t blame you for that,” she said, “But I think that's a question you should ask your father.”

He knew his father had said he’d explain all of it later but surely some of it was hers to explain, after all “What has my father got to do with your relationship with Hawkmoth?”

Given how they were all tangled together the answer to *that* question was probably a lot of things, but he couldn’t see how any of the explanations he’d thought up or discussed with Marinette would mean his father was the one who should answer that first question. Surely whether or not Hawkmoth and Nathalie were together was something up to them, and not his father?

What could his father even do about it?  Fire Nathalie if she refused to break up with Hawkmoth?

“That’s also a question you should ask your father.”

That *really* didn’t clarify things.

“He’s not really answering my questions either at the moment.” Adrien admitted.

Nathalie shifted to better look him in the eyes, “That might be my fault actually. I think he wanted to discuss some things with me, before he explained everything to you.”

“Oh.” He said, he supposed if they were Nathalie’s secrets too then that was fair enough but he didn’t understand why his father hadn’t just said *that* to him instead of letting him imagine all sorts of horrible things, “Do you need time to do that now? I know Hawkmoth let him have some sort of contact with you, but I don’t know how much.”

“No, we, talked,” Nathalie said awkwardly as if she was considering each word before committing to it, “but,  I think all we could decide was that we did need to talk to you. The rest it of seemed like a discussion for…after.”

“Ok.” He nodded, but really nothing of that she’d said had made anything clearer at all. Which was probably deliberate if Nathalie thought that it wasn’t her place to tell to him about this, but that didn’t make it any less annoying.

The door opened again and his father walked in, “I’m sorry I couldn’t find,” he stopped himself, “Adrien. I didn’t know you were here.”

Adrien looked his father up and down, and noticed he was *also* already dressed for bed, and that he’d come into the room *expecting* that someone was going to be here and that from what he’d said that someone clearly wasn’t *him*.

There was only one conclusion.

“You knew Nathalie was back and you didn’t tell me!”

His father looked past Adrien to Nathalie as if expecting her to tell him what to say but she just shrugged.

“I was going to tell you in the morning?” He said sounding completely without his usual assurance, “I thought you’d be in bed.”

“Father!” He complained, “Nathalie’s important to me too, you should have known I would have wanted to know immediately.”

Nathalie smiled at that, but looked down when she realised they were both looking at her. “Sorry.”

“You don’t have to apologise.” Adrien said.

His father walked over to the bed, and Nathalie shifted over making room for him to sit beside her opposite Adrien.  She hadn’t moved over *that* much though, and the sides of their arms touched as his father perched on the bed, and Adrien realised maybe she *had* meant that her relationship was dependant on his father after all.

Which, he *did* prefer the idea of his father and Nathalie being together than either of them being with the people he’d been regularly fighting, but he wasn’t exactly sure where that left Mayura and Hawkmoth, and their apparent alliance. Though it wasn’t as if he thought the villains were incapable of consoling each other from everything he’d seen and heard.

It would leave the matter of Nathalie’s mysterious condition unsolved though if he was right in his guess about the situation.

His father clearly had no idea of the thoughts going through his head, “I’m sorry Adrien. You’re right. I should have known you’d want to know.”

“Are you going to tell me what’s going on now then?” he ventured, “Nathalie *is* back now.”

The two adults looked at each other.

“It’s not exactly the best timing.” His father said.

“We could call Adrien in sick for school tomorrow.” Nathalie replied.

“I don’t want to wait any longer.” Adrien said, “I think I’ve worked some of it out anyway. Even if I’m still confused about what’s going on with the four of you.”

“The four of us?” His father echoed Nathalie’s earlier reaction.

“Us, Hawkmoth and Mayura.” Nathalie said.

“I see.” He father said, then he focused back on Adrien, “What exactly have you worked out?”

“Nathalie’s illness, its magic isn’t it?” He said.

His father flinched, and Nathalie took his hand.

“It is.” He confirmed.

Something in their reaction made Adrien wonder at if his wilder guess had been right, “Is it what Maman had?”

“Yes.” His father said, “How on earth did you realise that?”

“The symptoms mostly. And then everything recently making me realise mine wasn’t the only Miraculous connected to this house. I was talking to M-”he cut himself off before he could out Marinette, “My Ladybug about it and then it all clicked.”

Both adults looked pale, “Did it?” said his father.

“That’s what it’s all about isn’t it?” Adrien said, “Saving her? What Hawkmoth and Mayura have done is terrible, but if that’s it I can understand how you’d condone their villainy.”

“I’m so relieved to hear you say that.” His father said, “I’d considered telling you before, Nathalie encouraged me to, but I never knew how to explain it to you.”

“I wish you had. I know you didn’t know I was Chat Noir, but Ladybug and I would have done whatever we could to save Nathalie.”

Nathalie and his father exchanged a look and Adrien suddenly realised what he’d accidentally implied, “No I mean, we’ll *still* do whatever we can to help Nathalie. Obviously Hawkmoth and Mayura will have to stop and give up the Butterfly and the Peacock, but we wouldn’t punish you like that.”

“Thank you,” Nathalie said, “I know I don't deserve that.”

His father made a noise of disagreement, but she shook her head cutting him off, “We know I don't. But Adrien, are you sure you can only help me?”

Actually Adrien wasn’t even sure he *could* help her, and he didn't really want to give her false hope but at the same time he could feel this conversation was teetering at on a knife edge and he knew he had a responsibility as Chat Noir to make sure it landed on the side where Paris wasn’t terrified by Akumas.

And as Adrien Agreste he selfishly wanted that side to *also* have a solution to Nathalie's condition and one where freed from its secrets his family could start to put itself together again.

But to do that he had to work out who Nathalie *meant,* "Are you worried about Hawkmoth? I'd have to talk to Ladybug before I could agree anything for him and Mayura."

"I am and I understand that, but,"

Feeling sorry for her, he tried to reassure her, "I'm sure we could work out *some* sort of deal with him, Ladybug *does* fix everything, and I'm sure she'll understand when we explain that all of this was to save *you.* It's romantic really."

He realised that he actually *would* feel sorry for Hawkmoth if Nathalie abandoned him for his father. There wasn't really a bigger gesture of your feelings for someone than terrorising an entire city to try to save their life.

He wasn't sure the adults agreed as Nathalie was staring at him wide-eyed and his father was looking at him as if Adrien had just started speaking Chinese or a different language he didn't understand.

Nathalie seemed to break out of it first. "To save," She paused, "*me?*"

"Yes?" He asked, suddenly unsure, "Isn't that what this is all about? Hawkmoth wants my Miraculous and Ladybug's so he can cure the curse or whatever you're under, and Father's supporting him because he lost Maman to the same thing?"

She opened her mouth as if to say something then promptly shut it again.

Then she turned to his father, "Gabriel?"

"I didn't foresee this." His father said.

"Have you changed your mind?" She asked.

"What do *you* want me to do?"

"You know I want what's best for you. And for Adrien."

"And what about you?" His father said pushing her hair off her face and behind her ear.

The effect was ruined by her looking down at the bed rather than answering.

"It would be easier. Not to." His father mused while tapping his fingers against her bedside table, "But, it would be unfair to you. And unfair to *her.* She deserves the truth if I'm to betray the promises I made her."

Adrien was now completely lost. The only her that would make sense in this sentence would be Mayura, but that didn't seem to fit the conversation they were having.

Nathalie looked up and gave his father something that looked like a nod.

“Adrien,” his father started, “All of this, it wasn’t because of Nathalie.”

“But,” he interrupted, “I don’t, you just said that she *was* ill because of magic, are you saying you don’t think you need our Miraculouses to heal her?”

“No.” His father said, “No I don’t know any other way to heal her, and I am going to need your help with that, but Nathalie’s illness, that came later. Hawkmoth exists because of your mother. She’s who we’re trying to save, or were trying to save.”

“Because of Maman?” Adrien reeled but that did make sense, he’d even thought that his father might have funded Hawkmoth and Mayura to find a way to save her and they’d been too late but, “*are* trying to save? She disappeared before Hawkmoth made his first appearance, are you saying that she’s not,” he struggled for words, “gone?”

“Not exactly.” His father said as if he wasn’t shattering his world.

“I don’t understand.” He really didn’t and he wasn’t sure he wanted to, “Either she’s alive or she’s not surely?”

“It’s not that simple. You mother.” His father swallowed, “the magical damage she suffered has her on the brink of death. We were able to stabilise her there but that’s it. Without the combined powers of creation and destruction she’ll never open her eyes again, or breathe unaided, or have her heart beat of her own accord.”

Adrien felt horror creep through him, and he could feel his own heart beating fast in his chest, “That doesn’t really sound like she’s alive.”

His father tilted his head in what might have been an admission that Adrien was right.

“*Please* never do that to me. If I’m ever in that situation then *let me die.*” He wasn’t being imprisoned in some limbo tied up to a machine. Being trapped in the house was bad enough, he couldn’t let himself be trapped in some sort of half-life. He needed to know his father would let him go.

“You’re not going to die.” His father said, “Not before I do.”

The confidence in his voice was the opposite of reassurance when Adrien was talking to the man behind Hawkmoth and Mayura’s reign of terror.

Nathalie intervened, “Gabriel, I don’t think,”

His father groaned and buried his face in his hands before she could finish. He mumbled something indistinctly.

“Um, sorry, what did you say?” Adrien asked.

Releasing his head from his hands his father looked up, “I’m sorry Adrien. I release that wasn’t helpful. I will,” he sighed, “endeavour to follow your wishes. In fact I’m glad you said

that really."

"Glad?"

"In a way. You see, the reason I wanted to tell you this was, I suppose I hoped you'd be the one to end this."

"End this? Are you saying you'll stop?"

"I don't know if I have it in me to keep going. Now I know that it's you I've been fighting the whole time, and other things," his eyes flicked towards Nathalie, "have changed for me as well, it suddenly seems like an entirely different enterprise. I hoped that either you or your Ladybug would be able to save your mother, or you'd force me to stop and free me of the obligation regardless. Either way there'd be an end."

"Force you?" He couldn't help but ask, even as he didn't really want to know what his father's ideas of that might entail.

"I supposed you'd take the Butterfly and Peacock from me at the very least."

"You keep them *here?"* He asked in utter disbelief, struck by the thought that Marinette was going to be so unimpressed with him.

"Yes."

"How did I have no idea of any of this? They were under the same roof as me this whole time? *How did my kwami never notice either?"*

"I had much the same thoughts when I realised you were Chat Noir." His father admitted ruefully.

Adrien tried to focus on the important things, "but you're saying you'll *give* them to me?"

"I thought we might negotiate."

"*Negotiate?* Are you saying you'd still fight me now you know?"

"I'd *prefer* not to, but there's things to consider."

He stared at his father wondering if he'd ever truly known him at all, "What things?"

"Well, Nathalie's life for one. If I can't save your mother then at the very least I don't want to have killed her attempting it."

That was, well, he could understand *some* level of fighting him for that maybe if it looked like he was the sort of person that would abandon someone who helped bring him to die but, "I already said we'd help if we could."

"So you did. But there's also," he shrugged, "well I don't plan on going to prison Adrien."

“I don't know if I can decide that.” He admitted.

“I’d appreciate some warning before you went to the authorities at least. Or do you value your morals over your family so much you couldn't even do that?”

“I could,” he hesitated because he knew that he'd never been as altruistic a hero as Marinette was, but that he didn’t think he could refuse his father now seemed to show he probably wasn’t a very good one either, “probably do that.”

It might have been the wrong thing to do but all of this has been for his *mother* after all. That meant something.

But something else occurred to him, “Willl Hawkmoth and Mayura agree to stop? I know you said you're the one holding their Miraculous and I don't think *she'd* fight me, and I suppose he did stop her but that was because you asked him to wasn’t it? And I suppose it's because of Nathalie but he really believes in this doesn’t he? He's not just doing this for the money anymore if he ever was.”

“Adrien.” His father sounded almost incredulous, “I’m not paying Hawkmoth, I”

Mind racing he interrupted, “but you said Nathalie didn't get ill until later, that this was all for my mother,”

“It was,” his father said sending his thoughts down a terrifying route, because that meant Hawkmoth wasn’t doing it for Nathalie originally, “you see I,”

And if his father wasn’t paying him then, “*Was Hawkmoth in love with Maman?”*

“Yes,” his father took off his glasses and pinched the bridge of his nose, “Because I'm,”

“What even was the situation?” He tried to make sense of it all because his mother wouldn’t have, she *wouldn’t,* and his father wouldn’t work with Hawkmoth if she had and, “Did you lie to me when you said you weren't involved with Hawkmoth? Did all three of you have some *thing* together?”

Both his father and Nathalie made different but equally inarticulate noises.

“*Nathalie,”* his father choked out his hand gripping his pyjama shirt pocket, “what was *that* reaction?”

Adrien thought that was a bit unfair. He wasn't quite sure what her response had meant but it didn't seem like it deserved that reaction, when it hadn’t seemed *that* different to his father’s to him.

“I'm sorry. That was inappropriate. It was just a very striking image.” She said.

His father continued to look at her, “Really? *All* of it?”

“I don't think we discuss this in front of Adrien.” She said, and suddenly he realised what she'd meant by striking and he felt inexplicably betrayed. Just because she liked his father,

and Hawkmoth, and apparently his mother didn't justify her finding the scenario not-weird.

"Later then." His father said.

"So you do *like* Hawkmoth then Nathalie?" He asked, grasping to the slightly older discovery so he could ignore the newer one, "It's not some one-sided thing on his side?"

"I" she started then gave up.

"Wait," he realised, "You never answered me Father. Were Maman and Hawkmoth together? They weren't right? You and her were happy won't you? You didn't need anyone else did you?"

"We *were* happy yes, that's why I,"

Thrown by the admission in his tone he interrupted, "There *was* something?"

"Because," His father tried to explain, but Adrien didn't let him finish.

"Oh this is weirder than watching him making out with Mayura was, which by the way how did you even manage to,"

"Watching," Nathalie interjected in a curiously high pitched voice, "What do you mean *watching?* Please tell me you mean you saw the photos?"

"Ladybug and I kind of got stuck on the Eiffel Tower above them and saw the whole of that performance, which by the way I don't think really had that much acting involved," he realised too late that maybe he shouldn't have broken the news like that to someone in some nebulous type of relationship with Hawkmoth, "Sorry Nathalie."

"Oh my god," She said, and turned and buried her face in his father's chest.

He looked as lost as Adrien. "Nathalie?"

Her voice came out slightly muffled, "I can never look Adrien in the eyes again."

"It's not that bad." His father said, "We knew he'd see the photos."

"That's not the same thing. I'd never have done it if I knew he was there."

That single pronoun forced his wordview into a whole new alignment again. Nathalie was Mayura. That changed *everything,* and suddenly all those incidents with her, and with Mayura, and with Hawkmoth started to look very different.

She looked up at his father, "How can you be so calm about this, we did *that* in front of your son."

"Unfortunately I'm sure Adrien's seen worse."

“I’m not sure I have?” He offered uncertainly, though if his father thought that was normal it put a new slant on his attempts to keep him away from the outside world.

Nathalie groaned collapsing into his father’s shoulder, “I *knew* that it was a bad idea, the kissing was a mistake. I should never have kissed you like that, and now it turns out it was *in front of Adrien*.”

The final piece slotted into place.

“You’re Hawkmoth and Mayura.” He said almost at the very point he realised it, “They don’t work for you, they *are* you.”

“Yes.” Said his father, “I have been *trying* to tell you that for the last five minutes.”

“That does make a lot more sense,” he said ignoring his father’s interjection, “Especially compared to you getting into three separate love triangles with him. That was stupid of me.”

His eyebrow’s almost reached his hairline, “Three love triangles?”

“Over Maman, Nathalie and Mayura?”

“Right.”

Slowly he started to realise what all of this meant, “You *kissed* Nathalie.”

“Yes.”

“But,” Adrien struggled to put his thoughts together, “You said Maman was still alive. That’s not right, unless, was I *almost* right earlier?”

“What?”

“That there was something between three of you, except that three was you, Maman, and *Nathalie?”*

Nathalie still hadn’t moved so he couldn’t see her reaction but his father blinked, “Now that’s a striking imagine, but no Adrien, no we didn’t.”

“Then, you’re cheating on her? Except she’s not really alive is she, so it’s not really cheating? Or is it? I don’t know. How can you terrorise Paris for her? But then go and start a relationship with someone else?”

That did seem to strike something. His father looked uneasy as he said, “none of this was my intention. Things just happened.”

Nathalie sat back upright, “We’re not in a relationship. You don’t have to worry about that Adrien. I know things have got a bit complicated recently, but I’d never let myself come between your parents. I’ll resign if that what’s needed.”

“But,” his father started, “I thought, you said.”

“It doesn’t matter what I said. Your family is the important thing here.”

“I don’t think that’s necessary,” Adrien told her, as he tried to force his thoughts into some sense of order. As betrayed by her as he was he didn’t want Nathalie to leave them, especially after the proof of her concern for him she’d shown as Mayura.

“What isn’t necessary?” She asked, seeming sincerely thrown.

“You resigning. Or you two denying what’s between you. I’ll have to speak to Ladybug but I don’t think it sounds like Maman can be saved. I couldn’t let my Miraculous be used for something like that. Not with the cost it would have. If she *is* dead, then, I don’t think you should force yourselves to be unhappy because you think you should.”

Nathalie smiled weakly, “When did you get so mature?”

“When my father abandoned me to go play supervillain apparently.”

“Adrien,” his father sighed.

“This is all a lot to process.” He pointed out, “I’d realised some of it, but knowing the truth about my mother, knowing that Hawkmoth and Mayura aren’t just working for you, I need time if I’m going to forgive you.”

“Technically I do work for him.” Nathalie pointed out.

“Please tell me you didn’t do all of this because this was your job.” He might have to tell her to sue for sexual harassment if that was it and that seemed ironic for someone who’d sat him down before his first photoshoots and delivered various warnings of what he should immediately report to her if it happened.

She leant back against the headboard, “No, that was because I’m stupid.”

“No you’re not.” His father said, “You just care too deeply for people who don’t deserve it.”

“Adrien deserves it.”

“Yes, he does.” His father agreed.

“I think you deserve it.”

“Hmm. I’m not sure about that.”

Silence reigned over them until suddenly Adrien’s phone went.

He looked at it and mentally winced as he saw Marinette’s face. He needed to tell her about all of this in their roles as Miraculous Wielders, and he needed to talk to her about it to make sense of his own feelings about it, but he wasn’t quite sure he was ready for either of those conversations.

“Hi,” he answered.

“Hi, um, are you ok?”

The truthful answer was no, not at all but he dialled it back to, “Not exactly, but why are you ringing?”

“Is it a bad time? I can ring back.” She asked apologetically.

“No it’s fine.” He reassured her.

“It’s just. Do you remember our conversation about who you-know-you might be?”

“Yes.”

“I don’t want you to think I don’t trust you, and I know you didn’t like the idea, but what you said about your mother and her illness got me thinking and I really do think,”

“Stop.” He said.

“Adrien? I’m sorry I didn’t mean.”

“You’re right.”

“What?” Marinette’s shock was audible over the phone line.

“It was my father and Nathalie the whole time.”

“Oh. *Oh.* Are you okay? Is your Miraculous ok?”

“That’s fine. *I’m* fine. Physically.”

“He didn’t?” She trailed off.

He calmed her concerns, “No. They just told me.”

“Oh.”

That summed it all up really.

He knew it was a lot to ask, but he needed to get away from here, and he chanced, “could I come over to yours for a bit?”

His father straightened up as if to say something but Nathalie put a retraining hand on his arm and he stayed silent.

Marinette didn’t immediately respond.

“I know it’s late, and your parents might not approve. I can come as Chat if that’s easier.”

“No, I mean, of course you can come, you don’t have to come as Chat, you can come as Adrien if you know you needed to stay a while.”

“Yeah, I might do that. Um.” He looked at Nathalie and his father, “I’ll ring your home phone to talk to your parents, if that helps?”

“They’d let you anyway I think, but yeah that wouldn’t do any harm.”

“OK I will. See you soon.”

“Are you safe to come off the phone? Your father won’t,” she hesitated to say anyway more, and he loved her a little for her clear attempt to not slander his father even though she knew he’d been who they’d been fighting the whole time.

“No, I’ll be fine.” He tried to reassure her again.

How successful he’d been in that he didn’t know but Marinette didn’t try to drag out the phone call at least.

He put it down to find both adults looking at him.

“I’m going to Marinette’s for the night.” He announced, “Maybe for a bit more.”

“I didn’t say you could,” his father said but he looked sideways at Nathalie who almost imperceptibly shook her head, “but I suppose I can allow it if you put a good word in with us with Ladybug.”

“What?” He attempted to obfuscate, “I said I was going to Marinette’s, my *girlfriend’s,* not Ladybug’s.”

“They’re the same person. I worked *that* much out.”

“*What?”* Adrien’s mind span round in circles as he realised he’d betrayed Ladybug to *Hawkmoth,* “And you didn’t try to capitalise on that?”

“I had other things on my mind,”

Nathalie suddenly started coughing, and his father’s attention left him completely as his hands fluttered ineffectively around her, before he seemed to remember the glass of water on her bedside table and passed it to her once she’d stopped.

“I told you weren’t ready to return to work.”

“You know I couldn’t have spent any longer,” she glanced at Adrien, “where I was or we’d have done something you’d regret.”

“You don’t know that.”

“I do.”

“Wait,” Adrien interrupted, “Where were you? If you’re Hawkmoth,” he addressed his father, “why did you take Nathalie and not bring her back here?”

“I told you.” His father said, “She needed to rest, and actually take some time to recover. If having her ‘kidnapped’ was the only way to make that happen I was quite willing to go along with that.”

“If she’s that ill, shouldn’t you have been with her?”

“I was.”

“But, wait, are you saying she was in the *house* the whole time? *Where?*”

“Various places.” Nathalie said, “It doesn’t matter. Didn’t you need to ring your girlfriend’s parents?”

“Oh yeah right. Um. I was hoping one of you would do it.”

Nathalie went to reach for her phone, then realised it wasn’t close by and gestured for his, “What are we telling them anyway?”

“Um, I thought maybe we could claim you guys were sick, and wanted me away from it?”

“Huh, you really are your father’s son aren’t you?”

“*What?*”

“That was his excuse for when we weren’t taking calls while I was captured by Hawkmoth too.”

---

“Do you have everything?” His father asked.

“Nearly.” He summoned every bit of courage he had, “I need your Miraculous too. And Nathalie’s. I can’t endanger Ladybug by letting you have it.”

“I can understand that.” His father paused, “You *will* help Nathalie?”

“We’ll do whatever we can.” He promised.

His father unclipped the Butterfly Miraculous from where it had apparently been pinned inside a front pocket of his pyjama shirt, and pulled the Peacock out from the other one.

At Adrien’s surprise he said, “Nathalie had a bad habit of finding it wherever I hid it. I decided that on me was the safest place. Here.”

---

Once they were safely alone, Marinette asked, “Are you *sure* you’re ok?”

“No,” he admitted, “Hawkmoth was my father the *whole time.* He was doing it to save my mother. How am I supposed to respond to that?”

“Oh kitty come here,” She said pulling him into a hug, “It’ll be ok, we’ll work it out.”

Finally safe in her arms he let himself cry.

---

“So, what sort of curse was on your mother? And on Nathalie? You never said.”

“I don’t know,” he said, “I didn’t think to ask.”

“How did you not ask?”

“I was distracted ok!”

“Because of your dad being Hawkmoth? That would be pretty hard to get past but surely what happened to her would be your first question?”

“Um, can I tell you later?” Preferably once he’d been able to come up with a less embarrassing version of events.

“Ok, if that’s what you want.” She accepted, “Though I’m going to be completely unable to concentrate the whole time at school.”

“I could tell you before?” Adrien offered.

Marinette’s disbelief was clear. “What part of me almost missing registration everyday made you think I was a morning person?”

“I could tell you on the way to school?” He suggested as a compromise, either as he meant to make sure she woke up in enough time to do so.

“That works.”

Chapter End Notes

disclaimer: I *don't* think Adrien's stupid at all. He just doesn't want to admit some things and who could blame him?

———

also I'm not sure if/when the next chapter this will appear b/c...I struggle to see a way to make Adrien grappling with his mother's death funny.

# Chapter 9

Chapter Notes

In which very little happens

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Um, shouldn't Marinette be downstairs by now?”

Sabine looked back from the counter, in between customers, and glanced at the clock, “Probably.”

She didn't seem particularly concerned through, despite the fact Adrien was convinced they were going to be late and he'd have no time to talk Marinette about what happened if she didn't appear soon.

“Should I go and make sure she's up?” He asked, slightly unsure of the etiquette of being in a girl's room when she was your girlfriend and mightn’t be dressed, and yeah he'd been in Marinette's room at night as Chat Noir but that felt different somehow.

Thankfully Marinette’s father was busy baking and his own father didn't have the Butterfly Miraculous any more so at least any repeat of Weredad was unlikely.

Marinette’s mother seemed unbothered but she did seem slightly amused as she said, “If you’re volunteering then go ahead.”

Adrien headed upstairs feeling like he’d missed something. How hard could waking Marinette up be?

---

“I'm sorry I threw a pillow at you.” Marinette mumbled through a mouthful of croissant as they left the shop.

“It’s ok.” Adrien said, “I guess you weren't really expecting me to be in your room first thing in the morning.”

“I honestly thought it was a really weird dream and then I panicked.”

“Hey, at least now we don't have to deal with Hawkmoth anymore you'll be able to get more sleep.”

“That's something,” Marinette smiled, “though honestly I always seem at my most creative late at night, so who knows if I’ll manage to get to bed that much earlier. Not having to worry about akuma's in the middle of the night will be nice though. Seriously did your dad sleep with that Miraculous on? Do you even feel emotions though it when you’re asleep?”

Adrien was struck by how he’d had the Butterfly Miraculous pinned to his pyjama shirt. “Uh, yeah I think he did actually.”

“Huh,” Marinette started to laugh.

“What?”

“I know it doesn't matter what we’re wearing when we transform but the image of him akumatising people in his pyjamas is kind of hilarious.”

“I guess.” Honestly the whole thing was still a little too fresh to laugh at.

She noticed his morose mood and took his hand, “Sorry. I wasn’t thinking about how much this is to deal with for you.”

“That's ok. It's kind of hard for me to believe all this happened, it must be weirder for you not even bring there.” Despite knowing this was the perfect lead in to discussing last night and what they were going to do he found himself unready to do so and changed the subject away again instead, “Hey, wouldn’t you know if you still feel things through the Butterfly Miraculous when you’re asleep? As the Guardian I mean.”

“Master Fu didn’t exactly have the time to give me a full course of training. I’ve no idea. I guess we’d have to ask the Butterfly Kwami now we have his Miraculous.” She wrinkled her nose and Adrien was distracted by how cute it was, “I think the wielder must be able to though.”

“I don’t know.” Adrien admitted, “My father stays up pretty late, he gets ideas in the middle of the night too. I mean he did even when Maman was around. She threw him out of their bedroom for coming to bed too late and waking her up too many nights in a row once. Maybe it’s a creative thing?”

Once he’d said it he had the passing thought that maybe he should have reassured Marinette that he wouldn’t chuck her out of bed but that felt like kind of a weird thing to say when they didn’t share one yet.

She didn’t seem to pick up on it anyway.

“I hope that’s the *only* thing I have in common with him.” Then her expression changed, “wait, I take that back I have no problems with being that successful launching my fashion brand.” She shook her head, “I still can’t believe Hawkmoth was your dad the whole time. I had posters from *Hawkmoth’s* ad campaigns off in his room.”

“You had posters of *me* up in your room.” Adrien pointed out, eager to save his mark on her room on the rubbish bin, then he belatedly realised, “That was because you *liked* me wasn’t

it? It wasn't to do with fashion after all."

He probably *had* known that deep down. After all he *did* live in a house covered in images of his mother. He knew the implications. He'd just been too fixated on Ladybug to want to consider the possibility of Marinette as more than a friend.

"I am so sorry."

"Why should you apologise? You can put up as many photos of me as you want. I'll even pose for some if you like." He exaggerated a pose, "I *am* a famous experienced model."

Marinette blushed, "I think I'm ok for now."

"Well, if you even change your mind you know where I am."

She tilted her head, and looked him up and down, "It's weird seeing you act like Chat as Adrien."

"Good weird though?"

"Yeah, actually. I wouldn't have guessed it, but I think it is."

"Good." He said, and the smile on his face was genuine. Then he realised. "We've uneven. I need photos of you for my room."

She blushed again, but deflected him, "You might need to work out if or when you're going back to your room first."

"Oh." His heart sank down from the giddy heights it had been soaring oh, "yeah, I guess I do."

"So," Marinette said giving his hand a reassuring squeeze, "How exactly did it all happen last night? Did they just sit you down and tell you or what?"

"I wish that was what happened. No it all started when I noticed a light on in Nathalie's room and went to investigate to see if she was back." Adrien began.

---

"You thought *what?*" Marinette asked.

"In my defence I had just been blindsided by everything about Maman."

---

*“He knows I’m Ladybug?”*

Adrien looked at his girlfriend in panic, “Did I not say that last night?”

“No, no you did not.”

In an attempt to shift the blame he asked, “Did Plagg not tell Tikki?”

“Apparently not.” Marinette said, and at least it sounded like her annoyance was shared.

---

“So why fake-kidnap Nathalie?” Marinette asked, “If he was going to admit the whole thing to you anyway? He knew who you were, and he might have known who I was so it can’t have been he thought us incapable of getting her back to the house.”

“Apparently he thought she needed a rest, because of her condition and he decided that was the only way to make her take one?”

Marinette frowned, “That’s kind of sweet actually, but it’s also kind of controlling?”

“That’s my father.”

“Yeah, I guess she knows what she’s getting into there. I can kind of see why she’d go along with it though.”

“Really?” Adrien asked. He could understand Nathalie hadn’t been in much of a position to complain when Hawkmoth had left with her, but he assumed she *had* been more herself later, and the whole thing did seem out of character for someone who usually seemed allergic to taking sick leave.

“I don’t know about her but being Ladybug and dealing with everything in my own life has been pretty exhausting. If someone else gave me an excuse that got me all away from everything while making it not my fault I’d have been tempted to go along.”

“Are you saying you want Chat Noir to kidnap you?”

Marinette actually seemed to consider it, “That’s actually kind of tempting but I don’t think we should ruin your reputation like that.”

---

Marinette stopped him before they got to the school gate. “So did you want to go home this evening? Or do you need more time away? Because I think we need the full story of what’s

going on here before we decide anything."

---

Alya quirked her head in interest when they got into the room. "Both of you here together. And Marinette *on time.* I'm impressed. Did you pick her up on the way to school Adrien?"

He could have lied but he was sick of lies, so he admitted, "No, I stayed over at hers last night."

"*You what?"*

"Not like that!" His rushed to clarify, "Father and Nathalie are both ill and they didn't want me to catch what they had, so Nathalie asked Marinette's parents if I could stay there."

It was another lie, but at least it wasn't a totally new one. Only the same one they'd already told Marinette's parents.

"And you dad was ok with your spending the night at your girlfriend's house?" Nino asked, "Marinette, what magic powers do you *have*? Teach me please. I thought his father might ban him from dating and instead he's being allowed sleepovers."

Ironically Adrien did actually think Marinette's *literal* magic powers had something to do with it all. Since his father had worked out Marinette was Ladybug and he was dependent on her goodwill he'd have a very good reason to avoid annoying her.

"I've just been lucky I guess." She said.

"Alright. Don't teach me your secrets then." Then Nino's eyes narrowed, "Wait, did you say your dad and Nathalie were *both* ill?"

"Yeah?" Adrien said. He didn't think that was that odd. They were in the same room for most of the day, even if it was large, and even if Nathalie did go out at times. It seemed pretty plausible that if one of them was ill the other would be too.

Nino looked meaningfully at Alya.

"That does not count as substantive evidence." She said.

"Surely it counts as *some* sort of evidence?"

"Maybe. If it was a question I actually wanted to answer."

"Do I want to know what you're talking about?" Marinette asked.

"No." Alya said.

“What’s going on?” Adrien asked.

Instead of answering him Alya turned to Nino, “Are you going to tell me or am I?”

“You were the one who said *not* to tell him.”

Alya broke staring contest she was having with Nino. “Nino thinks your dad’s assistant has a thing for him.”

Adrien stared at Nino, trying to remember if he’d said anything to give him that impression, or whether his friend was just *way* more perceptive than he’d known, and if he was what that meant for his and Marinette’s secret identities, “How did you know that? You’ve barely met either of them.”

“Wait. It’s *true?*” Alya broke in, “Like, are they together, or did she tell you or *what?*”

“Why are you two so invested in this?”

“I’m not *invested,*” Nino said, “just kind of offended Alya was so dismissive of my theory when she’s supposed to be a journalist.”

“I’m trying to be a *better* journalist and confirm things before I accept them as true. When Lila told us about her compulsive lying disorder, it really made me think about how I need to go back to investigating things more instead of just reporting on them.”

Adrien was halfway glad to hear that Alya didn’t automatically trust everything Lila said anymore, and halfway concerned that an Alya who was re-committed to investigative journalism was a little too close for comfort to everything that was going on.

Still at the moment it was what *Nino* knew that was in question, “Again, why did you even *have* a theory?”

“Right, so obviously I’ve generally only met her when she’s chucking me out of your house?”

“Right?”

“But I swear she enjoys it.”

“I don’t think,” Adrien started to defend Nathalie, paused to wonder why he was defending Mayura, then remembered that she hasn’t hesitated to defend him, and decided to go ahead.

Nino had already taken advantage of his hesitation though, “So I assumed she was just a b,”

Adrien glared at him.

“Not nice person who got her kicks from bullying teenagers, but you were always like, 'oh she's not so bad, she's just doing what my father asks, she's nice really she helps with my homework, and helped convince him to let me go to school’ so I had to come up with another explanation.”

“And you came up with *that?”*

“It makes total sense! Either she totally inexplicably worships your dad so she enjoys doing stuff for him, *or* the reason she likes him is because they have the same opinions on everything and she also doesn’t want you to have friends.”

“I still don't understand how you even jumped to that idea.”

“Honestly? My cousin was over and she spent the whole evening complaining to me about how horrid her friend had got since she started dating some terrible guy and why do girls change themselves for awful boyfriends.”

Adrien made a concerted effort not to meet Marinette's eyes but Nino was weirdly right on the money if Nathalie had become Mayura for his father. Or for his father *and* his mother but he was still deliberately not thinking about that.

“I did tell him that maybe she just had a stressful job” Alya pointed out.

“She does.” Adrien pointed out.

Alya nodded, “And needed some way to take it out on someone.”

Marinette nodded, “I'm sorry Nino, but I agree with Alya. I think you're overthinking it.”

“Adrien just said I was right.”

“I don't know if she enjoys throwing you out of the house, but yeah my father relied on her a lot when my mother disappeared, and they've grown really close.”

“Hey,” Nino said patting his shoulder, “look on the bright side, at least she's a better option than Mayura.”

A look of realisation passed through Alya's eyes and he wondered if she just identified Nathalie as her argumentative commenter with the house IP address, “That whole thing must have been super awkward for them.”

“Yeah,” Adrien said, “yeah it was and yeah she is. I guess.”

Nino frowned, “That didn't really sound like you believed that. You know if things get bad at your house because she goes all evil stepmother or because your dad just continues to be a dick, then there's always space for you at mine. Even if I don't have all the attractions Marinette has.”

“You might have something better than a couch though.” Marinette said, “Not that we wouldn’t have you forever Adrien but I don't want to be responsible for you having a bad back once we’re old.”

Honestly Marinette’s couch was pretty low down on the list of things that Adrien thought were a threat to his health but, “That’s really nice of both of you but seriously I’ll be fine.”

“Are you sure?” Marinette met his eyes, and he wondered if their friends could notice hidden words the two of them weren’t saying.

“I have to be.” He told her. Paris was depending on him after all.

“Seriously,” Nino said, “Are you okay? You don’t *have* to be ok with whatever’s going on.”

Seeing Nino’s concerned face Adrien just wanted to be able to tell someone the truth. He had Marinette, and he was oh so glad that he had Marinette, but he wanted to be able to talk about everything with someone who wasn’t Ladybug. With someone who wasn’t going to have to decide what was going to happen to his family.

All of that was impossible though. He couldn’t tell them that he might have to be the one to condemn his mother to death, and maybe Nathalie too, and he supposed his father to prison as well, without admitting who he was.

Maybe he *could* tell them something though.

“There’s a lot going on.” He tried to carefully pick his words, “And Nathalie isn’t really the problem. I *like* Nathalie, and I’d be happy for them, but, well my father thinks he’s found some sort of lead on my mother.”

“Ouch.” Alya said, “That’s awkward.”

“Yeah,” he agreed, “but it’s not just that it’s that, I don’t think it’s the sort of lead that’s going to end up with her back with us alive, and if it’s *not* then I kind of wish he’d just left it alone and I’d never known.”

Marinette leaned over her desk to awkwardly hug him, and he let himself rest back into her arms. “Just remember it’s not your fault.”

“I’m sorry,” Nino said, “I wouldn’t have joked earlier if I knew. That really sucks.”

“It’s fine.” Adrien said, “You couldn’t have known, and it did kind of distract me a bit.”

“Well, I hope there’s nothing worse.”

Caught by a Chat Noir-like impulse Adrien went, “Actually,” and he felt Marinette tense up around him, but he supposed he did kind of deserve that after outing both of them to Hawkmoth.

“Wait,” he said to Alya, “This conversation is off the record right?”

“It can be?” She replied sounded confused.

“Promise me it is?”

“OK? I promise.”

“Honestly I’m dubious of the legality of some of his methods for finding her.”

“Seriously,” Nino said, “That offer of a place at mine is always open.”

“Thanks. I think legally I’d probably end up with Aunt Amélie if something happened with my father though.”

“In *London?*” Marinette said in a higher pitch than normal, “With *Felix?”*

“I mean I would much rather be in Paris with you guys, but Felix isn’t that bad.” Adrien tried to defend his cousin.

The other three all looked at him sceptically.

“Look, I know he made a bad first impression, and he can be a bit,” he hesitated, “abrasive but he was still grieving his dad then, that wasn’t just standard Felix behaviour.”

“But *London?*” Marinette asked, “Don’t you have any closer family?”

Adrien understood her dislike of the idea. The last thing he wanted was to lose Marinette too. He knew they could date long-distance and he could go on the Startrain every weekend he could but it wouldn’t be the same. Unfortunately, “Father doesn’t really speak about any of his family, so I’m not sure but I don’t think so.”

“It hurts my soul to say this.” Nino said, “but we really need your dad not to go to prison.”

“I hope so too.”

Marinette looked distinctly like she’s bitten into something and hadn’t been warned it was sour.

---

Ladybug and Chat Noir perched in the branches of one of the trees in the back garden. Adrien had thought it was a slightly less obvious approach than from the front.

Just as he was about to suggest they moved closer to the house the door opened and they watched his father and Nathalie walk out into the garden. He thought for a moment that maybe they’d been spotted by the security system and they’d come out to great them but it looked unlikely from how neither of the adults looked upwards to acknowledge them.

Nathalie, who was looked overly bundled on in a big coat given the temperate weather, seemed to be focusing on navigating the steps, and his father, who’d an arm wrapped round her in support, also seemed to be focused on getting her downwards safely.

Not for the first time he wondered how he’d missed all of this. He’d known they were closer than they used to be, and he’d known deep down something was wrong with Nathalie, but he’d let himself be distracted by his father’s denials and Nathalie’s reassurances.

When they got to the bench Nathalie sat down but after seeming to check she was ok, though even Chat Noir couldn't hear a *silent* conversation conducted mostly in glances and arm squeezes and caught very little more of spoken one than a murmured "be right back", his father left her there.

He was tempted to jump down and catch Nathalie alone, and see what she'd say, but that felt cruel and he didn't want to startle her.

If Marinette had had any of the same thoughts she didn't say anything.

Instead they waited and watched his father return with two cups of coffee. Honestly Adrien was kind of impressed he knew how to use the coffee machine. He'd always assumed that was solely Nathalie's domain.

As he passed one to Nathalie, and sat down next to her, she let her head fall against his shoulder, and his father usually one to flinch away from any physical contact from anyone other than Adrien and Maman allowed it.

Though of course he shouldn't have been surprised because he knew his father and Nathalie had done much more than just sit resting against each other. He'd *seen* them do much more than that. That had been as Hawkmoth and Mayura though, and even though he knew now that they were the same people he still couldn't replace them with his father and Nathalie in his mind. The image just looked ridiculous.

That was probably some sort of mental defence mechanism.

It just didn't seem like his father and Nathalie though, whereas what he was seeing in front of him *did* look like how his father and Nathalie might act in front of him if they were actually together.

His parents had always been affectionate, or at least his mother had been to everyone and she'd drawn that side out of his father so none of this was entirely new but watching his father's obvious concern as he watched Nathalie he found himself feeling slightly unmoored.

His father *did* care about him, Adrien knew that. He had stopped Mayura fighting him after all and they had been talking more recently, but he couldn't help but wish that some of these deep reserves of affection his father apparently had, that made him willing to terrorise Paris for his mother's sake, could actually be spent on *him.*

He moved and jumped to make his escape from the garden before he knew what he was doing.

"Are you okay?" Marinette asked for yet another time that day, when she landed beside him, and it was a testament to the sincerity in her voice that he felt touched rather than annoyed.

The confusing mass of emotions swirling around him coalesced as he came to the beginnings of a decision, "I'm not ready." Adrien said. "To go back. Going back means finding out the truth about my mother, and that means whether or not she can be saved is going to be up to us, and I'm not ready to kill Maman."

Marinette put a hand on his shoulder, “Look at me.”

He kept looking at the ground, and tried to not start hyperventilating.

“Look at me.” She said again and he looked up and was caught by the conviction in her eyes, “Whatever happens you haven’t killed her. Whatever curse she’s caught in did the damage. None of this is on you. If she can’t be saved she can’t be saved. And we don’t know that yet. We won’t until we talk to your father, but if we can’t save her it’s not your fault.”

He take a deep breath in, and then released it.

“OK. I’m OK. I think.”

“It’s up to you, we can go back in and confront them now or we can wait another day or two if you want. My parents are happy for have you, and honestly if your dad makes a fuss about it, mine is quite happy to stand his ground.”

“I don’t think we need to be worried about that. He knows he has to stay on your good side.”

Marinette looked unhappy at the reminder that his father knew her identity but all she said was, “It’s up to you then.”

Adrien looked back at the wall as if he could see through it and see his father and Nathalie. For all his mixed feelings he didn’t want to interrupt the peaceful scene he’d just seen.

“Maybe tomorrow.” He said. “And maybe we’ll phone then to announce we’re coming beforehand or something.”

Chapter End Notes

Guys I can't make Adrien having to grapple with his mother's life funny

# Chapter 10

Chapter Notes

> I am....super not happy with this chapter, and there's still decisions in it I second guess, but I'm also pretty sure I'm not going to improve it without a long time away from it so ¯_(ツ)_/¯

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Mademoiselle?” the Purple Butterfly Kwami asked nervously, from between where Plagg and Tikki were hugging him. “Are you my new master then?”

Adrien and Marinette looked at each other. He had a sinking feeling about what his father’s relationship with his kwami might have been like.

“I’m the Guardian,” Marinette explained, “I wanted to talk to you but I’m not going to be your permanent wielder. You probably won’t have one for a while. I hope that’s not a problem.”

Nooroo shook his head, “That sounds nice actually. I’d like to help a hero one day, but maybe not just yet.”

He looked around, “Did he give you the Peacock Miraculous too?”

“He did.” Adrien confirmed, “But we wanted to start by talking to you, before we talked to Duusu.”

Plagg muttered something that sounded distinctly like “For the sake of our eardrums,” and Adrien wondered exactly what the Peacock Kwami was like.

Nooroo curled in on himself, “I’m not sure if you should try and talk to Duusu. My master, my *former* master said he’d fixed Duusu’s Miraculous but Mlle. Nathalie didn’t seem to be getting any better.”

“The Peacock Miraculous was broken?” Marinette asked.

Adrien focused on the other fact, “It was her Miraculous that hurt her?”

“They hadn’t told you? Oh, he’s not going to be happy with me.” Nooroo flitted around the room, anxiously, “not happy at all.”

It had taken a while to calm Nooroo down. He'd seemed both scared of and worried for Adrien's father which, yeah honestly he *could* relate to that.

"I'm sorry." He said, "He sounds like he was a worse Miraculous Wielder than a Father. At least I was basically allowed anywhere in the house."

---

Eventually they did manage to get at least some of the story from him.

"So," Adrien asked uneasily, "he wasn't *making* Nathalie use the Peacock Miraculous then?"

Honestly he was starting to think maybe he *shouldn't* have discouraged Nathalie from resigning. Distance from his father might have been a good thing for her, even if both of them would have missed her.

---

"What do you mean *Duusu* suggested the whole staged kissing idea?" Adrien said.

"I think my master would have thought of it anyway. He'd come up with the idea of presenting Hawkmoth and Mayura as a couple to draw away attention, and he was talking to Mlle. Nathalie about how to establish that, when Duusu made the suggestion."

Plagg laughed, "That's genius. I wish I'd been able to convince this one to do that."

"We're not supposed to interfere in our wielder's lives." Tikki pointed out, "Although this time was possibly,"

"Justified?" Plagg suggested.

"It did worry me." Nooroo admitted, "I could feel their emotions as much as Duusu could, but my master's were…volatile."

---

"Do you think we'll be able to save my mother and Nathalie?" Adrien asked Marinette. "Does anything the Guardian gave you talk about a broken Miraculous?"

“If it was just fixing the Miraculous I think I’d be confident,” Marinette said, “But your Father’s already done that according to Nooroo. Nathalie. I think we could do *something* for her. I don’t know about the side-effects of a broken Miraculous specifically, but Master Fu *did* talk to me about the damage wielding a Miraculous could do. Your mother. I’m sorry Adrien. I don’t know. What you said to me,”

“It’s not clear that’s she’s actually alive? Yeah, I know.”

“I’m really sorry. I will do my best.”

“It’s not your fault.”

“But,”

“You’ve been telling me it’s not my fault constantly.”

“Because it’s not.”

“And if you can’t save her it’s not yours either. It might be my father’s or it might be her own, or it might be whoever broke the Miraculous but it’s not yours.”

---

His phone seemed to mock him as it sat there innocently on Marinette’s desk.

“I can call them if you want.” She said.

“No.” Adrien said, “Thanks for offering but he's my father. I have to be the one to do this.”

“We can wait a bit longer if you want.”

He ran his hands through his hair in a futile attempt to bleed off some nervous energy. “No, I mean I know they can't do much without any Miraculous and I'm *fairly* certain they’re not going to try to flee the country without me, but I don't think I want to wait any longer. I know we know some of it from the Kwarmis but I want to hear it from them. And I think I want to see my mother.”

Marinette wrapped an arm around him, “You’re being really brave about all this. I don't know if I could have handled this this well if it had been my parents.”

“It wouldn’t be your parents though,” Adrien tried to point out trying to imagine her father and mother dressed up as Hawkmoth and Mayura and failing completely, “Your parents are *normal.”*

“Yeah, I don't think my dad would use magic to become a Supervillain but,” Marinette clutched at her fringe, “I guess I don’t know *what* he’d do, in that situation.”

“I don’t know what I’m supposed to do in *this* situation. I always thought that if we defeated Hawkmoth and Mayura they’d go to prison and that’d be the end of it, but he’s my *father,* and Nathalie’s my,” he stumbled over their relationship again, “well, she’s important to me too, and they were doing it for my mother.”

“Look.” Marinette said, “Firstly we’re going to see your mother, and then we’re going to see what we can do for her, and do for Nathalie, and once we’re got into that, we can look into what sort of punishment or restitution she and your father should undertake.”

“Ok.” Adrien nodded. “I’m going to call them.”

He didn’t move for the phone.

“I am going to call them.”

This time he managed to make himself pick the phone up and ring the house.

It barely rang before being picked up.

“Adrien?” Nathalie asked, “Are you coming home?”

“I’m coming to talk. I don’t know about after that.”

“OK.” She sighed down the phoneline. “I can understand that. When did you want to come?”

“We can come over this evening.”

“OK. We’ll be there.”

“I’d hope so. I’d be concerned if Father decided to suddenly start leaving the house now.”

Nathalie was quiet.

“He’s *not* is he?”

“No. It’s just, he’s been visiting your mother a lot.”

“Saying his goodbyes?”

“Apologising I think. I don’t know, I’ve been letting him have his privacy.”

“But you think he’s alright? He’s not going to try and steal back his Miraculous is he?”

“No. I know you’ve no reason to trust me, but I really don’t think so.”

“Are *you* ok Nathalie?”

“I’m doing alright. I think all that rest did do me some good but don’t tell your father that.”

He might disagree with his father on a *lot* but if rest was what Nathalie needed to stop her ending up like his mother, then he didn't have any issues teaming up with him on that particular issue. Now wasn't the time for that though and anyway, "That's good to hear, but are you doing ok, you know *emotionally?*"

"I think I should be saying that to you."

"I'm ok." He told her.

"Are you?" Nathalie didn't really sound convinced. "This has been a lot for you to take in I know."

"I don't really know how I feel." He admitted. In some ways it was easier to admit that on the phone to Nathalie, than it was to anyone else. She at least wasn't able to judge him for caring for Paris' villains.

"We have that in common then, though I feel much better for having spoken to you."

"You do?"

"Of course I do. I was worried about you. I know all of this might make it hard for you to believe but I do care for you Adrien, I was worried you might never want to speak to us again, but I was worried *for* you too."

"Uh, yeah I know that you care about me. I mean Mayura's actions make a lot more sense now, even if I'm still struggling to make sense of the rest of it."

"It'd be stranger if you weren't."

Adrien didn't really know how to answer that. And he knew he should probably just bring the conversation to an end but, "Father isn't with you right now is he?"

"No. Did you want me to get him?"

"No!" Adrien said a little too loud, and then taking care to sound slightly calmer he asked, "Sorry, it's just, Nooroo said it was the Peacock Miraculous that hurt you right?"

"It was." Nathalie's tone was carefully neutral, and he recognised it from over the years when she was trying to give an answer but didn't know what he, or more usually his parents, actually wanted her to say to him.

"And it was that that," his voice wobbled but Marinette had been firm that the blame didn't lie with him, "almost killed Maman?"

"Yes."

"Do you really love Father that much that you'd risk death for him?" They'd asked Mayura why she'd help Hawkmoth but they hadn't known anything of the danger she'd put herself in then.

Nathalie was silent.

“Nathalie?”

“There wasn’t any other option. Not when I put it on first.”

“But you kept wearing it.”

“I told you I wanted to fix things.”

He waited for her to expand further but she didn’t.

“Alright, look, I’ll see you both soon.”

“See you soon.”

He put the phone down, and looked at Marinette, “I guess we’re going over there soon then.”

“Guess so.” She took his hand, and pulled him towards her and pressed a kiss to his lips. “You’re doing really well.”

---

They detransformed out of sight on a nearby street, and approached the gate, which opened without Adrien even pressing the button.

“They must have been watching for us,” He explained to Marinette’s confused look.

---

Nathalie opened the door for them, but his father was nowhere to be seen.

“He’s in the dining room waiting for you,” Nathalie said in response to his look around. “Welcome back Adrien, and welcome to you too Marinette. I can only wish it was under better circumstances.”

“That’s a change of tune,” Marinette said, before suddenly seeming to realise what she’d said and going, “I’m sorry, I didn’t mean,”

“It’s fine.” Nathalie dismissed it, “I’ve had much worse than that for doing my job. Come on.”

For all she’d said that she didn’t move herself, and then she shocked Adrien by hugging him. “I really am sorry for all of this.”

Adrien didn't really want to let go of her, but when she pulled away he let her.

"I'm sorry," She said again, seeming embarrassed at her show of emotion, "Let's go find your father."

---

They sat awkwardly looking at each other. He and Marinette sat on one side of the dining table, and his father and Nathalie on the other.

"So where did you want me to start?"

"At the beginning I guess." Adrien said, "Nooroo told us what he could, but he didn't know much about what happened to Maman."

"No he wouldn't. I rarely used his Miraculous until I lost her." Gabriel pressed his fingers to the bridge of his nose, "The beginning then. When I look back it seems like there's a lot of beginnings, but I suppose the best place to start was with our first trip to Tibet, when your mother first heard about The Missing Temple. She was fascinated by the idea of it. Her family was full of stories about magic, and they all believed in it, so where other people might have scoffed at the idea she had no issues believing it was a real place."

---

"If I'd known what was going to happen I'd have burnt all my research." Nathalie said, looking down at the table instead of meeting their eyes, "Sometimes I thought that if I ever got a chance to get the Rabbit Miraculous, I'd do that."

"You couldn't have known." His father pointed out.

"I should have known *something* world happen. No Miraculous Wielder has a normal life. All the rumours make that much clear."

"Emilie and I were *never* going to have a normal life anyway."

"Yeah," Adrien pointed out, "but there's kind of a difference between being famous and messing with magic you don't understand."

"We'd have found the Miraculous anyway," his father waved off his objection, "I don't mean to demean your contribution Nathalie, I'm sure if would have taken longer, but you know me better than to think I'd give up on something just because it was difficult."

"I know." Nathalie said, "The last few years have proved *that.*"

“Did you never even consider stopping? When you saw everything you’d done?” Adrien asked, unsure why he was lying himself out for more disappointment.

But his father surprised him. “Of course I did. I considered it multiple times. When you got hurt. The first time Nathalie used the Peacock Miraculous. Sometimes after a particularly embarrassing defeat.”

“But you didn't?” Marinette asked with more bravery than he could have mustered.

“I couldn't just abandon my wife. And stopping wouldn't have fixed anything that had happened. Winning was the only way to fix everything.”

---

“So she was *helping* people with the Peacock Miraculous?” Adrien *wanted* to believe that, to believe than his family wasn’t all villains, but, “That doesn’t make any sense, we didn’t hear about any superheroes in Paris back then.”

“They weren’t big events. Just little everyday things. Or so she told me then, now seeing how the Miraculous effected Nathalie comparatively I’ve wondered if she was using it for more than I knew of. But as far as I know she was mainly just testing it out. Finding strengths and weaknesses with each amok she created.”

“But, if it wasn’t for some big important thing, then why did she keep using it? Why did she leave us for that?”

That was what didn’t make any sense to Adrien. He’d been worried that he’d discover his image of his mother was entirely wrong. Just like his ideas of his father and Nathalie had been, but he *could* see the mother he remembered in the person his father painted, all except for the fact she’d kept using the Miraculous when it was killing her. That didn’t make sense at all.

It made much less sense than his Father and Nathalie being Hawkmoth and Mayura, which though he didn’t like to admit it, actually did seem to fit with their characters the more he thought on it.

His father shook his head, “I don’t know Adrien. I just don’t know. We argued over it a lot at the end, she always *did* have a dramatic streak, but she was more stubborn than you are.”

---

“M.Agreste?” Marinette asked, “Your wife *wanted* you to do all of this?”

“Not exactly. I promised her I’d save her, and she encouraged me to use the Butterfly Miraculous to locate your Miraculous Jewels to do so, but she wasn’t aware of how I ended up using it.”

“Didn’t you worry she’d be disappointed in you?”

His father looked at them as if he thought that was a stupid question, “She’d be alive. What would that matter?”

“Didn't you worry *I’d* be disappointed in you?” Adrien asked, even though he was unsure if he wanted to hear the answer. Neither that his father honestly thought what they were doing was so right Adrien would support them, nor that he just didn’t care would make him feel better.

Instead his father said, “I knew you would be. The amount of Ladybug memorabilia you bought made that clear. Why do you think I never told you?”

Marinette mouthed, “Ladybug memorabilia?” to him.

A hint of a smile ghosted over Nathalie’s lips, “I’m sure Adrien would love to show you his collection. I hope you don't have any issues with statues of yourself.”

“Statues?

“*Nathalie.”* Adrien complained, “They’re *miniatures.* You're making it sound like I was going to put up a statue of Ladybug in the garden next to Maman's and I would never do that without us actually being together.”

Marinette's eyes widened impossibly, “I feel so much less embarrassed about my room now.”

Nathalie looked between them, “Really?” She said to Marinette, “You too? I thought Adrien got it from his father, is this a thing people do now?”

Adrien didn’t understand what her issue was, “Don’t you have pictures up of people you care about in your apartment?”

She didn’t in her room here, but that made sense, given that until she’d started getting ill she’d rarely used it.

“Not really, but, Adrien, there’s a difference between having a few photos of your friends and family and, you know a *shrine.* Though I guess you and Marinette get a pass given your age.”

His father’s head turned to look at Nathalie, “You know why we had to keep Emilie where she was.”

“I wasn’t talking about the repository sir.” She shook her head, “We’re getting off topic anyway. We did consider telling you Adrien. I even thought your father was going to once, but he changed his mind at the last minute.”

That did surprise him. His father keeping it from him didn't seem that strange, but he had to wonder about why Nathalie had wanted to tell him. "Did you *not* think I'd be disappointed?"

"I didn't think you'd approve, but I thought it would be worse if you found out another way, and well I thought you'd understand *why* we were doing it."

That was the thing. Adrien wasn't sure if he did or not. He could understand wanting to save his mother's life, and he could even understand not giving up when traditional medicine didn't work and turning to a Miraculous to try and save her but, "I don't know. I mean I understand *why* you were doing it, but I don't know if I can approve. I know Ladybug always fixed everything but, do you understand the cost your victory would have had if we'd made the wish?"

The adults both glanced at each other guiltily.

"There's a lot of room in the idea of keeping balance in the universe," his father began.

Nathalie interrupted him, "I hoped we'd be able to control it."

"How?" asked Marinette eagerly, "Did you know some way to have them grant wishes without repercussions?"

"No, but." Nathalie looked down at the table, "I couldn't see any reason why the Wielder couldn't essentially offer the cost of bringing Emilie back willingly."

"Oh." Escaped from Marinette's mouth.

Unlike his girlfriend Adrien didn't think he quite got Nathalie's point, "Are you saying you thought you could *choose* someone to be the cost?"

Nathalie nodded.

"But I don't understand," He said, "Why would that help?"

Marinette took his hand, "Adrien, I think she was saying she could chose herself."

He felt dread crawl down his spine, "Nathalie?"

"Yes." She admitted tightly. "That was the idea."

"But, *why*?" He asked, as that conversation they'd had with Mayura suddenly loomed crystal clear in his mind, "I know you felt guilty, but were you really planning to kill yourself to bring my mother back?" He echoed his earlier question to her again, "Do you really love my father that much?"

"The why doesn't matter. It was the obvious solution. I was going to die anyway if I kept using the Peacock Miraculous."

His father finally spoke, "But I fixed that." He turned in his seat so he was facing Nathalie straight on, "You weren't going to die. I know you're not getting better but you're not getting

worse anymore either. I don't understand how you thought any of this was obvious."

"I know you'd have done anything for her," Nathalie said, "I wasn't going to let you become a murderer for her sake."

"And I'd be less of one in this scenario because I'd not pulled the trigger myself? Nathalie do you even hear yourself. Why on earth didn't you mention all of this when we spoke before?"

"Because you had to decide what you wanted yourself." She snapped, "I wanted you to stop after we found out about Adrien because I knew he might not give us his Miraculous, but it had to be *your* decision for *your* family's sake. Maybe Adrien's if you chose to let him decide but I wasn't going to try and stop you for *my* sake and have you blame me for it the whole time after. Like you said, you've considered giving up before and not gone through with it. I wasn't going to chance you'd regret giving up this time too."

"What part of the last week exactly made you think that *your death* wouldn't be relevant information for me to make my decision? Was there a single scenario we considered about our future that included you dying?"

Nathalie threw her hands up in the air, "I didn't think Adrien would let us do it anyway. Once it became clear you weren't going to steal his Miraculous I assumed that if they saved Emilie it would probably be with some knowledge we didn't have, so the results of using the Combined Miraculous didn't seem worth bringing up."

"What?"

"Uh," Adrien interrupted, "I just wanted to say that I definitely would not have let you do that." It felt very important she knew that. Of course he wanted his mother back if there was a way to do that that *didn't* include killing someone, but he didn't want her back like that. "Um. Did you actually think he might steal my Miraculous?"

His father ignored his interjection, "You thought *Adrien* wouldn't allow you but *I* would? God, Nathalie, how long have you been hiding this from me?"

This time Nathalie ignored his father, "Adrien, you've seen what we've done. If you'd told me he'd discovered who Ladybug and Chat Noir were, even if it was you, I'd have thought if he saw a way to take your Miraculouses without you knowing then yes he would have done it. But he didn't." Nathalie looked like she didn't quite believe what she was saying, "All that time I was ill, he knew you were Chat Noir, and at some point he worked out Marinette was Ladybug and he didn't do anything. "

Adrien wasn't quite sure that earned his father the credit Nathalie thought it did, but then she *had* been Mayura so it wasn't surprisingly their morality didn't exactly align.

"That why I didn't say anything Gabriel," She took his father's hand, "You were changing your mind because of *Adrien* and his happiness and *that's* why I wanted you to make any decision."

His father's other hand went up to cradle her face, "We're talking about this later when we're alone. This conversation isn't over."

The two adults stared into each other's eyes, then his father said, "I know," and released her and looked back at them.

"Is there a way to save Emilie without using the combined Miraculous?" He asked Marinette.

Marinette didn't meet his eyes, "I'd have to see her, but what from Adrien's said to me, I think it might be too late for anything."

"Can we see her?" Adrien asked, "Where is this repository?"

His father stood up. "Of course. I'll take you both there."

---

They stopped in front of his mother's portrait in the Atelier.

"Come here Adrien," his father said pointing to a stop on the floor, "Nathalie will you bring Marinette down?"

"Of course." She said.

His father reached out and pressed against the portrait. Adrien wasn't sure what he expected, but it wasn't for a circle of the floor around his feet to light up. Then his father joined him on the circle and suddenly they were moving down.

Marinette took a step towards them but Nathalie put a hand on her shoulder.

"It's fine," he saw say just before they lost sight of them, "It's perfectly safe."

"I just think maybe I should have gone with Adrien." Marinette's voice echoed down the pipe.

"It's a fast ride. We won't be waiting long." Nathalie reassured her.

He thought maybe that they'd gone too far to hear them, but then Marinette said, "Mlle. Sancoeur? Given you were ready to die for him, I think you could have photos of him in your apartment if you wanted. I don't think he'd mind."

They faintly heard Nathalie's response.

"Why would I want photos of him in my apartment? I see him nearly every day."

---

“This was under the house the whole time?” Adrien marvelled at the huge room the lift opened out to. It was too dark to make out all of it, but at the other end of the room an impossible beam of sunlight illuminated a green platform that almost seemed to glow. In the middle was something shining, “Is that her?”

“That’s her.” His father confirmed, and squeezed his shoulder.

Adrien didn’t have the time to wonder at the unusual reassurance before he found himself running towards his mother.

He felt a lump in his throat when he got close enough to make her out through the reflection of the glass. She looked like she was sleeping, and none of this seemed real.

Putting his hand out to the glass he found it cold, “Maman?”

He turned back to his father when he heard his footsteps behind him, “Can she hear us do you think? They say you should talk to people in a coma don’t they?”

“She’s a little bit more far gone than that.”

Tears started to well up in his eyes, “Why did you never tell me?”

His father opened his mouth to speak, but Adrien didn’t let him, “I know you didn’t trust me about Hawkmoth but didn’t you think I deserved to know what was happening to my mother? To know she was lying here under my home? That you were keeping her like this?”

“Adrien,” his father sighed but didn’t say anything more, or if he did Adrien couldn’t hear him over his own sobbing. He took a step back away from his mother’s casket, and almost tripped over but his father caught him, and then pulled him into a hug.

“You’re right.” He said. “We should have told you. It might all have been very different if we had.”

“Adrien?” Marinette’s voice rang out, and he could hear her running along the catwalk.

She reached out to him but he shook his head, “Can you do what you need to do?”

Marinette still looked unsure but then she straightened up, and went determinedly to the casket, letting Tikki out of her bag, and her Kwami buzzed around it seeming equally focused on the situation.

She also pulled out several antique looking instruments Adrien assumed were Guardian-related.

“Does this open?” She asked.

“Only for.a short amount of time," His father says, “The atmosphere has to stay undisturbed to keep her in stasis.”

“Right.” Marinette said.

---

Eventually Marinette looked up from her work and shook her head.

His father’s grip on him tightened for a second before releasing.

Adrien expected to feel more at this confirmation his mother *was* dead but instead he just felt empty as if he’d cried everything out while she’d been working.

Chapter End Notes

Alt Ending:

Eventually Marinette looked up from her work and nodded, "We can save her."

# Chapter 11

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adrien tried to get to sleep, he really did, but he couldn't stop thinking about his mother in that casket below him.

It had been easier to, not forget, but at least not constantly think about it at Marinette's house but he couldn't stay there indefinitely.

He'd thought about taking Nino up on his offer and going there next but he had had to go back to the house *some* time.

This had been too early though.

"You're never going to get to sleep if you keep moving like that." Plagg said.

"I know, but every time I almost fall asleep I just remember that she's *down there.*" His voice wavered on the last two words and he had to swallow a sob.

"I should have stayed at Marinette's. Or I don't know. Done anything but came back here."

Plagg brushed up against Adrien's check, and he realised he was pushing away a tear, "Wait here kid."

Adrien watched his Kwami phase through the wall and wondered where he was going. That was the wrong way to go if he was planning to leave the house.

After a few minutes there was a knock on his door.

"Come in?" Adrien ventured, sitting up in the bed.

His father opened it, "Plagg said you having trouble sleeping."

"I just keep thinking of her down there alone in that glass coffin. Not alive but not dead either."

"Adrien," he said sitting down on the bed next to him, "I know it's difficult. It's the same for me."

"It's not though," he pointed out, "you knew she was there the whole time, you *put* her there, you" He got distracted by how his father's hand had gone to his ear, "what happened to your ear?"

His father glared at Plagg, "Your kwami bit it to wake me up. Could you turn the light on, I can't tell if it's bleeding or if it's just his saliva."

"*Plagg."* Adrien reprimanded him as him switched his bedside lamp on. In the light it gave off he could see his father's eyes were rimmed in red. He hadn't been lying about having a bad night at least.

"Hey," Plagg said, "I was doing you a favour. And reminding him of his responsibilities."

His father didn't let down on the daggers in his eyes but once he'd ascertained his ear wasn't bleeding he reached over and hugged Adrien. "I'm sorry. You're not wrong."

"Finally." Plagg said, "I only got you because I'm too small to do that. And to make things more fair."

"Fair?" His father asked.

"You made him give up his shoulder to cry on for tonight, it's not very fair for you to get to curl up with yours."

"Nathalie said Marinette's parents were responsible. Surely they didn't let Adrien?"

"Why I should tell you? It's not as if *you're* a responsible parent is it?"

"You've sadly been proven right on that, but perhaps we could come to an agreement on information sharing?" His father said, "Adrien's simultaneously too old and too young to be sharing a bed with a girl."

"I slept on their couch." Adrien offered, "If that's what you're asking."

"Oh thank god."

Adrien didn't make any further comment at first, content to let himself relax in the reassurance that he *did* at least have one parent still.

Eventually though he had to ask, "Does it not bother you? Are you just able to forget she's there because you have Nathalie?"

"Forget?" His father asked, the incredulity clear in his tone, "Adrien if I was able to forget she was there I would have given up Hawkmoth long ago. No, I can never forget she's there. That's why nothing *has* happened between myself and Nathalie."

Now it was Adrien's turn to look incredulous, "I literally saw you make out on Eiffel Tower."

"As a *performance*."

"It looked pretty real to me."

"Don't be inappropriate."

"Do you *not* like her like that? Because she was literally willing to die to bring Maman back, so if that's the case I think the best thing you can do for her is give her a job elsewhere in the company, or give her a big payoff to leave or something."

“I’m not sending her away.” He snapped in affront.

Adrien tried to turn a judgemental look on him.

“She’s,” He stalled, “very important to me, and *yes,* I have to talk to her more about what she said that night.”

“You *haven’t?* Father, you can’t just not talk about it.”

“Nathalie’s really the one you need to say that to, but there’s been a lot going on, and a lot to deal with, and Nathalie knows, *we* know, that whatever our future is we want to go through it together but, with the situation with your mother neither of us feel comfortable acting on that. So no. Nothing’s happened.”

“Oh.” Adrien said, “You weren’t lying then earlier. When you said you couldn’t forget she was down there either?”

“No,” his father swallowed, “You’re right that I put her there, and that means that *I’m* the one that failed to bring her back too. So I don’t think I’m ever going to forget that.”

“I’m the one that stopped you combining my Miraculous with Ladybug’s though. Well, Ladybug did too but that’s not really the same is it?”

“Adrien. Nathalie wasn’t wrong. I might not have admitted it to myself but when I gave you my Miraculous and hers I knew that was the end of it for her. I could have acted on the fact I knew who Ladybug and Chat Noir were to save her and you would have been unable to stop me, and I didn’t.”

“I’m glad you didn’t.” Adrien could feel the tears threatening to spill out of his eyes again, “that sounds terrible doesn’t it? What sort of son wants his mother dead?”

“I don’t think you do. You just aren’t ready to risk losing someone else too. I can understand that better now that I know what Nathalie was planning.”

“Do you ever wish that she’d died in some normal way, and you’d never had any chance to bring her back?”

He gave a bitter laugh. “All the time.”

“It’d be easier wouldn’t it?”

“It would be. And, then I wouldn’t have endangered you and Nathalie, and maybe I wouldn’t have, well, I’ve neglected you haven’t I?”

“Hey,” Nathalie said from the doorway, “What are you two still doing awake?”

“Sorry,” his father said, “Did I wake you? I tried not to disturb you when I left. Adrien’s Kwami woke me.”

While Adrien tried to work out how apparently his father could simultaneously claim nothing was happening with Nathalie and share a bed with her, Plagg flew over to her, "*Someone* had to make him parent his son."

"You're right." Nathalie said and reached out absentmindingly brushing Plagg's neck with her finger, "We should have checked on Adrien."

Plagg made a purring sound, and she seemed to realise what she was doing. "I'm sorry." She said, "I wasn't thinking. I'm used to Duusu."

"No, keep doing that."

She gave him two more strokes but then came over and sat down next to the two of them. In the light he could see a damp patch on the upper right side of her pyjama shirt and he realised that Plagg had been talking *literally* when he'd spoken about a shoulder to cry on. Or slightly lower than she shoulder actually.

She wrapped an arm round both of them, "Are you ok, Adrien?"

"It's just knowing she's *there.* I don't know if I can sleep here."

"Ah." She looked past him at his father, "Did you talk you him about?"

"Not yet."

"Talk to me about what?"

"Burying your mother."

"Yeah, we should do that, but that doesn't change things now does it?"

"Hey," Nathalie said, "We'll get through tonight and then we'll find some alternative for you."

"We can't send Adrien around different friend's houses indefinitely. Think of how it would look."

"No, I guess," Nathalie sounded uncertain, "There's my apartment, he could stay with me for a while. I suppose he'd have to come back here between when his school day finishes and I leave work but, it'd be something. I mean, if you'd like that Adrien?"

He thought he could *maybe* manage to be here during the day, and he *did* want to go down and say goodbye to his mother properly but, "Father won't do anything stupid will he? If we leave him here alone?"

Nathalie didn't seem to be much of a mitigating influence on his father herself given she'd gone along with him being Hawkmoth, but Adrien thought the fact it would be hard for him to forget he'd hurt her, and almost got her killed doing it would at least act as *some* sort of restraint on his father's actions.

“Why am I being left alone?” His father said.

“Gabriel you couldn’t come. How would *that* look?”

“I don’t see why you apparently taking custody of Adrien would look better.”

“We’d have a better chance of sneaking that under the radar at least. After everything with Mayura the press is going to be following your every move.”

“It would *distract* them from everything with Mayura.”

“Um, if you’re planning the same sort of distraction you did last time please let me know in advance so I don’t end up watching it this time.” Adrien interrupted.

“We’ll talk about it in the morning.” Nathalie said, “The important thing right now is Adrien. Do you think you will be able to sleep here tonight Adrien, or should I book a hotel room?”

“I think I can stay here tonight, but, can you two stay with me?”

He could feel Nathalie seeking his father’s permission, but in the end she said, “If you want.”

As they settled themselves down Adrien *did* feel better but, “What if it doesn’t get any better? What if I’m haunted by her every night?”

“We just have to deal with it I suppose.” His father said, “Though we could try moving I suppose.”

“Out of Paris?”

“Tempting. But I’d assume you’d prefer to stay here.”

Adrien was torn on that. On the one hand Paris was where he’d lost his mother, and where he’d unwittingly fought his father. On the other hand Paris was where Marinette was, and the rest of his friends too.

“I think so.” He decided.

“It would be easier. Logistically. To stay in Paris,” Nathalie offered, “It’d take time though- we’d have to regularise the house before you could sell it.”

“Yeah, I don’t think you’d want the basement lair to become common knowledge.”

“The basement isn’t the lair.” His father said.

“*What?*” Adrien said, “Are you saying you’ve *another* secret room? *Where*?”

“The attic.”

“You said that was structurally unsafe and you’d blocked off the entrance.”

“I did block off that one, yes.”

“You’re showing me this tomorrow.”

“Alright.”

---

Nathalie’s breathing evened out shockingly quickly.

“Is she asleep already?” he asked his father as quietly as he could.

“Don’t wake her up.” His father whispered, “But yes, she seems to fall asleep immediately. I don’t know how she does it. She literally fell asleep in a closet after a fashion show once.”

---

“I’ve changed my mind about Nathalie,” Plagg announced at breakfast, “She’s allowed to get away with it. Your father’s still on thin ice.”

“Why?” Adrien asked, as his kwami disappeared into the fridge.

Plagg reappeared with what Adrien assumed was camembert though he didn’t recognise the packaging.

“There’s more expensive camembert out there.” Plagg said, “You’ve been holding out on me. Also she showed me a website of other artisan cheeses and told me to let her know my order.”

When Nathalie had even had time to order Plagg cheese he didn’t know but, “OK, so in my defence I only get a certain amount of transferred to my account for spending money each month, and Nathalie has control of my father’s credit card.”

“And you spent money on Ladybug memorabilia instead of cheese? Not good. Honestly I always avoided Duusu because that’s a kwami with just too much….energy,” Plagg made energy sound like a swear word, “But with everything I’m hearing and seeing I’m starting to think that was a mistake.”

---

Technically Adrien probably should let them know he was leaving now to meet Marinette and then the others to hang out *but* he didn't really want to interrupt his Father and Nathalie

based on the raised voices coming out from the Atelier, and it wasn't as if he hadn't informed them earlier that he was going out.

Fragments came through the door, "Not the point", "Should be grateful", "think that.", "Emilie,"

He wasn't sure if he wished he could hear all of it or not.

Then suddenly there was silence followed by a clattering and Adrien was kind of worried and about to open the door, until he heard Nathalie go "Gabriel, those were my files for next week. I had them alphabetised." In a tone that didn't sound very upset at all.

He decided he didn't need to let them know he was going after all.

---

Marinette gave him a quick peck on the lips when he arrived.

"How's it going?" She asked.

"They were arguing when I left."

"Are you ok?"

"Honestly I'm kind of relieved." Adrien admitted, "Not that they're arguing exactly, but that Nathalie's actually disagreeing with him over something. I was kind of worried at how she always seemed to put him first you know? I don't think that's healthy."

"No, I don't think it is."

"I mean, she was willing to *die* for him? Who does that? I don't know. It makes me feel selfish for wanting her there, instead of trying to convince her to leave."

Marinette was looking at him oddly. "Um, Kitty? You do that for me."

"My lady, that's not the *same.*"

"Why not?"

"It's not premeditated. I don't *plan* to. And I know you can always bring me back. And it's necessary, if we lose you we're screwed, but you can win without me."

"Have you ever thought that maybe *I don't want to?* I've told you how I feel about you making the sacrifice play all the time, And you keep doing it. I *know* I'm the one who has to save it all in the end but do you know how tough that is? I wouldn't be able to keep doing it without you."

“Marinette,” he took her hand, “I’m not abandoning you. I would never want to do that. Whatever I do I’m doing it because I want to protect you.”

“I know, but I want you to think about protecting yourself too. You never wait to think if there’s another way to do things,”

“I,”

“No let me finish. Look at your mother, look at Nathalie, they must have thought that were doing important things too, but one of them killed herself for it and the other one almost did, and look at how that’s made *you* feel. Don't do that to me.

Adrien hadn’t thought of it that way *at all.* He’d just been putting Ladybug ahead of himself because objectively she *was* more important, but if that made it him the *Nathalie* in this relationship then he suddenly understood how difficult his actions could be for her.

While he was still trying to formulate a response Marinette pulled him in and kissed him desperately her hands clutching his coat, and he let himself return it just as frantically. She was right. He *hadn’t* realised what he was doing to her and he was never going to let himself do that to her for as long as he had a choice.

“I won’t.” He told her. “I’m not going to abandon you, I don’t understand why Maman did, and Nathalie shouldn’t have thought what she was going to do was OK either, but I’m going to learn from their mistakes. I’m going to do *better.*”

---

Nino stood in the queue with Adrien to get ice cream while the girls chatted back on the picnic rug they’d brought to the park, “Hey, I wanted to message you but I couldn’t think of the right words to say, which is kind of rubbish of me but, did anything come of that lead your dad thought he’d found about your maman?”

“She’s dead.” Adrien told him looking down at the ground. It felt freeing to finally say it. It might not be technically true while she was still on what he and Marinette had decided to call magical life support, but it was the real truth. She was never going to wake up, but more than that she couldn’t even survive in a coma outside of that pod. When neither of them had thought he could hear them he’d heard Tikki reassuring Marinette that she couldn’t have done anything, that *she,* the Kwami of creation, hadn’t been able to find any signs of life.

“I’m sorry.” Nino put his hand on Adrien’s shoulder, “Do you want to talk about it?”

“No,” He looked up and met his friend’s eyes, “thanks, but not yet.”

He’d been tempted but the idea of having to present an edited version of what had happened sounded exhausting.

“Do you want me to tell Alya?”

“I don’t know. If it looks like she’s going to say something then if you could interfere that’d be great but I don’t know if I’m ready for everyone to know yet. And, I don’t know if my father’s ready. He might want to wait to announce it until we’ve got the,” his voice broke on his lie, “body.”

“Dude come here,” Nino said, and pulled him into a hug, “It’s going to be ok. And if there’s *anything* I can do to help let me know.”

“Yeah, I will.”

Nino let go of him, “How are things with your dad?”

“OK actually. I mean as much as they can be in the circumstances you know? But we’re talking more, and he’s not pushing me away this time, so that’s *something* I guess?”

“And whatever shady stuff he did to find her? That’s not going to be a problem?”

Adrien couldn’t stop his gaze sliding over to where Alya and Marinette were sitting, “Hopefully not.”

In all the revelations he and Marinette hadn’t really talked about what sort of punishment his father and Nathalie deserved.

And the thing was Adrien *was* still angry at them, but he didn’t want to lose them more than he wanted to see them get what they deserved, which probably wasn’t a very heroic thing for Chat Noir to think but they were his *family.*

He had to talk to Marinette. Even if he didn’t want to.

---

They caught the end of the girls’ conversation when they got back with the ice cream.

“You’re allowed to be selfish sometimes.” Alya said, “Don’t go full-on Chloé on me now but you’re *always* doing things for other people. You’re allowed to do things for yourself sometimes too. So long as this whole selfish secret you can’t talk about isn’t about Chat Noir.”

“Why would it have anything to do with Chat Noir?” Marinette asked and Adrien was proud of how she managed to almost keep her voice at its normal pitch.

“Yeah Alya,” He passed Marinette her ice cream, “What am I hearing about Chat Noir?”

“Um, nothing,” Alya squeaked.

“That kind of didn’t sound like nothing.” He said. If the Ladyblogger knew that something was up with Chat Noir then Adrien needed to know. All his thoughts about his father and

Nathalie and justice were pointless if Alya had worked it all out and was going to expose it to the world.

“Marinette,” Alya implored.

“What?”

Alya looked at Adrien and then back to Marinette, “You *have* to tell him.”

“I have no idea what you’re talking about.”

“Um, Alya?” Nino interrupted, “Whatever this is this might not be a good time for it.”

Alya ignored him, digging through her bag onehanded while she held her ice cream in the other, for her phone. She flicked through it and passed it to Marinette, “*this.”*

Alya was trying to shield the phone, but spying over his girlfriend’s shoulder he saw a photo of Chat Noir climbing into Marinette’s window. Whether it was after he’d gone back to look at his house alone, or just that the photographer had caught him and not Ladybug, he didn’t know.

“Did you take this?” Marinette asked sounding vaguely offended, and honestly Adrien agreed. Alya shouldn’t spy on her friends for her scoop.

“No,” said Alya, “Some random person spotted him, and released the photo on the internet. That’s why I wanted *you* to be the one to tell Adrien before he saw it I know you said you and Chat Noir are sort of friends but,”

“Alya.” Marinette stopped her, “Adrien *knows*. He’s was staying at my house while his father and Nathalie are ill remember?”

“Oh.” Alya said.

“Yeah,” Adrien realised he should try and clear things up, “Chat Noir’s a mutual friend. He’s basically the one who got me and Marinette together.”

“What?” Nino went flatly, “Alya and I have been trying for *ages* to get you and Marinette together and *Chat Noir* was the one who actually succeeded?”

“What?” Adrien asked, “When did you two try and get Marinette and I together?”

The other three groaned.

“That does answer the question of whether Adrien was truly that oblivious or just trying to be nice.” Alya said, confusing him even further.

“I told you,” Nino said, “All that homeschooling stunted his social growth. This is what happens when Chloé’s your only link to the outside world.”

“I don’t understand. What did I miss?”

“Adrien,” Marinette said, “I’ve liked you for ages. That was why I was always so nervous around you.”

*What.* But. Then. “Wait, it was *me* you liked the whole time? *I* was the other boy? *What.”*

Marinette slowly nodded.

“But. *What.* Oh my god.” He suddenly realised, “I’m like my father.”

Not *as* bad, and in a much better situation, and at least he’d never endangered Marinette to save Ladybug, but actually maybe things had been better when he thought he was the Nathalie in this relationship.

Although if Marinette wanted to make out with him in public for the paparazzi to prove that she wasn’t dating Chat Noir he wouldn’t have a problem with that.

If she *wanted* to make this a public that that was. That was another thing they had to talk about. *And* about not getting caught coming in her window.

“I mean, you’re a lot better than your father.”

“I am so lost right now.” Nino said.

“Chat Noir told me Marinette didn’t like him because she liked someone else *and it was me the whole time. What.*”

Alya’s brows knit in thought, “So *he* does like Marinette? But then he decided to set you two up instead?”

“Something like that.”

“I’m not sure I’d exactly say Chat Noir got us together,” Marinette said, “If anything he sort of almost messed things up.”

“I think *I* was the one to sort of mess things up, but Chat Noir *did* try to get us together.”

“Technically I guess your father was responsible for getting us together.”

Technically Adrien had been the one to drop his transformation and then finally realise Marinette was Ladybug but, “Yeah, he did kind of expose me didn’t he?”

“This sounds like a different story to the one you told us where Adrien felt so bad about rejecting you he realised he’d made a mistake and ran to your house to apologise.”

“That version of the story was less embarrassing.” Adrien claimed.

“Right.” Said Alya but she looked unconvinced, “So just to clarify, you two are together, and Chat Noir is just a mutual friend?”

Nino gave her an odd look which Adrien didn’t understand but Marinette said, “Yes, exactly.”

“OK,” Alya said looking between them, “OK.”

---

After the others had left Adrien forced himself to ask what he had to, “I know they’re villains and they’ve done bad things, and we *should* do something about that, but could we leave that off until we’ve had a chance to lay my mother to rest?”

Marinette looked at him, “Of course we can. I feel bad enough I couldn’t do anything for your mother. I wasn’t going to rob you of your chance to say goodbye.”

“Thank you,” Adrien said, trying to put as much feeling into it as possible, “You’re such a good person you know? I wish I could be like you.”

“You’re a good person.”

“I don’t know that I am.” He’d *enjoyed* being Chat Noir for the fun of it, as much as he’d been proud of being able to save the city, *and* he kind of wanted to prevent Hawkmoth and Mayura coming to any real justice so he obviously wasn’t a great person.

“I mean you’ve never shoved Lila down a flight of stairs.”

“Neither have you. She made that up.”

“Yeah, but sometimes I wish I’d actually done it if I was going to get in all that trouble for it. She’s just so,” Marinette gave up on words, “urgh.”

This was a new side to Marinette he hadn’t seen before, and he was almost reassured by seeing it and realising she was a person and not some perfect icon but, “I didn’t realise you were still that upset over it.”

“I know Ladybug *shouldn’t* be, but she’s just *such* a liar. Sometimes I think she’s a sociopath or something.”

“Really?” Adrien asked suddenly forced to reassess what he thought was going on being Marinette and Lila, “I mean I know she’s a liar but I thought she was just lonely and wanted friends. It must be hard moving around for her mother’s job all the time.”

“I guess I hadn’t thought about it like that.” Marinette said, “maybe I could have some sympathy for her if she hadn’t been ready to get me expelled.”

“Yeah, I kind of wish she’d find her own friends so she could just stop being so,”

“Yeah” Marinette interjected, “Couldn’t your dad make her a catwalk model or something? That would keep her busy.”

“She’s too young. Maybe in a year or two if she gets growing.”

“Pity we couldn’t set her up with Felix.”

Adrien wasn’t really sure where Marinette was going with that, “I mean, he’s in London, and I also think he *might* have something with some girl called Bridget. Or possibly Bridge. I don’t know. English people names are weird.”

“*Felix* has a girlfriend?”

“I don’t think so? But I’ve been trying to message him more because I felt bad about not being there for his dad’s funeral, and he complains about her a lot.”

“Where are you getting that he likes her from *that?*”

“I think she’s maybe dating some guy called David now? It’s honestly kind of unclear but Felix keeps messaging me saying that this other guy is taking advantage, and how do I keep, actually it’s you he keeps using in his examples, did *Felix* know you liked me somehow?”

“Anyway,” Marinette said, “Talking of your father and Nathalie I’ve been looking into this thing called restorative justice. I think maybe we could work something out.”

Chapter End Notes

how do you finish a story when your joke ran out like 3 chapters ago, but actually healing the characters will take years? Asking for a friend. (It's me. I'm the friend)

# Chapter 12

Chapter Notes

Well, Shusu did ask for Amélie

“I don’t know,” Adrien said, “Father and Nathalie definitely *should* have to make amends, and I like your idea of tailoring it to the people they akumatised but, even ignoring whether Paris would accept it if we tried to do something like that officially, *and* even if you were comfortable given them back their Miraculouses to wear, I don’t think Father’s very good at apologising?”

“Seriously?”

“You’re met him. He’s, you know, abrupt.”

Marinette frowned prettily, “I thought that was because he wanted to upset people to akumatise them? Which was a stupid plan because it put himself, and *you* and Nathalie in danger but,”

“It may have got worse because of that? I thought the change was Maman’s absence? But he was still himself before. He just made more time for him.”

“But, how did he become so successful then? If he was offending people left and right then surely no one in the fashion world would have wanted to work with him?”

“He’s can be polite. And from what I’ve heard he can be pretty good at convincing people to do things, or buy things when he wants to be. But also a lot of that was back before he could refuse to leave the house so I guess he was better at people then?”

“This isn’t going to work is it?” Marinette buried her head in her hands, “I thought maybe I had a way we could justify keeping their identities secret.”

“We could talk to them I guess?”

---

“So,” his father said, “What did you want to discuss?”

The doorbell rang, and Nathalie immediately reached for her tablet to see who was at the gate.  From how her grip on it tightened it wasn't anyone good, and Adrien had visions of the police or journalists at the gate before she said, "It's Amélie."

Adrien waited for some further explanation. He hadn't known his Aunt was coming last time either, yet Nathalie didn't look like she'd just forgotten an arranged visit, but it didn't make any sense for Aunt Amélie not to call ahead if she was coming all the way from London to visit them.

His father mirrored Adrien's own confusion, "We weren't expecting her were we?"

"No. We weren't." Nathalie confirmed, her lips pursed in concern.

The four of them all looked at each other. He knew his Aunt deserved to know the truth about her sister but they'd barely started discussing the logistics of putting his mother to rest, and how and when they'd tell people.

They weren't ready to confront her *now*.

"We could pretend we're not in." His father suggested.

Nathalie looked considering but she said, "The lights are on. And you rarely leave the house these days."

Marinette looked confused and Adrien wondered if she was also wondering how they'd never beaten Hawkmoth earlier if this was the level of his planning.

"Adrien and I could let her in and tell her you were already out if you want?" She offered, "If there's a good reason you really don't want to talk to her?"

His father shook her head, "No, she'd only invite herself in to wait."

Marinette winced, "Is Felix with her?"

"Thankfully not." Nathalie confirmed.

The bell rang again.

"*Shouldn't* we let her in?" Adrien asked guiltily, "If she's came all the way from London it must be something important."

"Not necessarily." His father said, "She might have been in Paris for other reasons and have just decided to drop in on us."

"Or maybe she just didn't want to give us the chance to escape her. You two didn't exactly part on good terms." Nathalie pointed out.

His father focused on Marinette, "I don't suppose you could give me the Butterfly Miraculous back? It worked to get rid of them last time."

“*That’s* why that attack happened?” Adrien asked. He’d been pretty annoyed at Felix too but that seemed rather petty compared to trying to trying to get this mother back, like it lowered the tone of the whole enterprise.

His father shrugged, “Two birds with one stone.”

“Well we're not doing that.” Adrien announced.

“It was just a suggestion.”

---

Nathalie took a step back from the door as she opened it, but Aunt Amélie ignored her, sparing a moment to nod to his father and, before coming straight over to him and Marinette.

“Adrien,” She said putting her hands on his shoulders, “You look more grown up every time I see you.  Oh,” she caught sight of Marinette, “And this must be a friend of yours, I had no idea you were entertaining, I'm so sorry to interrupt. Here, Why don't you two go back to whatever you’re doing, and you and I can catch up later. I've business to talk about with your father.”

Adrien found himself unable to talk for a moment as he dealt with the strange sensation of talking to his mother’s twin, while his mother lay below the house. He realised he’d forgotten the slight differences between them. He’d noticed the hair obviously but both their hair had always varied in shade. The main difference was in the eyes.

And in that his Aunt was alive.  He couldn’t forget that. Seeing her now made his mother in her casket look less so.

“I don't believe we have any business.” His father said in the absence of any answer from Adrien. Nathalie had returned to her usual position beside him and the two of them certainly presented a united front, both stood upright with their hands behind their backs.

Adrien couldn't quite say the same for himself and Marinette, but then being on the same side now as Hawkmoth and Mayura was quite the adjustment for them. *Hell.* Being on the same side as his father and Nathalie even.

His aunt smiled, but something around her eyes seemed to tighten as she turned to face him, “Oh, it's not anything official, just boring adult things Adrien wouldn't be interested in.”

“He might surprise you.”

“I'm not sure it's quite an appropriate conversation to have in front of little ears.  Especially with how much I know you and Emilie liked to shelter him.”

There was a slight fracture in his father’s frozen façade, “this is about Emilie?”

“Of course it's about Emilie.” She glanced back at him and Marinette. “Are you sure you're happy to for him to hear this? Are you sure you want *her* to hear it? This is a family matter. I never thought you one to air the dirty laundry in public.”

If Marinette wasn’t Ladybug Adrien might have agreed but if Amélie knew anything about any Miraculous, or if his father decided to admit the truth to her then she *needed* to know.

From his glance over at the two of them his father *was* at least tempted by the idea of not having this discussion without an audience but all he said was, “I'm done keeping secrets about Emilie from Adrien, and he’d only tell Marinette everything anyway.”

Amélie's eyebrows raised, “They’re aware of the situation?”

“They are. I didn't think you were.”

“We do get news in London.” Amélie reached into her Birkin and pulled out a file, and passed it to his father, “I worked it out once I saw your interactions.”

His father pulled out what looked like newspaper clippers and started flicking through them. His brows knitted as he read them. Next to him Nathalie’s eyes widened, making Adrien wish he could see what was going on.

“Amélie,” his father said, “I don’t know what,”

“I want to talk to my sister.” She said.

Adrien caught Marinette’s eye but from the look on her face *she* didn’t know what was going on either. That *was* a weird way to ask to be brought to see his mother in the circumstances. It sort of made it sound like she didn't really know the circumstances at all.

“Talk?” His father said carefully, having clearly picked up on the same thing.

“Can you not contact her?”

“*Contact her?”*

“Look Gabriel. Don't play dumb. It doesn’t suit you. I know she's Mayura.”

It was probably a very good thing that she wasn't facing him and Marinette or Adrien was sure his gaping mouth would have given it all away. Marinette clutched his hand and didn't look much better, though her expression *could* have passed at shock at what had said, rather than the shock of someone that knew it was wrong.

Nathalie meanwhile seemed to be doing a rather good impression of a statue.

His father pinched the bridge of his nose, “Emilie isn't Mayura.”

“Right. So it's just a coincidence that she's using one of those jewels my sister was obsessed with then?”

This time Adrien couldn't prevent the embarrassing squeak he made. His Aunt *knew* about the Miraculous?

That caught her attention, and she looked back at him, while he hurriedly tried to school his face back to neutrality, and then back at his father, “I thought you said Adrien knew?”

“Adrien *does* know about his mother and the Miraculous. He didn't know *you* knew.”

“And did he know that she was in Paris the whole time?”

His father glanced back at them, and Adrien wanted to tell him that he didn’t have the right answer to give her either, but rather than answering that question he cut to the point. “She’s not Mayura Amélie, you’re barking up completely the wrong tree.”

She flicked her hair off her shoulder, “Please. I've had to sit through numerous dinners with the two of you. I know how you interact. I can recognise you and my sister together.”

“I was *akumatised.* I've already pointed that out to the press a thousand times. My behaviour wasn’t due to any sort of prior romantic relationship.”

Adrien supposed that was technically true but it was rather skirting around it.

Amélie snorted, sounding unconvinced, “And that's why she kidnapped you to make a point to Hawkmoth you weren't a threat to him? A kidnapping that might I point out the heroes don't seem to have had any issues rescuing you from.”

“What?”

“I realise you’re embarrassed about her running off on you, but did you never think that you should tell *me* where my sister was? Or,” Amélie's face softened slightly, “Did you not know either until you met her again?”

“She didn’t run off on me.” His father snapped.

“What else do you call abandoning you and Adrien to go prancing off playing at supervillainy with Hawkmoth? Did she even ask you first if you’d like to join her little escapade? Or was he the one that pursued her?”

“Emilie didn’t leave me for Hawkmoth, because, for the last time, *she’s not Mayura*.”

“So are you telling me you have no idea why she disappeared?”

His father swallowed and his anger seemed to drain out of him, “I, we've had this conversation before Amélie.”

“And you were just as evasive then. God Gabriel I'm not accusing you of killing her. I know you worshipped the ground she walked on. I just want to truth about my sister. I want to talk to her.”

“I'm sorry.”

“I don't want an apology. I want to know how if Emilie didn't leave you, or if you're not in contact with her, you're wearing *her* wedding ring right now.”

His father couldn't stop his eyes from going down to his hand holding the papers she'd given him before he looked back up, “So you're finally admitting Felix stole mine then.”

“You can't steal something that belongs to you.”

“My wedding ring doesn't belong to Felix.”

“It should *have.* It should have belonged to my husband, and then Felix should have inherited it when he died. I was dating Hugh before Emilie started dating you. We should have got the rings.”

“He should have proposed faster then. It's not my and Emilie’s fault we got engaged first. It had nothing to do with you.”

“Not for *you* maybe. My sister knew exactly what she was doing I'm sure.  You might as well give me that ring too if you've so convinced that Emilie isn't Mayura and you two have no chance of reconciliation.”

“Did you consider that maybe Emilie would have wanted *Adrien* to inherit the rings? That he should be able to use them for *his* wedding?”

Adrien was *not* blushing at this future wedding being brought up next to his girlfriend. He *was* not. This was so embarrassing. If he’d known this type of family issues were going to come up maybe he would have taken his Aunt up on her suggestion to leave the room.

“They’re not Adrien’s family rings.” She looked over her shoulder at him, “Sorry Adrien, but it's the truth. You’re an Agreste. Felix is a Graham de Vanilly.”

“I know?” He said kind of unsure how to answer that, and wasn’t sure if he felt insulted or not, “Did Felix really steal my father’s wedding ring?”

“Only because he knew I wanted it. He's such a considerate boy.”

“Really?” said Marinette, and even she seemed a little surprised she’d said anything, but she managed to continue, “Did you see the rest of what he did in Paris?”

“That little prank on Adrien? He and Felix always used to see who they could trick pretending to be each other. He couldn’t have known how it would end up, it’s not as if we have Hawkmoth back in London.”

“Little *prank?”*

“Oh,” his aunt said, looking slightly concerned, “Are you Adrien’s girlfriend? I'm *so* sorry, I will talk to Felix and explain to him that it’s not acceptable to impersonate his cousin to someone he's dating. He didn’t take advantage did he?”

His father and Nathalie exchanged a look behind her back that Adrien didn't want to know the meaning of.

Marinette's grip on his hand tightened and then after a delay she shook her head.

That raised more questions than it answered but Adrien tried to be helpful and said, "Marinette *is* my girlfriend. But that's *really* not the point."

Aunt Amélie didn't reply seemingly waiting for Adrien to say more, as if she *still* didn't see the problem with what Felix had done to everyone else rather than just to Marinette.

"You asked for both rings last time." His father said suddenly to Aunt Amélie. "Why did you think I had both? You've got what actually happened completely wrong, but how much *did* you know? How much did Emilie tell you?"

She turned back to him, "That brooch of hers, that wasn't a replica was it?"

Adrien gave his father a nod. It didn't look like they were going to be able to get out of it without telling his Aunt *some* of it at least, and telling her the truth about her sister *was the right thing to do.*

Marinette had said that if they were going to keep his father and Nathalie's secret then they had to make some sort of amends to everyone they'd hurt and not longing keeping his Aunt in the dark about whether her twin was alive or not seemed like the right place to start.

"Originally it was, but yes, she found one."

"I thought she would. No one ever said she lacked determination, and *you* weren't likely to be any sort of rein on her." Amélie bit at her lower lip, "So *what happened?* Did she blow herself into another universe in some magical experiment or something? Turn herself permanently invisible?"

"She," He trailed off, looking back down at the papers in his hands.

"You have to tell her Father." Adrien tried to encourage him.

"You know?" His Aunt asked him.

Adrien nodded, but now she was looking at him *he* found it just as had to speak the words as his father had a second ago.

Nathalie released her hands from behind her back, and placed one on top of his father's, and *that* finally made his father look up. He looked at her, and she nodded, and he finally spoke, "She effectively killed herself."

Aunt Amélie's gaze dropped to Nathalie's hand on his for a moment, before she looked up, "How?"

All the earlier certainty in her voice disappeared.

“Her Miraculous was broken. Using it made her ill. We didn’t realise until too late.”

“You didn’t or *she* didn’t?” Then she shook her head, “Where’s she’s buried then? Why didn’t you *tell* us? Why not lay her to rest officially? Was the body that,” Her voice broke off.

“She’s, *ah,* not buried.”

“What?”

He couldn’t blame her for that reaction. It *was* all completely crazy and at least Adrien had the benefit of having been Chat Noir, and caught up in it all already.

“You *have* to promise not to tell anybody. For Adrien’s sake.”

“How can I promise when I don’t know what I’m agreeing to? *What have you done?* What have you done to my sister*?”*

“It’s not like that. Emilie’s situation-she *agreed* to it, she helped think it up, but you *cannot* tell anybody. It’s vital.”

“Why should I believe that when you’ve been lying to me all this time?”

“I’ll give you the ring.”

“What?” Aunt Amélie said.

“Gabriel,” Nathalie sighed.

“I’m sure,” He said to her, then he looked at Aunt Amélie, “Will that buy your silence?”

She looked uncertain, then, “Adrien,” she said, “Do *you* want me to promise?”

“I do.” He said. He wanted to be honest with her he really did, *and* he could only be honest with her if she wasn’t going to spread it around.

“Alright.” She held her hand out, “Give me the ring, and I promise, *on it,* and you know what that means in my family, that I’ll keep your and Emilie’s secret.”

His father shut his eyes as he pulled the ring off his finger as if he couldn’t bear to look at what he was doing but he gave it to Amélie who pocketed it.

“Alright.” She sighed, “Take me to my sister.”

---

The matter of the size of the lift caused problems in the Atelier. Neither his father nor his Aunt seemed keen sharing the lift with each other.

“I can stay behind.” Marinette offered, “I don’t want to intrude on your mourning.”

“I’m still wondering why *you* apparently knew my sister was dead before I did,” Amélie said, “but thank you for that at least.”

“I can take Mme. Graham de Vanilly down sir.” Nathalie volunteered. “If you and Adrien wanted to follow after.”

“Well, I can see why *you* knew about it but I’m not sure why you think your presence is necessary down there either, or does Gabriel rely on you to unlock whatever security is down there?”

“I’ll take you down.” Adrien interrupted. “Father and Nathalie can follow us down.”

The tightness around Aunt Amélie’s eyes returned, but she agreed.

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“She’s, um, she doesn’t look *bad.*” Adrien said on the way down, “She could be sleeping really, if it wasn’t for, everything.”

His Aunt looked around the chamber they emerged into, “This is *not* what I imagined from what your father said.”

“Yeah, I didn’t expect it either.”

Unlike Adrien she didn’t run to her sister in the casket, but like him she put a hand out to the glass.

She shut her eyes, and he thought she was going to cry, but when she opened them, she said, “You idiot.”

“Uh?” came out of Adrien’s mouth without any conscience thought from him.

But his Aunt ignored him, “You *had* to go chasing after more powerful magic didn’t you? You couldn’t just confine yourself to family mysteries like our parents could you? Was it worth it Emilie? Did worth abandoning me? Abandoning your *son?* Why is our family like this? Are we cursed to never be satisfied?*”*

Adrien could relate much of that. Even if some of it only raised *more* questions about his family.

She choked off whatever she was going to say next and Adrien realised that she *was* crying after all.

His father’s and Nathalie’s footsteps echoed as they came down the catwalk.

Amelie whirled around. “Gabriel *you idiot.*”

That seemed to be her word of the moment.

“What on *earth* did you think you were doing? Why didn’t you take her to a hospital when she got close to the end? If she reappears like this now, you’re going to be the number one suspect. Did you particularly want Adrien to lose two parents? Or were you planning to keep her here until you died?”

“I’m touched. I didn’t think you cared.”

“Don’t try to distract me. What even *is* this?”

“It keeps her in suspended animation essentially.”

Amélie looked back at his mother and then at his father then, a horrified look crossed her face, which must have been the realisation her sister was only *nearly* dead.

“Oh my god. You thought you could bring her back. And not in any normal way based on *this.*” She laughed hysterically, “She killed herself looking for magical power, and you thought the solution was to *look for more magical power?* Did you not learn anything?”

She had a point.

“I couldn’t let her die.” His father tried to defend himself.

“It’s what the rest of us do. What we have to do. Those last few days with my husband were the worst days of my life, but I *accepted* it. I try to be the best mother I can be to Felix to make up for him missing his father and it’s hard but that’s what *normal* people do Gabriel.”

“There was never anything normal about Emilie and I.”

“No, I suppose not.” Amélie exhaled.

Adrien couldn’t pretend he was normal either, and he could only hope he hadn’t inherited his parent’s bad decision making genes. Though he refused to even consider what he might do if Marinette died because that wasn’t going to happen for decades so he wasn’t going to think about it.

“I am trying.” His father said. “To let her go. I admitted it all to Adrien and he shared your thoughts on the matter.”

Amélie twisted some hair round her finger in distraction, “How did you even think you were going to do it?”

The three of them all looked nervously at each other.

“Oh more secrets. Fantastic. Don’t tell me. I don’t want to know. Just leave me for a while, I want to talk to my sister in private. “

“Alright.” His father conceded, “Come on Adrien. Let’s give your Aunt some peace.”

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Halfway on their way to the lift Amélie’s voice echoed out behind them, “Wait, who *was* Mayura then?”

Adrien’s eyes automatically darted to Nathalie and he could only hope she hadn’t noticed.

“Does it matter?” His father asked sounding tired.

“I know what I saw in those photos and videos. Is *that* why you decided to let my sister go? Or was it some weird emotional transference based on them both being Miraculous wielders?”

“It wasn’t emotional transference.”

“I can’t believe it. Really? *You?* Finding someone else while Emilie was down here. And there I thought you loyalty was one of your better values. Though,” she said looking back around the chamber, “I suppose maybe it wasn’t if it led to this. Go on. Move on with Mayura then, even if your taste is inexplicable.”

“I married your sister.”

“Like I said. Inexplicable.”

“Careful. One would think you were insecure seeing as you’re identical.”

“I wasn’t talking about *looks.* After all Mayura’s pretty striking too. Both you and Hawkmoth are punching above your weight there.”

“She’s just blue.” Nathalie said.

Aunt Amélie looked shocked to be addressed, “What?”

“Mayura. She’s pretty but she’s not particularly special looking. She’s striking because she’s blue, and because of the make-up.”

“Did you think that was a helpful addition to this conversation?” his aunt asked, and he had to agree, whatever Nathalie’s self-esteem issues were this was *not* the time.

“*I* think Mayura’s stunning.” His father said, “Blue or not-blue.”

This time *both* Nathalie and his aunt looked at his father in askance.

“Again.” Aunt Amélie said, “Really not the point. The point is your horrific taste in personalities. Have you considered the danger you’re putting Adrien in by getting entangled

with her?"

"I'm not concerned about Mayura being a danger to Adrien."

"Yeah, she saved me actually." Adrien added in his father's defence. Mayura hadn't been a danger to *Adrien.* Only to *Chat Noir.*

"What about Hawkmoth though?" Aunt Amélie asked.

"I am *also* not concerned about Hawkmoth being a danger to Adrien."

That was probably true. Unless you defined neglect as danger, but really his father *should* have more time for him now he wasn't being Hawkmoth. And now that Adrien had some leverage to wield. He'd already taken everything with Marinette much better than expected after all.

"I see. Wait." Amélie looked between the three of them. "Not-blue."

"What?"

"You said not-blue. You've seen Mayura detransformed."

"I don't see how that's relevant."

"That means, the two of you, it's *serious?*"

"Why do you care?"

"I think I'm allowed to be concerned about my nephew getting a supervillainess for a stepmother."

"That doesn't necessarily follow." Nathalie said, "I don't think M.Agreste would,"

Amélie interrupted her with a hand on her arm, "Nathalie, can I call you Nathalie?"

"I thought you did."

She ignored this response. "Ask your boss just how quickly he and my sister got engaged. If you don't want Mayura as the new mistress of this house, then you have to act quickly."

Nathalie shrugged her hold off, "I'm sure that's a question for Mayura and M.Agreste to sort out between themselves."

"No one can say I didn't try. Sorry Adrien." his Aunt said.

Adrien wasn't quite sure what Nathalie's responses meant, but he thought he should probably clarify, "I wouldn't mind having Mayura as a stepmother."

The three adults looked at him. Nathalie hid her reaction better than his aunt or father, who looked respectively confused and considering, but she still looked a bit thrown.

“Thank you Adrien.” His father said, “I’ll bear that in mind.”

“Gabriel you don’t even know what Mayura,” Aunt Amélie trailed off, “That was your plan to bring Emilie back wasn’t it? The sources of Ladybug and Chat Noir’s powers. That is *exactly* the sort of plan she’d have come up with.”

“I don’t think she realised how difficult it would be.”

“You’re Hawkmoth.”

“You promised you wouldn’t tell anyone any of this.”

“You,” She gesticulated wildly, “You akumatised those girls and blamed Felix for it. You stood there bold as brass and asked for an apology from him, and you were *using* him. You utter hypocrite.”

“Felix sent that video with *no* prompting from me. And then he *volunteered* to help Hawkmoth without even being akumatised. Maybe *you* should look into your parenting skills.”

“Says the *supervillain.”*

“*Ex*-supervillain.”

“For how long exactly? And I will not be lectured on parenting by the master of emotional neglect? Do you even hug Adrien?”

“Of course I hug Adrien.”

“Really? How often?”

“When he needs it.”

“Right, so not until he discovered about his mother then? God, I hope your girlfriend can make up for your toxic masculinity.”

“Amélie,”

“Just go. All of you. I don’t want to see you right now.” Amélie shook her head, “I’m going to say goodbye to my sister, and then I’m going home. Don’t worry, I’m not going to tell anyone. I did promise. And the last thing I want is the infamy of being Hawkmoth’s sister-in-law. And Adrien doesn’t deserve to be known as Hawkmoth’s son. I’ll contact you at some point regarding how we’re going to lay my sister to rest once I’ve had time to think.”

---

“How it’d go?” Marinette ran to him when he re-entered the Atelier, accidentally knocking some files off Nathalie’s desk where she’d be sat.

Nathalie sighed but didn’t say anything.

“She knows basically all of it now.”

“Is she?”

“She said she wouldn’t say anything.”

“That’s good then isn’t it?”

“I guess. Just.” He tried to put on his best begging eyes, “Please don’t dump me because of my family drama.”

Marinette smiled, “Yeah, that’s not going to happen. Besides my family has drama too.”

“Not like this.”

“Not when they’re not akumatised I guess, but things can still be” Marinette hesitated, “difficult.”

# Chapter 13

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adrien was halfway out the window when there was a knock at his bedroom door and he froze.

“Adrien?” Nathalie’s voice came through the door. “Are you ok?”

“I’m alright,” He called back, hurriedly trying to climb back in. “Did you need something?”

Somehow despite being transformed in his hurry he misjudged the distance and landed back in with a thump.

He couldn’t really blame Nathalie for opening the door hearing that.

“Are you ok?” She asked, and then took in the situation. “Oh.”

“Don’t tell Father?” He asked her.

She looked uncertainly back behind her. “Where you going out to meet Marinette? Or, nothing’s happened has it?”

“No nothing’s happened!” He reassured her, “I was just going to meet Marinette.”

She looked over his costume, “You weren’t planning to stay over at hers were you? It’s just, if you were you can just *ask* me you know? I’d been much happier sending Adrien over to her, than you climbing in her bedroom window as Chat Noir. And I’m sure *her* parents would be as well.”

“Yeah they,” Adrien started, “Wait, did you see that photo then too?”

Nathalie nodded. “Your father hasn’t yet. I’ve been trying to ensure he *doesn’t.*”

“Right. Thanks.” He said. “Marinette described the conversation she had with her parents when they brought it up to her as the most awkward one she’d ever had with them. I can’t imagine having to go through that with Father.”

“At least he’d know it was you,” Nathalie said, but she didn’t look like she thought it would be a good conversation to have with him either, “Though I’m making assumptions. Do Marinette’s parents know?”

“No. Or at least I don’t *think* so. After everything that’s happened I’m not assuming *anything* these days.”

“That’s understandable I guess. Did you want a lift to hers then?”

“That’s ok. I wasn’t planning to going to hers. Didn’t really want another photo.” Marinette had given him a long talking to about being more careful. Which he *had* taken on board, since while she was really cute when she was lecturing him, he didn’t want to annoy her so, “We were just going to meet up as Ladybug and Chat Noir and practise and chat for a bit. We thought it might be reassuring for people to see us around, and it’s easier to talk outside than it is here or at hers, and I’ve missed it really.”

“*Really*? I would have thought you’d be relieved it was over.”

“I’m relieved no one has to worry about Hawkmoth anymore.” He said, and Nathalie winced, “but honestly I *liked* being Chat Noir. I know that sounds terrible, but,”

“I don’t think it sounds terrible. Though I’m clearly no judge of that sort of thing. But I would have thought surely it’s a good thing to want to be a hero?”

“Probably. And *Marinette’s* like that. But for me, it wasn’t the fame or anything, and I did like helping people, but honestly it was just kind of fun.”

“The superpowers?”

“Yeah, not Cataclysm because that’s serious. But the rest of it, and how I felt I could just do anything and go anywhere, it was,”

“Freeing?” Nathalie suggested, “I always had the after-effects at the back of my mind, but I can’t deny the transformation itself was exhilarating.”

“Exactly. And I didn’t have to hold back as Chat Noir, I could,” he suddenly realised who he was talking to and stopped.

“Could?”

“It doesn’t matter.”

He expected Nathalie to leave it there. Usually she’d leave it there, but this time she sighed, “It sounded like it mattered.”

At his look of surprise she shrugged, “The whole situation’s our fault, if there’s something I can do to help, I want to.”

“I think it’s more Father’s fault than yours.” He said, “But I don’t think you can really help unless you can magically change Father’s mind on how I should behave.”

“Oh.”

“Yeah.”

She frowned, “Was there a particular way you wanted to be more like you are as Chat Noir? I mean if it’s the flirting I think it’s Marinette you need to talk to about that, and if it’s the puns obviously it’s not an issue though I’d advise against them if you’re working, and,”

“Why obviously?”

“What?”

“Why are the puns obviously not an issue?”

“Well, you get that from your father don’t you?” Then she muttered, “Actually you might get some of the flirting from there too.”

“I do.” He realised, “I’d forgotten he used to do that,” back when they were happier and his mother was still healthy.

“Still does.”

“No he doesn’t. I haven’t heard him make a pun in years.”

“You didn’t hear his conversations with akumas.”

“No. No I *didn’t.* Were they funny? No one told us Hawkmoth was funny.”

She shook her head, “I wouldn’t say his speeches were funny. Sorry, I probably shouldn’t be talking to you about that, I’m sure it’s the last thing you wanted to hear.”

“Actually it’s ok. It kind of makes it easier to reconcile him and Hawkmoth,” his staff beeped, “Maybe we could talk about it another time though? I’m running late.”

“Right of course,” Nathalie said, then she looked him up and down, “Won’t you be cold? Where’s your coat?”

“It’s *magic*. You know how it works.”

“I didn’t make a habit of going out at night,” She said and pulled part of his wardrobe, “Ah,” She said triumphantly, “See this is fitting. Put it on.”

She was holding up a Chat Noir themed hat he’d bought on a whim, and his reluctance when he took it from her was half-performative. Then he spotting his birthday scarf and reached for it.

“Happy now?” He said.

Nathalie was staring at the scarf.

“Maybe you should wear a different scarf,” She said, “That one doesn’t go.”

“It’s fine.”

“No really, I think you should change it.”

“*Nathalie.* This is my favourite scarf. It’s my birthday one.”

“Yes I know.”  She continued to look at it as if he’d slung a snake around his neck, “Maybe you should invite Marinette over on Saturday.”

“Yeah, I can do that, but I really have to go. And cover for me with Father ok?”

“Of course.” She said, “But. Do ask Marinette.”

---

That Saturday Adrien ran down the stairs to great Marinette, when he saw her come in the gate, only to not find her waiting for him in the hall. After looking around to check he wasn’t somehow missing anything he tried the main door to check that neither his father nor Nathalie had left her on the doorstep but she wasn’t there either.

He looked at the Atelier door without much enthusiasm. Nathalie hadn’t said to invite her talk to her and Father about everything. He’d thought she’d just been trying to be nice and this was going to be time for the just the two of them.

He could have misunderstood her though, or maybe they were just trying to talk to her without *him.*

He gently pushed the door open to find…his father at his screen and *only* his father. No Marinette, but no Nathalie at her desk either. Which was unexpected. She *could* have been back in bed but she’d been up earlier and while she *shouldn’t* have been working on a Saturday her hours had been kind of erratic recently.

“Um,” Adrien said, “Do you know where Marinette is? I saw her come up to the house but she wasn't in the hall when I came down.”

His father looked slightly sheepish. “Ah. Nathalie wanted to talk to her.”

“Without *us?”*

“Apparently.”

“About *what?*”

“She didn't say.”

Adrien stared at his father in disbelief. “And you didn’t *ask?*”

“It seemed like she wanted to keep it private, and no, I’m not lying so you don’t have to threaten to break the electronics again.”

“What?” Adrien asked completely lost, “I’ve never,”

“He was talking to me.” Plagg said from above his shoulder.

“You talk to him without me?” He asked his Kwami.

“Someone has to make him face up to his responsibilities.”

Adrien shook his head, and got back to the important issue, “Father, weren’t you even slightly concerned? What on earth would Nathalie want to talk to Marinette about in private?”

“I don’t know.” His father paused. “I thought it might be. Female things. Girl talk.”

“*Girl talk?”* Adrien asked in sheer disbelief.

His father shrugged. “I don’t know what women talk about when we’re not around.”

“Isn’t your entire career literally built on selling things to women?”

*“*And that includes knowing when they don’t want us around.”

Adrien officially gave up. “I’m going to wait for Marinette. Where’s best? In the hall?”

“I’d think so. Though I don’t think you should disturb them.”

---

Marinette came out of the dining room putting what looked like a few 50 euro notes into her purse.

“Is she bribing you too now?”

She startled having apparently not noticed him, “I don’t, I’m not sure. *Who* else has she bribed?”

“Plagg.” Adrien admitted tiredly. He bet Tikki wouldn’t have had her head turned so easily.

Marinette looked surprised. “*Plagg?* Really? How?”

“She’s given him free reign on my father’s credit card for a load of fancy cheese. And she bought him a mini cat bed. Though that might have been because apparently Duusu had some mini nest or something? So maybe she thought he needed one. I don’t know.”

Adrien *had* been reassuered that at least one of them had had a normal relationship with their Kwami and felt kind of sorry for Duusu not having had the chance to say goodbye to Nathalie. Sometimes he wondered if she was using Plagg as a substitute Kwami rather than just trying to butter him up but if now she was trying to bribe Marinette too that was a strike againt that idea.

“Maybe she’s just trying to nice?” Marinette suggested.

“And was she just trying to be nice to you?”

She didn’t meet his eyes. “OK. So she’s not bribing me with money.”

“Wait. What *is* she bribing you with then? And what was the money for?”

Marinette blushed. “She kind of mentioned some photos of you as a kid she has? But I don’t now that that was a bribe, we were just kind of talking when that came up.”

His father might have been right. *That* was a thing that happened on films and TV so Adrien assumed it happened to some people in real life. He just hadn’t really thought the whole parent showing your girlfriend embarrassing photos thing would happen to *him,* when his father would never consider showing anything that showed him as less than perfect.

“and, um, the money was for a commission.”Marinette said looking even more embarrassed.

“A commission? Why would she need you to make something for her?” He realised how demeaning that could sound and abruptly backpedalled, “Not that it wouldn’t make sense for her to want something from you, you’re a great designer and I’m sure whatever you would make would be fantastic, it’s just I didn’t think Nathalie would need anything, and if she did she could,”

“Just ask your dad? Yeah, I’m sure she would if she was for a dress or something but this was actually for something I already did ages ago. Apparently she hadn’t realised the money hadn’t gone through.”

Adrien couldn’t help feel sceptical. That sounded *very* unlike Nathalie. “Really?”

“Yeah, she actually offered to pay online if that was easier for my tax records, but I said cash is fine, because I checked with my parents about my commission money, when they were doing the bakery tax return and I don’t make enough to be taxed apparently.”

That *did* sound like Nathalie but, “I didn’t realise you’d spoken to Nathalie much before.”

“I hadn’t,” Marinette glanced back at the door, “Hey, could we go upstairs?”

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Adrien shut his bedroom door behind them. “Was there something you wanted to say out of their hearing?”

They’d have gone up anyway but he could take the hint in Marinette asking when she had.

“It’s just, Nathalie,” she bit her lip anxiously, “Should she be working? I thought she was going to faint before we sat down, and then she was coughing a lot, and I know maybe I’m oversensitive about people working sick because obviously we can’t at the bakery but she doesn’t look well.”

“Probably not.” He admitted. “I think Father *does* try and let her rest, even when he’s not kidnapping her to do so, but I guess the company keeps going, and if Nathalie took sick leave then he’d have to another assistant in to cover her job, and that’s hard when we’re trying to hide all of this. Maybe when Aunt Amélie let’s us know how she wants to handle this with Maman it might be possible but until then I don’t know.”

“I wish I could find something to help quicker. I know they deserve *something* for everything they’ve done, but I don’t like the idea that I’m letting someone suffer like that.”

“You’re not. You’re doing the exact opposite of that with all the work you’re doing to find a cure. And you’re going to find something, beause you’re Ladybug and you’re amazing. But you’re right, we’ve been putting off making a decision,” He’d honestly become quite used to the purgatory they were living in, especially with how his father *was* actually finally showing some concern for him openly, and yet Nathalie had taken his comments about not wanting to be in the house to heart, maybe a little bit too much, and tried to give him *way* more time out of it than he’d had basically ever. “And I hadn’t really thought about Nathalie’s health meaning we should try make it quicker but I guess we should.”

“Yeah,” Marinette agreed, “I think she’s kind of looking forward to quitting once she can.”

“*Quitting?”* That didn’t make any sense. “Quitting *what*?”

She looked at him confused as if she had no idea of the import of what she was saying, “Her job?”

Adrien tried to make sense of that. Marinette must have misunderstood. Nathalie had *always* been there, and she wasn’t going to abandon them now and he doesn’t get it. “Nathalie can’t quit.”

“Adrien?”

Marinette reached up in concern but Adrien took a step back.

“I need to go talk to her.”

---

“Is Nathalie quitting?”

Both his father and Nathalie looked up from their screens.

“I’m sorry,” Nathalie said, “I didn’t want to presume anything.”

“Presume *what?”*

“If you and Marinette do let us keep our identities secret, then once we’ve through all of this, yes I’ll be resigning, but I understand that you haven’t made your decision yet, and that I

can't do anything until you do."

"But I *don't* understand. You can't leave us. Not now. I've just lost Maman, I can't lose you too."

"Adrien," She stood up, "I'm not going to leave you."

"But you said,"

She put her hands on his shoulders and met his eyes. "That I was going to leave my job. That's got *nothing* to go with leaving *you.* Quite the opposite really."

"I don't understand."

Nathalie looked as if she was struggling for words, "your father and I we're,"

"Together?" He suggested, because everything suggested they *were,* and he really hoped that was right because if it was than Nathalie wouldn't be leaving them.

Nathalie looked towards his father who had come over to sit on her desk while she was talking, "Are in agreement that we want to be, and if we are then I can't keep working for him."

"So," He tried to get his thoughts together, "You want to resign because you want to be *with* Father. Not because you want to be away from us?"

"I've *never* wanted to be away from you. If I did and if I had any sense I would have quit long before this. Trust me." She tried to smile, "You're struck with me."

"Ok." He said, "So, you're still going to be here, just not working?"

His father nodded.

Nathalie said, "That's the plan."

"What are you even going to do?"

"In the short term? Rest. Recover. Probably harangue my replacement for messing up. Still accompany you places probably if I'm feeling up to it, because I'd that time with you otherwise."

Adrien's heart starting to return to a more normal beat, "So you won't look for another job immediately?"

"Not until I'm completely bored anyway. Or not until your father stops being unhelpfully jealous over the idea of me being someone *else's* assistant."

His father looked completely unrepentant, "You make me sound unreasonable."

Nathalie looked back over at her shoulder at him and rolled her eyes, “No one has ever described you as reasonable.”

Her tone was fond despite her words, and Adrien’s beating heart calmed down a bit, “OK. So you’re not leaving.”

“She’s definitely not.” His father said, and having stood up he put a hand on Nathalie waist. “We did mean to mention it to you at some point, but it didn’t seem worth it when we didn’t know how things were going to end up.”

Adrien suddenly felt very silly, “I *might* have overreacted a bit. I shouldn’t have assumed it meant you were leaving us, not after everything that’s happened. Even if it *is* going to be really weird, having someone else here doing your job.”

“Yes,” His father said, “It will be.”

“And for me,” Nathalie said, “But we’ll adjust. And I will be here for you Adrien. You can still ask me for help with your homework, you don’t have to ask your father’s new assistant.”

“That’s good to hear,” He said, and he knew he’d reacted kind of excessively but, “Can I hug you?”

Nathalie awkwardly took her hands on his shoulders as his father let go of her, “Yes. Of course. You don’t have to ask.”

“I’m sorry,” he said as he clung to her middle, “It’s just, with everything,”

“No, it makes sense.” Nathalie said running her fingers through his hair, “you’re been through a lot of upheaval, and you’re just lost your mother. It makes sense another change would be frightening.”

“It’s alright Marinette.” His father said, and Adrien realised she must have followed him down and saw *all of that,* “You can come in.”

“Is Adrien ok?” She asked.

He lifted his head up to say, “I’m alright.”

“Um, you know what we spoke about earlier?” She said.

Adrien guessed Nathalie’s health wasn’t unrelated to his panic over losing her but he hadn’t thought it was an immediate concern.

Except apparently it hadn’t been *him* she’d been talking to because Nathalie said, “Yes, I think therapy would be a good idea.”

“For *me*?” Adrien asked, he was upset obviously but he was hardly the person in this house that had the *worst* reaction to grief, and he didn’t really know how he could talk about it, while not talking about Chat Noir, and Hawkmoth, and Mayura.

“For you and your father.” Nathalie clarified, “To help you deal with your grief.”

“If we’re somehow doing it then you are too.” His father said.

Nathalie’s fingers stilled, “It’s not the same for me, Emilie wasn’t,”

“You know that’s not the only issue here.”

She sighed. “I’ll think about it. It’ll take long enough to sort something anyway given everything.”

---

“So that was embarrassing.” He said to his girlfriend afters when they were sitting in the living room on the sofa. Or Marinette was sitting. Technically he was lying down with his head in her lap. Theoretically they were both watching some silly romcom but all of it was going over Adrien’s head.

“Not as much as you think.” She said, “I’ve done much more embarrassing things in front of way more people for way more stupid reasons. You’re allowed to be upset at what happened you know.”

“Did you and Nathalie really talk about therapy?”

“A bit. I just want to help you, but I don’t know what to do. It’s not like being Ladybug where there’s some Lucky Charm to point me in the right direction. And from what Nathalie said, well, I guess I’d thought it wasn’t that tough for your dad given he knew the whole situation the whole time *and* he’s got Nathalie but it sounded like *he’s* not coping that well with it either.”

“Not really.” Adrien said. “Not that they let me see much of it but I’m fairly certain he’s not sleeping much either. If Nathalie wasn’t here I think he’d try and just constantly work through the night.”

“Are you sleeping better now?”

“It’s not great, but I’m getting enough. I’ve a sleepover at Nino’s tonight actually.”

“You seem to have a lot on recently. Even for you.”

“I think they’re trying to physically exhaust me so I’ll sleep.”

“Is that…working?”

“Kind of? It does help I think. I’m just lucky I have a competition coming up in fencing soon so there’s lots of extra practice on.”

Marinette stiffened underneath him. “Adrien.”

“Yes?”

“Did you ever tell Kagami we were dating? Because I haven’t.”

“I didn’t even think of it. “ He admitted. Which was odd in its own way because his relationship with Marinette was the one thing he *could* talk to people about, and he’d already got in trouble with his Chinese and piano teachers for talking about how amazing she was for too long to them instead of working, “I probably should have shouldn’t I?”

“Yeah. Yeah you should have. Or I should have. She deserves that much.”

“Yeah she does.” Adrien realised with a sinking feeling, “I guess *I* should say it given I see her more, it’s just I don’t know to say it without upsetting her.”

“You can’t.”

“What?”

“Look, if it was her you were dating and you told me then I’d be upset no matter how nicely you broke the news. I’d accept it, and I’d try to be happy for you. And I’d be glad it was *her* you were dating and not someone like Chloé or Lila, and I’d be happy for her because she’s my friend too, but I’d still be disappointed. There’s no way you change that.”

“Are you sure?” He asked her. He’d been relying on Marinette to know some way for him to be give her the news without upsetting her. The idea that she didn’t know a way was disconcerting. Adrien liked Kagami. He didn’t want to upset her.

“You have to upset people sometimes. That’s life. And hey, at least we know she won’t akumatised.”

“Yeah I guess there’s that.”

---

“I’m sorry,” Nathalie said, “I didn’t want to interrupt you two. Especially after earlier. It’s just. Amélie’s on the phone.”

“Is there a problem?” Marinette asked.

“There might be.” Nathalie said. “Gabriel wanted me to get you two.”

Suddenly Adrien’s earlier concerns seemed very silly in comparison to this, “Has she changed her mind? About not exposing him?”

“I don’t think so. He didn’t look concerned enough for that, but we should go.”

When they got to the Atelier his father wasn't on the phone.

"She doesn't know I don't have my Miraculous any longer." He announced.

"Is that a problem?" Marinette asked, "Only I've been thinking and I'm not sure if I *want* to announce to the world Ladybug has them now."

Adrien looked at Marinette in surprise. She hadn't mentioned that. He could see the security issues and why she'd worry but that sort of sounded like she *wasn't* planning to announce Hawkmoth and Mayura's defeat to Paris.

"Quite." His father agreed. "Which is why I didn't admit that to her. Only she wants me to akumatise myself or Nathalie so we can teleport Emilie to her."

"And did you agree?" He asked. If he had it seemed quite presumptuous of him, but on the other hand explaining he didn't would risk his Aunt working out his and Marinette's identities as well which didn't seem like a good idea.

"I said I'd have to consider a way to do it. She didn't know enough about how the Butterfly Miraculous' powers work to argue about that."

"OK." said Marinette, "*I'm* going to have to think about it then."

"I can understand you being unwilling to let me use the Miraculous but perhaps you could akumatise one of us?"

"That might be possible." She said. "Or, do you think she could tell the difference between someone akumatised, and someone wielding a Miraculous?"

"I wouldn't think so."

"Leave it with me." Marinette said.

Chapter End Notes

Does this chapter add anything?
tbh no, but I'd written too much of it before I realise that and then didn't want to scrap it, so oh well.

# Chapter 14

Adrien watched Nathalie watch him at breakfast. Marinette's outside perspective had reminded him that she still wasn't well but it was always so hard to tell with Nathalie if she was *actually* fine or if she was just putting up a front. Or what was just a normal cough, and what was the effect of the Peacock Miraculous.

He considered how she was subtly leaning against the wall rather than standing free like normal. "You can sit down you know?"

Nathalie looked uncertain.

"I mean we're basically family, even if you haven't been able to quit your job yet," he added even though the still wasn't sure how he felt about that. The idea of someone *else* being around when she usually was was odd.

It seemed to convince Nathalie though because she took a step away from the wall.

"Thank you Adrien," She said sitting down next to him, "That's very kind of you."

He could swear some of the tension had left her when she'd sat down but she was still tightly holding onto her tablet, and what looked like a magazine underneath it.

"Is something wrong?" He asked.

She pursed her lips, "You might need to talk to Marinette."

He couldn't help the bit of fear that crept up his spine at that, "Has something happened?"

Nathalie looked back down at her tablet and then back up at him, while he worried and then said, "You are aware that the press is aware of your relationship?"

That hadn't been were he'd thought this conversation was going to go but, "I guessed?" He said, "I mean we didn't exactly announce it but people have thought it before when we weren't and we've not exactly been hiding it."

"No, taking her out to dinner isn't exactly hiding it."

"*That* was a necessary apology," He pointed out, unsure where she was going with all of this since he doubted his father was going to ban him from dating Marinette after everything, "and that didn't necessarily have to be a date."

"People are never going to believe you went on a social dinner with someone of the other gender *alone* and it wasn't a date." She said, looking somewhat sympathetic.

That seemed unfair though. "My parents used to meet people individually out for dinner all the time. No one thought they were dates. Back when Father left the house anyway."

“Adrien those were work related, and you’re a teenager. Besides people,” she trailed off and shook her head, “Anyway, you dating Marinette is *not* the problem. That,”

“It’s known is the problem?” Adrien interrupted with a sinking feeling, but “Father didn’t seem to mind.”

“I don’t think he was really thinking about it at the start. He was…distracted. My fault. But, that it's known you’re dating Marinette isn't the problem either. Or not exactly. The problem is that people have realised that the girl having late night rendezvous with Chat Noir is Adrien Agreste's girlfriend.”

He took it all back. That did actually sound like a problem.

Nathalie put a magazine down on the table in front of him with a picture of him as Adrien and Marinette and then a photoshopped photo of him as Chat Noir and Marinette on the front cover, along with her tablet which he now saw had multiple tabs open full of, he gulped, people speculating over the apparent love triangle that Adrien Agreste and Chat Noir were in over Marinette Dupain-Cheng.

This was not good.

“Given Marinette’s age and where there’s obvious libel regards her herself we can have our lawyers contact the legacy publications, though we’d have to talk to Marinette’s parents first, but it’s impossible to police the internet.”

“Ok.” Said Adrien feeling slightly overwhelmed.

“Also,” Nathalie hesitated, “There’s some concern that by responding to it we might draw more attention to the matter, and I assume both you and Marinette would prefer *not* to have your name linked to closely to Chat Noir’s.”

Adrien nodded.

“Of course you’ve other avenues to explore. Given the Fox Miraculous you could perhaps stage something of *you* interacting with Chat Noir but, given her position I realise that how you want to handle this is your and Marinette’s decision to make despite your age.”

“Could we go back to you handling all my public relations?”

Her expression slipped from being purely business as some sympathy crept in, “I know this is overwhelming, and I wished we hadn’t contributed to the issue, but how you want to handle this can’t be my decision. I can deal with the press for you but you have to tell me what you want.”

Adrien didn’t *know* what he wanted.

Nathalie’s lips quirked up a little at the corner, “I’ll no comment them for now until you two have had a chance to talk it through. You don’t have to make a decision immediately, it might all die down of its own accord.”

Adrien could feel himself sag in relief.

She sighed, “It’s not like there’s not going to be other news to displace it.”

He mood dipped at the reminding of the upcoming annoucment of his mother’s death to the world and he firmly pushed those feelings down and asked instead, “How did you know what I wanted you to do for now? *I* didn’t know.”

“It’s my job to anticipate those sorts of things.” She said shrugging but there was an amused light in her eyes, “It’s funny. You made *exactly* the same expression your father makes when put on the spot for a response. I don’t usually see any real resemblance between the two of you but that was striking.”

“I thought you said we both had the puns?”

“That was Chat Noir and Hawkmoth.”

“And aparrently we’re both in love triangles with super-powered versions of ourselves.”

Nathalie groaned, “Don’t remind me. Though I wouldn’t suggest you emulate your father’s methods for shutting down rumours.”

“Huh.” Adrien realised, “If I’m dating Marinette, does that mean Chat Noir’s dating Ladybug now too?”

The real answer was yes but that wasn’t what he meant and Nathalie seemed to understand that, “That’s something else you’d have to decide. It might shut down the talk about Marinette and Chat Noir, but it risks people noticing the two couples are together at the same time too.”

“I guess there’s not much reason for them to be around much more anyway.”

“Marinette seemed to think you’d still be making appearances. And you know she’s not going to take Plagg away from you.”

“Yeah I guess,” He said.

“Come on, eat up or you’ll be late for school.”

Adrien didn’t really feel like eating at all but he forced himself to chew knowing he’d need the energy later.

“At least there’s one good thing out of this all being public.” He realised.

“What’s that?”

“Kagami probably already knows Marinette and I are dating. I should probably still say it to her because she’s our friend but at least I won’t be breaking the bad news.”

Opposite him Nathalie stiffened. “Mme. Tsurugi’s daughter?”

There was an odd tone Adrien couldn't read in her voice.

"Yeah, she fences with me."

"Yes I remember."

"Um, are you ok?"

"Fine. You just reminded me of something I'd forgotten about."

"Like a meeting with Kagami's mother?" Adrien asked but that didn't sound like Nathalie *at all,* "Or?"

"I need to schedule a meeting or a call with her. It'd gone completely out of my head."

"I'm sure Father won't blame you. He knows you're still suffering the effects of your Miraculous, he can't expect you to work like you normally do."

Nathalie didn't look reassuered at *all,* but she said, "I know. He's very understanding about that but," she looked at the wall as if she could see through it and the room behind to the Atleier, "I have to talk to your father about something."

She stood up and Adrien watched her leave the room utterly lost as to what that had been about. He really didn't think his father was going to be cross with her, and he didn't even think *she* thought that but she'd definitely been concerned about something and completely cagey about what it was.

When she didn't return he collected his stuff up ready for school, and headed to the door so Gorilla could drive him to school.

Only when he got into the hall Nathalie *and* his father are coming out of the Atelier.

"Adrien." His father said in acknowledgement and he waited for him to continue.

"We're being honest with you about things now." He announced.

"Is this about Kagami's mother?" Adrien ventured, unable to see any other explanation for Nathalie's behaviour.

His father nodded.

"Is this going to be another world-shattering revaltion?" He asked as if he wasn't already exhausted by those.

"You might consider it that." His father conceded.

Adrien shook his head, "How urgent is this?"

"What?"

"Do I need to know right now, or can it wait until this evening?"

His father than Nathalie looked at each other then she gave a slight nod, and he said, “It can wait that long but,”

Uncaring of how impolite it was Adrien interrupted, “I don’t have time for this right now. I have to go to school, and I have to talk with Marinette about what we’re supposed to do about people thinking she’s dating me and Chat Noir at the same time, and deal with the rest of my normal life, and then this evening you two can to explain what exactly you’re talking about.”

Neither of them tried to stop him leaving and despite everything Adrien almost got a little thrill from that, even if immediately afterwards that made him wonder what was wrong with him. Apart from the fact that all the adults in his life were crazy people apparently.

He stopped and turned around, “I won’t be back for lunch. I’m going to eat with Marinette.”

“That’s sensible.” Nathalie agreed. “Good luck.”

He just about heard his father ask, “Why does he need good luck?” as he shut the front door. He wondered if Nathalie hadn’t told him about the whole Chat Noir issue, or if he just didn’t think it was a particularly large problem compared to everything else.

“Hi,” He greeted Gorilla as he got in the car, “Thank you for being a reasonable normal person.”

---

“Hey,” a guy Adrien vaguely recognised from the other class as he walked down the corridor at school, “sorry about your girlfriend. I guess even a famous model can’t beat off a superhero.”

Adrien did his best not to scream. “It’s not what it looks like. She’s not like that. *He’*s not like that.”

The guy held his hand up in surrender, “If you say so.”

---

“Are you ok?” Nino asked him, “The whole desk is shaking from your fidgeting.”

He forced his leg still. “I’ve just realised I should have picked Marinette up from the bakery. There’s almost no chance she’s going to get here signicficantly before class starts is there?”

“Uh, no? It’s Marinette. You know last-minute arrivals are basically her thing.”

Maybe Marinette needed an assistant, Adrien thought morosely. He could volunteer Nathalie for the job after she resigned.

“What’s wrong?” Nino said, “It’s not about,”

The unannounced fact of his mother’s death lay between them.

“No it’s nothing about that.” He told his friend, and took out the offending magazine and put it on the desk, “It’s *this.*”

Nino couldn’t know the truth of the story but given he and Marinette had said Chat Noir was a friend he figured it was fair enough to complain a little about this. It would probably look weirder if it didn’t.

His friend made a face, “That totally sucks. Marinette doesn’t deserve that. We all know she’d not two time anyone.”

“Urgh, exactly” he agreed, running his fingers through his father in frustration, “And there are these websites online that are even *worse.* And Nathalie said we could sue if I wanted but also that that might just draw attention to the whole thing so I’ve no idea what to do.”

“But you’re aware of it now?” Alya asked from behind them.

“Alya,” Nino said in warning.

“Look, I didn’t say anything because you didn’t want me to, and I didn’t post anything on the Ladyblog because Adrien and Marinette are my friends but everyone’s posting comments about it anyway and this could be their chance to set the record straight.”

Adrien appraised Alya at the sudden reminder that they had a friendly reporter right here. And if that didn’t work out, well, Marinette babysat for Nadja Chamuck. He was sure she’d give him an interview.

“No, she might have a point,” He said, before Nino could come to his defence again.

Alya was almost vibrating with excitement. “Does this mean I can publish your statements on the Ladyblog?”

“Statements?” asked Adrien confused as to why she already had her phone out and ready when surely she’d now he needed to talk to Marinette first, “Did Nathalie put something out on my behalf?”

“What?” Alya looked at him blankly, “I was talking about what you and Marinette told us the other day in the park. That Chat Noir’s a mutual friend who got you together.”

“Oh. Right. That. Which is true, but I think if it’s going to be published somewhere then I should draft a proper thought out comment instead,”

“Obviously I’d edit it for clarity,”

Adrien interrupted, “And I’ve have to talk to Marinette.”

“Yeah, ok, I guess you do. “ Alya conceded. “But maybe at lunchtime.”

At that point Marinette ran into the room and came to a sudden stop before Adrien.

He’d thought it was because of the magazine in front of him but instead she reached out and started tidying his hair.

It took him a moment to realise that he might have inadvertedly made himself look more like Chat Noir. And while he was fairly certain the Miraculous magic made people harder to recognise-after all not only had he somehow missed Marinette despite how *obvious* it seemed now, there was also the fact that Nathalie might have been blue and had short hair but she *hadn’t even worn a mask,* and he’d never recognised her-right now anything that helped distinguish him and Chat Noir was a good thing.

“Thanks,” He said, honestly meaning it.

Marinette smiled at that.

Then she looked down and saw the magazine and went pale, “What the *hell*?”

---

He almost dragged Marinette out of the classroom at lunchtime. “I think we should go to yours for lunch.”

“Good idea.” She agreed.

---

“It’s alright for you!” Marinette said, “You’re not the one everyone thinks is cheating on your boyfriend *with your boyfriend.* How would you feel if everyone thought you were cheating on me with Ladybug?!”

“Like the entire world should envy me,” was his immediate reaction before he realised that he’d said it out loud on seeing the anger on Marinette’s face, and tried to immediately backtrack. “Not for cheating on you, I didn't mean it like that! Obviously cheating is bad and not aspirational! And I would never do that to you. But I'm already the luckiest guy in the world getting to date you in the first place. And anyone should be jealous of me for getting to date Marinette or Ladybug. Dating both of you-which technically I *am* is double amazing and if it wasn't for everything then I’d be shouting about it to the rooftops.”

Marinette was staring at him, “You make it really hard to stay cross at you, you know.”

Adrien grinned, “You don't really to stay cross at me do you though?”

“I don't know. I might want to one day.”

He couldn’t be offended when she said it smiling like that.

“So, do you know you what want to do about it? Ignore it? Or go the legal route? Or try and make it *very* clear Chat Noir isn’t involved with you somehow?”

“Like how?”

“Well, we could make it clear that Chat Noir’s dating Ladybug.”

Marinette bit her lip, “I don’t think that’s a good idea. I mean if you weren’t *you,*” she gestured to a copy of his perfume ad stuck to the wall, “then maybe. Though we wouldn’t be in this situation then, but, I don’t think it’s a good idea for Chat Noir to start dating Ladybug at the same time as Adrien Agreste starts to date Marinette Dupain-Cheng.”

“You’re probably right,” he agreed even though he really would have preferred that, “Nathalie said the same thing earlier, but what should we do then?”

She looked uncomfortable, “I guess we could pretend Chat Noir was dating someone else. One of the temporary heroes might be happy to fake a relationship with you.”

That idea made him feel like snakes were sliding round in his stomach. “No. I’m sorry, but I’m not doing that except as a last resort.”

Marinette smiled, “I didn’t really like the idea either. I guess we *could* have you interact with Chat Noir somehow. Maybe I could still on the balcony with an illusion of you, and then Chat Noir you could come visit or something?”

“Maybe.”

---

“Oh,” Adrien said, “Can you ask your parents if you could come to mine tonight?”

“Sure. Though I don’t think that I’m going to have many more ideas about how to deal with this by then.”

“So it’s not about that unfortunately.”

“What?”

“Apparently Kagami’s mother is involved in this whole thing somehow. They’re going to tell me this evening.”

Marinette hands went to pull at her fringe, “Why are our lives like this? Can we not just deal with *one* thing at the time.”

“Yeah, that’s what I’ve been asking myself.”

---

“Alright.” Alya said when they gave her their statements on Marinette’s lack of relationship with Chat Noir, “I can put that if you’re sure, but you know, if you ever want to talk off the record about your real relationship then I do totally support you three and I won't publish anything until you’re ready.”

“Our *real* relationship?” Marinette shrieked.

“When you say us three,” Adrien said as the implication hit him and he realised that getting a taste of his own medicine was not that appetising *at all,* “You mean, Marinette, Chat Noir and me?”

“Who else would I mean?”

“There is no three of us,” Marinette said, “Why would you even think that?”

“Babe,” Nino said, “I told you I wasn’t sure they were there yet.”

Adrien felt slightly betrayed, “*You* think we have a thing with Chat Noir too?”

“I only thought you all had feelings for each other.”

“Where did the two of you even get this idea? We told you Chat Noir was our *friend.* Not our mutual boyfriend or whatever.”

“Yeah, but you also told us *Marinette* was just a friend.”

Adrien buried his head in his hands, “This is all my fault isn’t it?”

“Mostly.” Marinette said, and he going even blame her for agreeing when he’d been the one to get caught visiting civilian-her as Chat Noir, and how that he apparently had a reputation for not noticing his own feelings.

"I don't think it's all your fault?" said Nino but he sounded unsure of himself.

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“Oh no,” Marinette's hand tightened on his, then she hissed, “Adrien walk faster, Lila's heading towards us.”

Unfortunately Lila intercepted them before they got to the school gate, and given the bunch of their classmates hanging around by it they couldn’t just run away from her.

“Hi,” she said, “I wanted to catch you at lunch but you didn't seem to be around.”

When Marinette didn't say anything, Adrien offered, “No, we wanted some privacy at lunch, I'm sure you can understand that. And of course Marinette’s parents bakery very tempting at lunchtime.”

“How lucky for you getting extra treats, you’ll make the rest of the class jealous you know. The only place I've been that's better is the most exclusive little bakery back in Rome off the Piazza Navona that does the most amazing amaretti biscuits.”

Lila left a pause as if waiting for a response and with a fixed smile Marinette said, “Thank you so much for saying that.”

Lila smiled, “I hope it doesn’t make things too difficult for Adrien though, modelling demands a certain bodytype. I wouldn’t want to have to befriend another photoshoot buddy.“

“I’m fairly certain I’ll be fine.” Adrien said, “It’s not like I’m banned from eating bread or anything, but thanks for worrying about me. I could have a nutrionist review my diet if you’re that concerned.”

“You’re so lucky to have access to that sort of thing. Of course *I* do, but not everyone does.”

Marinette’s grip on his hand was getting tighter and tigher.

“Anyway,” Lila said, “What I *wanted* to say was that I think it’s really good of you, what you’ve been doing.”

“Been doing?” Adrien asked.

“And to say Congratulations to Marinette of course. Chat Noir’s always seemed like a great guy when I’ve met him.”

“Oh,” Marinette said, “I hadn’t realised you two had spoken so much all those times you got akumatised. And congratulations aren’t necessary because Chat Noir and I aren’t together. But we are friends, and now I think of it you two must have spoken because he was just saying about how it seemed like you needed some sort of support, with the insecurity your akumas suggested about you. Have you considered seeing some sort of therapist?”

“How sweet of him to worry about me. But it’s alright Marinette you don’t have to pretend you and Chat Noir aren’t in a relationship any more. And you and Adrien don’t have to pretend to be in a relationship to hide that anymore.”

“Marinette and I aren’t in a fake relationship,” Adrien snapped and he was *very* close to being much ruder than that to Lila, “She’s the love of my life and I’m sorry for you if you can’t

recognise that because you don't have that with anyone, but I hope you do one day."

Lila started blinking and her eyes looked suspiciously watery, "I'm sorry Adrien. I didn't realise I'd got it so wrong. It's just I was *so* sure Marinette would never cheat on you,"

"I'm not." Marinette said.

"But everyone said,"

"You shouldn't believe everything you read." Adrien said, "Especially now you're modelling, and people might write odd things about you too, but seriously Chat Noir is just a friend. And even though he might be the one guy in Paris I could accept losing Marinette to I know that I *never* ever will."

"Wow, you're so trusting."

"Thanks, but honestly when you know the people in question as well as I do, it's not hard at all." He pulled slighted on Marinette hand as he took a step back, "Come on Marinette, Gorilla's here. We should get going before my father gets upset we're late."

"Of course," Lila said, "I'd hate to get you in trouble at home."

# Chapter 15

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Nathalie let him and Marinette in the door. “Your father’s waiting in the dining room to talk to you.”

It all felt eerily reminiscent of the other day. “Is this going to be a recurring theme?”

“I’d like to think not.” She looked tired. “I really would like to think not.”

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“So, what’s this whole thing about Kagami’s mother?” Adrien asked once they were sat down.

“I have to talk to Mme. Tsurugi to clarify some matters before we announce that your mother's passed away.”

“Before? Why?”

His father glanced back at Nathalie. “She was aware of my activities, and of the Miraculous. If she heard about your mother she might interpret it incorrectly.”

“She was *what?”* burst out of Adrien before he could even process that, “Kagami’s mother knew you were Hawkmoth? I thought Aunt Amélie knowing about the Miraculous was bad enough. Who *else* might know something?”

“Audrey Bourgeois.” Nathalie admitted.

*“Chloé’s mother?* But you akumatised her. *Twice.*”

Was *every* adult in his life in on this?

“She didn’t know I was Hawkmoth. Only of Emilie’s interest in the Miraculous and of that last trip to Tibet.”

By the standards of the house he’d been raised in Adrien was starting to think that he was actually pretty good at thinking things through, even if his girlfriend might think otherwise because, “Did you not consider that maybe that made akumatisating her *just* a little risky?”

“It wasn’t *the* riskiest of his plans in fairness.” Nathalie said. “She’d have been more likely to come here to confront him than to expose us. And she was Emilie’s friend too.”

“What was risker than giving someone who might work out you were Hawkmoth a reason to want to expose you exactly?” Other than going out in public yourself when you had a Miraculous whose powers meant you didn’t have to, and other than, “Oh right, Simon Says. What the hell was *that?*”

His father did at least seem somewhat embarrassed. “On balance it seemed worth the risk.”

“You literally could have jumped off a building.”

“Marinette would have brought me back.”

“If we’d *won.* Urgh,” he pulled at his hair in desperation, “Nathalie, did you not try and *stop* any of these plans? You’re supposed to be the sensible one.”

“He wouldn’t have listened to me. Not then.”

“That must have changed at some point.”

“There were worse plans we didn’t do.”

“There were *what?*”

“How did we never not get your Miraculouses earlier?” Marinette said next to him, but it was pretty clear it was a rhetorical question even if Adrien was thinking the exact same thing.

“There was a reason I generally didn't leave the house as Hawkmoth,” his father said, and Adrien resisted the urge to point out he rarely left anyway, “And why is Nathalie the sensible one?”

This time Adrien just looked at his father.

“*I* wasn’t the one who used a broken Miraculous.”

“I couldn't let you be caught.” Nathalie said.

“You didn't have to keep using it.”

“We’ve discussed this.”

“I think we’re getting off topic.” Marinette said, “You said Chloé’s mother knew about that Miraculous but *not* about Hawkmoth, but Kagami’s mother did?”

“One would assume so.”

“*Assume so?”* Adrien asked, “What do you mean *assume* so?”

That really did not feel like the sort of thing you assumed.

“Tomoe had an interest in the Miraculous too. Not in the same way as your mother, but from what she’d told her about them she became interested in how their abilities could be technologically replicated. Informally she used to help your mother look into them and lend

her equipment to help. After I lost Emilie I," he hesitated, "formalised that agreement with her. Use of Tsurugi technology in return for information and study of the Miraculous jewels especially your two. Given that, and given what she knew about Emilie, and a few encouraging things she's said since I can't see that she wouldn't know."

"But you didn't actually discuss it fully with her?"

"It seemed unnecessary."

"And again, you akumatised her?"

"I can't see she'd be bothered. It's no loss of face in public. You two have made it very clear that my targets are victims not perpetrators, and it certainly got her point across to her daughter."

Marinette fidgeted next to him, "But you akumatised Kagami too. She doesn't seem like she'd be impressed by that."

"You might be right, that could have been a mistake but thankfully she's never complained about it."

"Not the only mistake made that day." Nathalie muttered.

Adrien wasn't sure it that had been meant to be heard but he answered it anyway. "I don't thinking wanting to let my school friends come in to do homework is a mistake generally. Even if Lila was."

"Seriously." Marinette said, "You might not know what she's like but I really wouldn't use her in campaigns if I were you. She's *awful.* And someday it all has to come out."

His father and Nathalie looked at each other and had some silent conversation before his father said. "I wouldn't say we were completely unaware of Mlle. Rossi's character."

"I'm sorry what?" Adrien said, "Why let her do photoshoots with me then?"

"She was really good at creating the situation for an akuma."

He was deeply temped to take Nino up on his offer and leave the house right now, "*You used me as Lila-bait for akumas?"*

"In fairness I also used her to get information about your school life."

"Why would you think that made it better?"

"Because I was worried about you?"

"Did you consider *asking* me about my school life? It's not like you could trust what she said anyway."

Adrien had been there and willing to answer any question he might have had had his father just emerged to *talk* to him.

Marinette was frowning, “Did *Lila* know you were Hawkmoth?”

“No.” His father said.

“Maybe.” Nathalie said.

“Um.” Adrien responded.

“She didn’t.” His father said to Nathalie, “Just because she kept us informed of events that we then used to akumatise people *and* she got akumatised voluntarily doesn’t mean she knew I was Hawkmoth.”

“Lila got akumatised *voluntarily?”* Marinette said, “Why am I not surprised.”

“What does that even mean?” Adrien asked, “Like, can you just *ask* to be akumatised? *Did* she just ask?”

“You still have to feel the emotion. But yes, she said she looked forward to being akumatised again when I assumed was an open invitation.”

“What does that actually *mean*?” asked Marinette, “Lila always seemed more like herself than the other akumas but, how different is it if you want to be akumatised?”

“You remember it. Sort of.” Nathalie said, “Fuzzily. And you’re not not-yourself exactly in the same way, you’re just. I don’t know, laser-focused on that one desire? You don’t mind about normal concerns and constraints. And it’s easier to do what you want rather than what Hawkmoth wants than for involuntary akumatisations. I think anyway. I’ve never been akumatised involuntarily but from what other people have said it sounded different.”

It made sense that any akumatisation of Nathalie was something she’d wanted, and honestly it *really* raised more questions about his father’s actions when he’d been akumatised and how they’d reacted, but, “When did you get akumatised?”

“Scarlet Moth. I could increase his powers.”

“*That’s* how you did it?” Marinette said, “I couldn’t work it out. I thought there must be some power-up potion we’d missed or something. I couldn’t work out why you didn’t do it again.”

“It didn’t seem to interact well with damage I’d taken from the Peacock Miraculous.” She said bluntly.

“Oh.” Marinette said.

His father had gone oddly pale during the conversation, “Nathalie, you were akumatised when you decided to use the Peacock Miraculous weren’t you? You weren’t in your right mind.”

“I had to break out of it to put it on so, no I wasn’t akumatised then. You must know that.”

“I hadn’t thought about it.”

“I can’t see that you need to now.”

“*Nathalie.*”

“We’ll talk about it later. The children don’t need to be here stuck listening to that conversation.”

“Ok,” Marinette said, “Putting aside the questions I have about akumatisations, *and* assuming that you’re no longer going to force Adrien to spend time with Lila.”

Both adults thankfully nodded.

“I already told her that her offer to comfort Adrien over Marinette’s relationship with Chat Noir was unnecessary. As was her offer to publicly date him to show he was unaffected and still desirable.” Nathalie said.

“I knew she was up to something.” Marinette said. “We *have* to do something about her.”

“What can we do though?” Adrien asked, “I get she apparently wants to date me, but I don’t see how we could fix that.”

“I still think we should set her up with Felix.”

“We’re not doing that.”

“Gabriel,” Nathalie said suddenly, “Is Bob Roth still trying to get costumes for XY on the cheap?”

“You know he is.”

“How badly offended would you be at the idea of using him in a campaign?”

“That might work actually. Would you be bothered by that Adrien?”

“Why would I be bothered?”

Less photoshoots *and* someone else having to deal with Lila on set sounded utterly fantastic to Adrien.

“It’d be *your* place he’d take.”

He’d worked that out and, “That is completely fine with me. It’s not like I care about my profile as a model apart from how it affects you.”

“Really?” He looked shocked by that, which Adrien did not understand at all but, “That could work then.”

“Are you suggesting trying to re-direct Lila’s attention’s from Adrien to XY?” Marinette said, “I’m worried that you’re a bad influence on me because I think I might actually be ok with that. Even though it is *really* weird that you’re interfering in the relationships of unrelated teenagers.”

“Trust me, we’d be happy to stop after this.” Nathalie picked up her phone, “Lila’s very fond of sending *a lot* of messages.”

“I could see that.” Marinette agreed. “So ignoring Lila for a moment, is Mme. Tsurugi actually going to be a problem?”

Adrien could see the consideration on their faces.

“I don’t think so.” His father said eventually, “She’ll be disappointed but we both had exit clauses on our contact, that I might want to use one was always a possibility, and I don’t think she’d go as far as going after the Miraculous herself. I always got the sense she found that part vaguely distasteful.”

“So are you going to just call her and tell her or what?”

“It probably deserves a face-to-face meeting.” His father said looking disgruntled at the idea, “Could you set one up please Nathalie?”

“For when we can be here.” Adrien added.

“I’m sorry?” Nathalie said.

“We need to know what she says.”

“She’s not going to allow you to sit in on a meeting Adrien. And it’s not like we have our Miraculous anymore, we’re not going to do anything to you.”

“You could tell her who we are.” Marinette pointed out.

“How on earth would that benefit me?” His father said.

Actually he was probably right about both those points, “Well at least do it while *I’m here* even if I have to wait in the foyer.”

“I could try for the late afternoon after you’re back from school.” Nathalie said. “I’ll let you know. And um, Marinette I realise this is a bad time but did you have any ideas about Amélie’s request?”

“I have,” his girlfriend said, and Adrien looked at her in surprise as she hadn’t mentioned that to him, “but it sounds like we shouldn’t do anything until you sort things out with Mme. Tsurugi.”

“Seriously Adrien,” Marinette said before she left, “You do not have to stay with these people.”

“They’re my family.”

“That doesn’t mean you have to stay with them.”

“I know.” And he *did,* and he knew he shouldn’t but, “I want to though.”

“Well if you father ever pulls something like that move with Lila again then let me know, and he’ll be in prison faster than you can say Miraculous Ladybug.”

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“Hi Kagami,” Adrien said, as she followed her mother in the door. “I didn’t realise you were coming.”

He’d been thinking of making a stand and claiming he had to be part of his father and her mother’s meeting by claiming he was shadowing his father to learn the business but he couldn’t do that in front of Kagami. She *knew* he wasn’t interested in following in his father’s footsteps, and she’d think he was just trying to avoid her.

And he kind of had been trying to avoid her while he’d been working out what to say to her but that was different to just rudely abandoning her in the foyer when the adults went in the Atelier.

“When my mother offered the chance to see you I took it. You know how it is.”

“Yeah I do.”

“Adrien.” She clenched her hands into fists, and Adrien winced, he’d definitely already upset her, “Have you been avoiding me deliberately?”

It seemed worse to lie about it when an excuse clearly wouldn’t be believed, “A little.”

“Is this because of Marinette?”

“I’m sorry. I know I should have told you. But I just didn’t know what to say, I didn’t want to hurt your feelings.”

“So the two of you are together then?”

“We are, and ignore all that nonsense about Chat Noir, he’s just a friend of Marinette’s, it’s,”

She interrupted him. “I know. I never believed any of that. Marinette’s honourable. She’s an honourable opponent, and I can accept when I’ve lost. I can hardly complain that she put you above our friendship when I did the same. But I thought the two of you respected me enough to *tell* me, instead of leaving me thinking I had a chance until I saw pictures of you two in a magazine.”

“I didn’t mean to lie to you. I’ve just had a really busy time of it lately,”

“I know. We’ve been doing extra fencing *together.*”

“And then, when I realised I hadn’t said anything I didn’t how to say it, and then maybe I overthought it, and you’ve *right.* It was bad of me not to say anything. I’m sorry.”

“Thank you.”

“I hope we can all still be friends?” He said holding out a hand. “I don’t what to think we’ve ruined our friendship with you.”

Especially given that he knew Kagami was just as busy, and had just as controlled a schedule as he did. If not more so. He really did feel bad since he didn’t think she had that many other friends.

She didn’t take it. “Maybe in the future. I meant what I said, I can respect that you’re with Marinette now but I’m not ready to be able to hang out with the two of you and watch you as a couple.”

“I am sorry.”

“It’s not your fault. Apart from the not telling me. But maybe we should try to find other partners for fencing for a while.”

“OK?”

She got out a pair of headphones and put them on, and took out her phone clearly signalling that the conversation was over from her perspective.

He wasn’t sure it if was weirder it he just left her there or if he stayed here with her in awkward silence.

Eventually he took his own phone out figuring that at least he could pretend that he wasn’t still stuck on their conversation but he then he was distracted by yelling coming from the Atelier.

Kagami took off her headphones and looked at the door quizzically, “That’s not like my mother.”

“That *is* like my father.”

“With business partners?”

“Yeah, at times.”

Then her mother opened the door, “I hope you think about what you’ve done Gabriel.” She said back into the room, “Come on Kagami, we’re leaving.”

His father and Nathalie followed her out of the room but neither tried to stop her leaving.

“That didn't go well then?” Adrien asked, once Mme. Tsurugi had stalked out the door with her head held high.

It was a rather silly question given her reaction, and that his father looked like he wanted to punch the wall next to him.

Nathalie shrugged, and sat down on the stairs.

“I have never been so insulted in my life.” His father snarled, “To accuse me of *that,* and claim I was reneging on our deal having got what I wanted, as if even at my worst I’d ever have entertained that suggestion. It’s insulting. To *all* of us. And going from someone Emilie and I had such a long association with, someone who’s seen us together Nathalie. *Really.* What on earth was Tomoe thinking?”

Adrien sat down beside Nathalie confused by the bored expression on her face as she watched his father continue to rant, now apparently about how they have perfectly reasonable withdrawal terms in their deal, and that should have shown he might decide to stop, and not that he didn’t have commitment.

“Should we say something?” He asked.

“Not yet.” She replied.

“What happened?”

“She suggested he’d given up on the Miraculous because he settled for transferring your mother’s consciousness into my body.”

“She *what?*”

“I know. I don’t act anything like your mother and she knows what we both act like.”

“And I thought Alya and Nino had ridiculous ideas.”

That seemed to catch Nathalie’s attention and she looked away from his father, “What was their idea? Something about the whole thing with Chat Noir?”

“They think the *three* of us are in a relationship.”

Nathalie blinked. “Oh.”

“Yeah.”

“I *did* anticipate that as a possible rumour but I wasn’t expecting it to come from people you actually know.”

“Well I didn’t anticipate it at all.”

Nathalie, looked at him, and appeared oddly uncertain, “Adrien, is there a reason,”

His father interrupted them, “Nathalie, why does everybody think I want to kill you?”

“I really don’t think everyone thinks that.” She said.

“I didn’t think that.” Adrien offered. “I kind of assumed me and Nathalie were the only people you’d try and keep safe from your wish.”

“See.” Nathalie said.

“Thank you. The two of you are very convincing.” His father said drily, but at least he seemed in less of rage, “But *you* thought so, Nathalie.”

“I didn’t think you *wanted* to kill me.”

“But you thought I’d *accept it,* and now Tomoe apparently thought I’d kill you to use your body as a vessel for Emilie, what next? Is Audrey going to, I don’t even know.”

“Suggest that you should drown me in a vat of dye for not knowing the difference between cyan and turquoise?”

“Why did you have a suggestion for that?”

He’d been thinking the same thing honestly.

“She threatens her assistants all the time. We do talk.” Nathalie said.

That seemed to distract his father from his annoyance. “Wait. What do you tell them about *me?*”

“Anyway,” Nathalie said instead of answering his question, “I really doubt she’d actually think that given that I’m pretty sure she’d still be seething about you not firing me not seating her in the front row if she was actually capable of remembering who I was.”

“I’m sure she knows who you are.”

“I have literally seen her call her daughter by the wrong name. I highly doubt she knows mine.”

“In fairness I think it’s usually other members’ of her family’s names. People do do that.”

“If you say so.”

“And that’s not the point. The point is *why do people keep thinking this of me.*”

Adrien didn't point out that his father had literally been a supervillain for a year, and that did tend to affect what people thought you were capable of.

"Gabriel come here." Nathalie said.

He sat down next to them and she took his face in her hands, "*You're* always telling *me* that it doesn't matter what other people think, this is no different."

"But,"

"You and I both know you wouldn't have done that."

"I do but,"

"Trust me, even if I thought you'd let me die for Emilie, I never thought you'd do *that*. And you've made it very clear recently that you wouldn't have let me do what I'd planned anyway."

"You know that now?"

"I do."

"I'm glad," He smiled slightly, and wrapped an arm around Nathalie's back, "but,"

"No buts. I know you actually value her opinion of you, but this has been a shock for her. Emilie was her friend too, and you know she had real hopes for what she could create with whatever you found out. She'll come around."

"How are you so calm about this?"

"Practice."

"I really don't deserve you." His father said gazing into Nathalie's eyes and it made Adrien feel a little awkward, as if he shouldn't be watching this.

"Should I leave?" he asked.

Both of their heads shot round, and he was pretty sure they'd forgotten he was there.

"I mean if the two of you are going to kiss or something then I should probably leave." He said and stood it.

"We're weren't, that is," Nathalie stuttered incoherently.

"You can leave if you want Adrien." His father said.

"I'm going to do that."

"Wait," Nathalie said, "You need to let Marinette know what's happened and that we're ready for whatever she's deceived about Amelie's request."

He'd noticed that neither his father nor Nathalie seemed comfortable referring to that request as what it actually was and he wondered if that should worry him, but then he *wasn't* either and he certainly wasn't planning to try to terrorise a city to get his mother back.

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"Adrien." His father said.

"Yes?" he said looking up from his homework, torn between confusion and concern about why his father had come to find him now.

"Nathalie thought I should speak to you."

"OK?" He was leaning more towards confusion right now.

"I am." He paused. "Aware of the issues you and Marinette are having with the press."

Despite the proven terribleness of his father's plans Adrien still couldn't help but hope, "Did you have an idea for how we could cope with them?"

"Several."

He didn't say anything more though forcing Adrien to ask. "Are you going to tell me them?"

The tension in his father's face was palpable and Adrien really wasn't sure why, "That's not what Nathalie thought I should speak to you about.

"What did Nathalie think you should speak to me about?"

"She said your friends thought you and Marinette were dating Chat Noir?"

"OK, so we told them we weren't so you don't have to worry about it being bad press for the brand or anything."

"That wasn't my concern."

"What was your concern then?"

"Adrien. Is there a reason your friends thought you might be dating Chat Noir?"

"What?" What sort of question was that, "What are you asking if I talk myself up all the time? I don't think so, I generally prefer to praise Ladybug if we're talking about the heroes of Paris."

"Yes, I'd assume you would."

"Then what are you asking?"

“You’re a boy.”

“Yes?”

“You’re also Chat Noir.”

“Yes?”

“Chat Noir is generally perceived to be a boy.”

“Yes-wait, what do you mean generally *perceived?*”

“It doesn’t matter.”

“I feel like it maybe matters.”

“Look, I read a *lot* of speculation about Ladybug and Chat Noir when we were trying to defeat you, it doesn’t matter.”

“OK,” not really because Adrien just had *so many questions* right now, “but what are you actually trying to ask me?”

“Your friends idea, it was that this was an equal thing between the three of you right?”

“Yes, but,” Finally he managed to assemble what his father had said into something that resembled a question people might actually ask. “Wait. Are you asking me if I’m bisexual?”

“Are you?”

That had been a really strangled way to ask that, and Adrien would have said that if it wasn’t for the fact he didn’t know, “Would that bother you?”

“Adrien I work in *fashion.* And you apparently thought it was plausible I was dating Hawkmoth, I thought,” he cut himself off, “The point is are you?”

“I don’t think so? But I don’t know, I’ve been attracted to like, 3 people ever and they’re all girls but on the other hand two of them were the same person so I don’t know that’s that indicative really.”

“Right.”

The silence that fell felt more awkward than not.

“So, um, what plans did you have about my and Marinette’s issue.”

“I’ve been told that that was up to you and Marinette to work out. *I* was planning on ignoring anybody that asked about it, but if it fitted with what the two of you had decided I am willing to make a show of showing we don’t disapprove.”

“Like what?”

“I assume you’ll want her there at the funeral.”

“Oh yeah. That.”

“Well. Yes. And I suppose we could all go out for dinner, but not until after that’s happened.”

“Why not?”

“Nathalie and I appearing together in a non-professional setting would certainly have the effect of drowning out your set of rumours but perhaps not quite in the way that you want. Or that we want.”

“Right. Yeah. I can see that.” Adrien had become so used to the idea that he’d forgotten how it might look to other people which admittedly probably wasn’t good.

“It’s not as if half the country doesn’t think I’ve killed your mother anyway.”

“They *what*?”

“No one’s said that to you?”

“No, no they hadn’t. Why on earth would people say that to me?”

His father looked disbelieving, “People must have become politer since I stopped going out.”

“That’s a horrible thing to think.”

“They’re not *entirely* wrong I suppose.”

That was a maudlin thing to say, and combined with how he’d reacted to being accused of killing Nathalie today he wasn’t sure he liked the picture he painted.

“It *is*. Unless you’ve been lying to me then you didn’t kill her. The Peacock Miraculous did.”

“The Peacock Miraculous she’d never have had without me.”

“You don’t know that.”

“I suppose not. Thank you.”

“So,” he tried to stir it back to less upsetting topics, “You really don’t have any ideas for when people think civilian-you is mixed up with superhero-you?”

“I think you saw my idea for that.”

“I did unfortunately,” and he was now trying to bleach the image from his mind now he was starting to be able to see his father and Nathalie as people capable of that, “But Marinette doesn’t think Chat Noir having a public display of affection, or an announcement we’re dating or something, with Ladybug is a good idea. She’s concerned people might work out her identity from it.”

“Understandable.”

“And I’m not even going to pretend to date anyone other than her, and even though she’s got the whole Miracle Box we can’t just have her use another Miraculous for no reason than to be seen with me. Think how that would make its usual wielder feel.”

“Is there no Miraculous Marinette could use? She has used others before hasn’t she? Though I guess she couldn’t be Lady Noir.”

Adrien gasped. It had been in front of him all the time. “*Multimouse.* Chat Noir can date Multimouse.”

“Multimouse….is also Marinette?”

“Yes.”

His father shook his head, “I’m not even surprised anymore.”

Chapter End Notes

OK, so I might *maybe* have the end of this fic in sight now 🤞

# Chapter 16

Ladybug knocked on Adrien's window.

Letting her in he said, "I thought you didn't want to start more rumours."

Although people thinking Adrien Agreste was dating Ladybug, and Marinette was dating Chat Noir, and that the two of them were hiding it *would* be closer to the truth than any other rumours had been that was what made it dangerous.

Marinette glanced back at the window, "I checked if anyone was around first. And I got Nathalie to send me plans of your house to work out what angles could be seen on the street. So I think we should be fine. And it seemed right to come as Ladybug for this somehow."

He could kind of understand that but he was struck by something there, "You and Nathalie talk?"

He knew they had the other day, but not that they talked outside that.

"We message."

"You have her phone number?"

"Yeah, she gave it to me the other day."

"Oh right. I guess that makes sense." Even if for some reason the idea felt unsettling to him, which was weird when he wanted Nathalie and Marinette to get on, and he didn't think they'd plan anything together that didn't have his best interests at heart. "I'd had some thoughts about what we could do about me and you actually."

"I think Chat Noir should just stay as far away from me-as-Marinette as possible and then maybe in like a month or two or so Ladybug and Chat Noir could start dating." She said sounding tired.

"That could work," He said hastily shelving his plan for Chat to date Mulitmouse *and* the elaborate rooftop dinner he'd planned for that, though he guessed the latter *could* work for when Chat Noir started dating Marinette,

"So um, you have a plan?"

"Yeah," She detransformed and took the Butterfly Miraculous out of her bag.

Eying one half of what had allowed all of what had happened with his family to happen he asked, "You're not going to give it to him are you?"

It wasn't that he didn't believe his father when he said he'd accepted things and didn't regret giving up the Miraculous but it was easier to trust him when there *wasn't* any Miraculous there for him to misuse.

“No.” Marinette said relieving him, “Or I hope not at least but Nooroo says I shouldn’t find his Miraculous too hard to use myself. Apparently Tikki’s impressed him with talk of my creativity. “

“You're going to akumatise him?”

“It seems fitting. And that way I should be able to monitor what he's doing.”

“Even that far away?”

“I mean it's not like he's going into space. And I can’t see him making a break for it while you and Nathalie are both here.”

“That's... Probably true.” Adrien admitted. “And given everything that's came out recently I’d almost be more surprised if it turned out my Aunt *couldn’t* look after herself if something happened there.”

“And I’m only planning on giving him teleportation powers. It's not like it should go *that* wrong.”

---

Seeing Marinette as Hawkmoth was *weird.* Not that she’d be called Hawkmoth. But. Hawkmoth. Marinette. Weird.

Because he *could* actually recognise her, and he guessed he did when she was Ladybug now too, and he wondered if whatever Miraculous masking magic there was failed when you knew who someone was and if everyone else would look like themselves to him now too.

But the fact remained that lacking the cowl his father wore as Hawkmoth it was very easy to still recognise Marinette under the butterfly shaped lilac and silver iridescent mask she wore instead, even if it did cover more of her face than Ladybug’s.

And maybe because the Butterfly Miraculous holder could do their work from a distance it was a Marinette with her hair down, and that was *really* unfair, because Marinette with her hair down was even more beautiful than Marinette normally and that was a really confusing thing to notice when despite the purple suit she was wearing being cut differently, more like the shape of the trousers and jacket she favoured in their normal life, her outfit was *still* recognisable as Hawkmoth’s.

Then his confused swirl of emotions changed to pure panic as she collapsed to her knees, “Wings down.”

Adrien knelt down to help her up, “Are you alright?”

She clasped on his arm tightly to support herself but she said, “I will be. Just,” she looked up at his father, “How did you bear it? All that emotion?”

“You get used to the Miraculous over time. And I avoided people as much as possible, it’s harder in close proximity. You could do it from upstairs if you wanted.”

“Wait,” Adrien realised, “*That’s* why you basically stopped leaving the house?”

“It was part of it. It was to avoid intrusive questions about your mother too, and I did generally prefer working that way anyway. So I’m not going to suddenly start going out all the time of *that’s* what you're thinking.”

“That's part of what I was asking.” Marinette said looking between them all, “I mean I did mean how did you bear the Miraculous but, your *grief,* how do you bear *that?”*

“I didn’t.”

“Right.” She shook her head as if annoyed at herself for forgetting, “Hawkmoth. And neglecting Adrien.”

His father shrugged in defeat.

“But,” Marinette chewed her lip, “Are you going to be ok now? I thought you *were* ok-that everything was working out for you, but feeling *that,* you’re not over her *at all.* I don't even know if I'll be able to akumatise you for this when you still feel like that about her.”

“You will.” His father said. “I’m not *over* her. How can I be? She was my wife, she’s the mother of my son, she was years of my life. I can't just suddenly decide that I’m ready to let her go and be fine with it. But I am ready to let her go. I’m going to miss her. I do miss her. And I can't pretend I don't feel guilty for not saving her. But I can’t. And I accept that now. I can accept she's gone. And that being the case I don't want to keep her like this any longer. I want to say goodbye properly. And if you use that Miraculous right you'll be able to find that desire and work with it.”

“He’s not lying,” Nooroo said, and the Kwami sounded relieved, “I can feel it. We could build something on that.”

“I don't know if I can.” Marinette said. “I barely coped with it for that long, everything was just overwhelming, even the nice things,” she glanced at Adrien and his stomach dropped as he realised Marinette had *felt* his reaction to seeing her like that, but then she didn't seem to mind so maybe it was ok, “But all of your feelings that was just. A lot.” She pointed at Nathalie, “And *you,* you look so unaffected all the time, how do you do that when beneath you’re feeling all of that?”

“When you reach a certain level of stress it just becomes your new default.”

Marinette blinked. “That’s terrifying.”

Nathalie seemed unbothered, “If you don’t feel comfortable *I* could try akumatising him. If you trust me that is. I don't think it works that differently to the Peacock.”

“I don't think that's a good idea.” His father said.

“Why?” Nathalie frowned slightly, “Are you worried about me sensing your emotions?”

“No, if anyone knows my feelings already it's you. I just don’t think you using any Miraculous is a good idea for your health.”

Her defensiveness melted away, and she put a hand on his arm, “I don't think it'd make me any worse.”

“We don't know that.” His father said, and Adrien was struck by the concern in his eyes.

“I don't think it's a good idea either.” Marinette said, “From what I know I think it's safest that you don't use any Miraculous for a very long time.”

Nathalie looked almost amused, “I don't exactly see any Miraculous use in my future.”

They all fell silent at the reminder of the situation, until Marinette broke out looking at Nathalie, “What you said, haven't you used the Butterfly Miraculous before?”

“What?” To someone who knew her as well as Adrien did she looked confused, “No.”

“But he,” she gestured to his father, “was akumatised.”

“I akumatised myself.” His father said.

“You can do that?”

“Yes.”

“Isn't that kind of dangerous? You wouldn't have any control over yourself then.”

“Perhaps. Though I had the advantage that no one else was going to take the brooch and try to command me. And I had Nathalie of course.”

“*Another* person with the Butterfly Miraculous can communicate with Akumas even they weren't the one to correct it.”

“Yes,” his father said somewhat chagrined, “Not that they’d necessarily be able to command it but that applies to all Akumas. Certainly I struggled with mine at times.”

Nathalie looked uncomfortable, “Did you two hear Timetagger talking to Gabriel about how there’s a future Hawkmoth? But you've the Butterfly Miraculous now, how could that happen?”

Adrien tried to make sense of all of this, “Maybe we’ve changed what's going to happen? Bunnyx said time was delicate.”

“Or maybe I'm going to trust the wrong person with this.” Marinette said uneasily, then she shook her head, “That’s something to think about another time though. Right now,” she pulled the brooch off her top and walked over to his father. “Here.”

“You're *giving* it to me?”

“To akumatise yourself. I’m trusting you. Don’t make me regret this.”

Though he took the brooch from her hand immediately for a long moment his father didn’t move, and just stared at it before he eventually pinned it on.

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So it turned out *knowing* his father was Hawkmoth and *seeing* his father turn into Hawkmoth weren’t actually the same thing, and the former was *much worse.*

The performance of watching him address himself though *did* feel weirdly in character.

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Adrien stared at, well the Akuma hadn’t actually named itself so he wasn’t quite sure, and wondered at the monochrome colour scheme right down to the grey skin, at whether that was meant to be mourning colours or what. In some ways this felt more disconcerting than the Collector had, with how the eyes were still visible, with the glasses transformed into goggles instead of a visor.

His father took a step towards Nathalie, and for a moment Adrien panicked thinking something had gone wrong because it was the *wrong woman* he seemed about to target, and what if he didn't really know what he was doing, or what if he and Marinette had got it wrong, and this was his father and Nathalie’s plan to run away or something.

His concern only rose when Nathalie took his hand, but she said, “It's ok. Go on,” and pulled it to the casket latch.

Adrien’s breath caught in his throat as the glass opened and his mother was no longer caught behind it.

And he should have asked them to do this before, so he could say goodbye without that separation from her and he found his feet taking him forward before he could stop himself.

His father, or *not* his father, because Adrien might have thought his father was cold before but this grey gaze was utterly inhuman, looked down at him and said, “Did you want to come? You'll have to hold onto my arm, I can't spare a hand.”

It was a very practical way of saying that his arms were full because he was carrying Adrien’s mother.

But then *Adrien's father,* grieved his mother, this Akuma born from a desire to let her go and lay her to rest, who know what *his* feelings about her might be.

He reached out and took his arm anyway. Perhaps because he wanted to be sure everything was went right.

Nathalie looked pale but she didn't say anything.

“Adrien,” Marinette screamed.

“Don't worry.” He lied, “I know what I'm doing.”

The air rippled around them like a special effect on an old science fiction TV show and then he was almost blinded by a kaleidoscope of colours before he found the three of them no longer in the basement but in a cosy little sitting room.

His aunt looked up from the couch, “I wasn’t expecting you to bring Adrien.”

No response was forthcoming so Adrien felt the need to say, “Is that a problem?”

Amélie softened, “Of course not, I know this must be very hard for you.”

Then she stood up and hugged him. “You’re a very brave boy Adrien.”

“Where are we?”

“A cottage on the family estate. It felt right that she would have come home to die.”

She hadn’t. In fact she’d refused to die, and refused to confide in anyone other than her husband. But Adrien didn’t point that out to his Aunt.

She looked back at her sister cradled in the Akuma’s arms. “Sit her down here then.”

“Won’t people be suspicious?” Adrien asked, “If you just, what, claim to have found her here?”

“I’ve made arrangements. I know people who can ensure it never grows into anything, and,” She looked down at a letter on the table with her name written on the front, “it helps that her and my handwriting is identical.  Besides,” She took her sister’s hand looking wistful, “I understand from your father that all the evidence will back up our story of her wanting to keep her terminal illness secret until the end.”

“Right.” He said, almost wishing he hadn’t asked, much as she’d been subtle about just calling it evidence rather than saying his mother’s body under any autopsy. “I don’t know how to say goodbye.”

“Just say it. It’ll make you feel better. Felix struggled too, but he’s dealing with it now.”

Marinette ran up to him when as the repository blinked back into existence around them. “Are you ok?”

“Something like that.” He said, not sure if it was true, but knowing that at least here with her arms around him it was better.

She let go of him, “Sorry, I have to cleanse the akuma.”

“No, of course.”

It was probably the easiest defeat they’d ever had if you could really call it a defeat when his father hadn’t fought Nathalie when she pulled the goggles off his face, and passed them to Marinette.

Though it was a good thing that she had when she had because he was fairly certain that the akuma *had* been about to take her somewhere now and where that had been he had no idea, especially as his father was now claiming he had no idea either.

Personally Adrien thought that maybe he *did* have some idea.

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“We should drive Marinette home,” his father said eventually.

“Oh, you don’t have to." She said.  "I came here as Ladybug.”

“I think it’s a good idea. For Adrien and I to be seen out and about tonight. Nathalie had thought maybe the three of us should go out for dinner, but I don’t think any of us are feeling up to that.”

“Yeah,” Adrien said, “I’m definitely not, but I’m not sure the car is exactly going to prove anything, so it’s fine, I can escort Marinette home if you’re not feeling up to anything.”

“I think that’s the opposite of a solution to *your* situation.” Nathalie said.

Oh right. He was supposed to *not* be having Chat Noir involved with Marinette anymore. Not that he would be since it would be *Ladybug* Chat Noir would be out with but if they got caught near her house together then people would definitely put two and two together.

Or think they were in some sort of love quadrangle or square or something though he wasn’t even sure how that would *work.*

So that probably wasn’t the best idea.

“Maybe you should drive her home, but um, Marinette? Do your parents know you’re out?”

“Not exactly. But *they're* actually out tonight so it's not really a problem.”

“Could you stay here a while longer?”

“Yes, yes of course.”

Neither adult said anything to argue with this.

As they headed back up Adrien heard his father ask Nathalie, “Well, is there *work* I can do at least?”

“Funny you should ask. There are some calls to Americans that it would be helpful if you made tonight.”

“What would I do without you?”

Adrien was pretty sure work was not a very good way to cope with grief, and he really hoped this wasn't his father's new plan for dealing with it, because he had hoped that *maybe* in a post-Hawkmoth world they'd have more time together, and maybe therapy *would* be a good idea.

---

Adrien was surprised to see his father there when he went for breakfast.

His presence was explained when he looked up from the tablet he was only pretending to read based on the lack of scrolling and said, “Your Aunt's informed the authorities of your mother's death.”

“OK.” He said, and he had assumed she would but he still thought, “That was quick.”

“She's never been one to hesitate. She and your mother are rather alike that way.”

That did seem to fit with his memories of his mother in a way so much of the rest didn't and that made him say, “Can, can we talk about Maman sometime? I miss her, but I realise there's so much I don't know about her too.”

His father's grip on his tablet tightened, and as his expression somehow became hardened Adrien braced himself for an explosion but all he said in the end was, “I can. Try. I suppose.”

It sounded like the words were being forced out of him but it was still more than Adrien had expected.

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Nino's face came up on his phone, and Adrien knew he'd heard the news before he answered because it *had* to be serious for him to video call him and his best friend's reaction when he accepted the call only proved that, "I heard on the news. I'm sorry."

For once he both didn't want to lie *and* he didn't want to be a burden, and he landed on what was true for both, "It's ok. I'm glad it's all over really."

"Isn't there still,"

"A funeral? Yeah. But my Aunt's handling all of that. I just have to turn up."

"That's something. But you know I'm there for you right? If there's literally anything i can do let me know."

"Yeah I know."

"How's um, your dad?"

Adrien couldn't keep the surprise off his face.

"Look I don't like him," Nino admitted, "But a) I *do* like you and I don't want things to be worse for you than they have to be, and b) I wouldn't wish what's happened on anyone, not even Hawkmoth."

The sound he just about managed to stifle down at that was somewhere between a laugh and a scream.

"He's better than I expected honestly." It was true. Since their decision to put her to rest, and even since they'd put her to rest on Friday night, he didn't seem any more absent than usual, though of course how much of his previous time locked away had been grief, and how much had been *Hawkmoth* he didn't know. And he also seemed lighter somehow, which made sense now he'd given up but, "Is it bad I'm kind of annoyed at that?"

"Not really. I mean I guess you've been justifying a lot of what he's like on her being missing, and now it turns out he's just like what."

"A lot of it *was* because of her being missing. I think that the closure is helping him."

"And it's not helping you?" Nino asked looking concerned.

In the face of someone that actually cared about him but couldn't know all the details he had to say, "I think I'd already aceepted she's not coming back. So. This is just,"

"Churning things back up?"

"Yeah."

"Hey, do you want to come over? Or I could come over to yours? If your dad would let you do *either* of those things? I know I don't have whatever powers of persuasion Marinette has on him."

Unforuntely the only way Nino could acquire those powers would be to know that his father was Hawkmoth and be holding that over him, but that might be being unfair because, “He might these days. I can ask Nathalie.”

“Hmm.” Nino said.

“What?”

“Don’t worry yourself.”

---

Nino still looked surprised at having been let in when Adrien greeted him.

“Are you ok?” He asked his friend unsure at quite why he looked *this* shell shocked.

“Shouldn’t I be asking you that?”

“Probably? But you look confused and I want to be distracted.”

“I did bring the newest game in the series,” Nino said pulling it out of his bag, “And unlike Marinette you actually have a chance of beating me.”

Adrien smiled despite himself, “A chance? I can definitely beat you. I *have* been training against Marinette, but seriously why *are* you so confused looking? I told you I’d got permission for you to come over. Honestly I think my father was relieved that someone else was getting him off the hook for spending time with me.”

Unless his father honestly thought playing sad piano music in Adrien’s presence was actually a good way of getting through things, which it was compared to being a supervillain, but Adrien personally suspected it was because he wasn’t ready to talk about it yet.

Nathalie had said to give him time.

“Huh,” Nino said, “Now that *does* actually make sense.”

“Seriously though what is it?”

“I swear to god his assistant kind of smiled when she let me in? *And* she was dressed like, almost casually?”

“Yes?” Adrien said confused as to why this mattered, “She does that sometimes?”

“She *does?*”

“Uh yeah?”

“If you say so.” Nino still looked unconvinced, “Um, she’s not being weird about your Maman and everything? Given that I guess that frees up things for her and your Dad?”

“Oh trust me.” Adrien said ruefully, “I’m not worried about that. She would have done anything to get Maman back.”

“O.K.” Nino said slowly, “So she and your dad aren’t a thing then?”

“No they’re definitely a thing.”

“But,”

“It’s complicated and I try not to think about it.” He’d decided the fact that Nathalie apparently liked *both* his parents was something he was better off not knowing.

“Yeah that seems like a good idea.” He looked down at his game for a second before he looked back up at Adrien, “Are all of your family like this, or do any of you actually have normal love lives? Is this like a rich people thing? I feel like this might be a rich people thing.”

Sometimes Adrien wondered if Nino had a point about homechooling stunting his emotional growth. “Why would it be a rich people thing?”

“I don’t know. They always seem to get up to weird things in history.”

“Look I don’t think that’s the situation. And I don’t *think* anyone in my family has anything like this,” or at least he hoped Felix’s nebulous thing with Bridget wasn’t this complicated, “And Marinette and I don’t have a thing with Chat Noir.”

He still couldn’t believe Nino thought that.

“Keep telling yourself that.”

“I like *Ladybug*.” He burst out and then realised what he said and tried to frantically backtrack, “I mean out of the two heroes. Even if Chat Noir helped get us together. She’s still more impressive.  But obviously I don’t like her as much as I like Marniette. Who I’m totally not using as a replacement for Ladybug. And my crush on Ladybug might have been a misplaced thing about not admitting my feelings for Marinette because it’s easier to think about something that’s never going to happen.”

Nino stared at him, “Because I actually do believe you about what you’re saying about Marinette I am never going to mention this conversation to her, but seriously, you are not OK.”

“I’m going through a lot.” He pointed out and Nino didn’t know about the half of it.

“Yeah, I know.” Nino hugged him, “But you have me, and Marinette, and Alya too. You *can* talk to us.”

“I’m not sure I want to give Alya any more ideas for stories.”

“Yeah, there *is* that.”

# Chapter 17

Adrien looked at the black and silver bracelet in front of him.

“It was your mother’s,” his father said. “I thought you might want to give it to Marinette. All her jewellery’s yours of course but this seemed fitting for the,” he swallowed, “funeral.”

That seemed weirdly sweet, and before all of this Adrien would have been sincerely touched by the offer, but with all he knew about his father now he had to ask, “Do you have an ulterior motive for this?”

“Adrien,” his father snapped at him, “I don’t know where,” then he stopped, “Sorry, I keep forgetting you’re in on everything now. Yes, if any reporters are doing their jobs then they'll recognise it.”

Adrien frowned, that didn’t really explain why he was doing this, “And that's a good thing because?”

“I thought it would help show our approval of Marinette and help with your issue.”

Oh. That actually was kind of touching.

“And,” he looked slightly ashamed now, “I hoped giving them something to talk about might stop them from talking about other things.”

“Like how Maman died?”

“Exactly. And. Well. Myself and Nathalie to some extent as well.”

Adrien felt a little defensive of Nathalie at that, it wasn’t right for her to be his father’s secret, after everything she’d done for him. “You’ll have to admit that at some point though, you can’t keep it secret forever.”

“Obviously not.” He grimaced, “And the reaction will be horrible whenever I'm sure. But your mother’s funeral is hardly the place. “

“Oh right” Adrien saw the truth of that, and he agreed for the sake of his mother's memory's too but, “Does that mean Nathalie won't come to the funeral?”

He knew he'd have Marinette. And technically his father, though he didn't have much hope of him being in much of a state to be comforting to anyone else but, he’d been relying on having Nathalie’s support too.

“No. She's coming. We thought it would be look stranger if she didn’t. And. I'm not sure how I’d her through the day without her there.”

“Yeah.” Adrien agreed, reassured by his answer.

“Yeah, what?” His father asked sternly, and Adrien hoped he wasn’t going to get a lecture on giving full answers.

“It’ll be easier with her there.” He clarified.

His father softened at that.

---

Overall for once Adrien couldn't actually see a flaw in this particular plan of his father’s. Except that he didn't think it would actually *work* to distract the press. But that wasn't a reason to not give it to Marinette especially as he thought this piece would actually suit her which he had an unfortunate feeling might not be the case for all the rest of his mother's jewellery given how different the two of them looked.

Anyway he was sure she'd appreciate the sentiment.

And she *did* even if she’d told him, “Oh wow, Adrien you didn't have to do that.”

“I didn't do anything really,” she looked at him oddly, “It was my mother’s. My father gave it to me.”

“Oh.” Her eyes widened, “Oh. That’s, are you sure you want me to have this?”

“I gave it to you didn't I?”

“Yes but,”

He interrupted her, “I've a lot of things to remember her by. And even more now that I think my father’s just planning to give me most of her stuff,” which what *was* he supposed to do if his father gave him all his mother’s clothes he wasn't quite sure. Store then somewhere? For something? He'd have to ask Nathalie. “I think I can give you one bracelet.”

“I guess.” Marinette said but she still didn’t quite sound convinced.

“And I like the idea of you having something of hers. I wish you could have met her, I think she'd have liked you.” He hoped so at least. The more he realised his mother had been a more complicated person than he realised the more he realised he didn’t really know her but he thought she'd have been impressed by Marinette’s cleverness and determination.

“Thank you,” Marinette and pressed a kiss to his check, “I wish I could have met her. And I have something for you too!”

She scrambled under her bed and pulled out a present.

He took it. It seemed soft under the wrapping paper, and he gently squished it trying to work out what it was, “What is it?”

She beamed at him. “Open it!”

He unwrapped it to find a black scarf.

“I saw it was supposed to be cold for the funeral. Not that you have to wear it!” She rushed to add, “I’m sure your father has a whole outfit planned for you,”

“He does. And he wanted to talk to you about what you were wearing actually so we could be visually cohesive or something,” Adrien wasn’t sure how they could all not go together in black, but Marinette seemed less mystified, “but he can't stop me from wearing this.”

He wrapped it around his neck to test it and it was very warm and soft, but he guessed he might be biased because he knew it had been made by Marinette for him with love.

“If you’re sure. I wouldn't be offended. I thought it might be useful for Chat Noir if not for you.”

That have him some pause, “Is there going to go a Chat Noir? I'm glad there’s no Hawkmoth any more, especially given, well you know” that I was fighting my father the whole time and he was abandoning me to be Hawkmoth, “but if there’s no Hawkmoth, then, does Paris still need us?”

“I don't know.” Marinette said, “I'm not going to take Plagg from you-you’re my partner, but there must have been a reason that Master Fu didn't give out our Miraculous until Hawkmoth arrived. Maybe our Miraculous just aren't meant to be used for more mundane threats. But then there's more villains out there than just Hawkmoth. If we all disappear one of them might target Paris.”

“Hey, we’ll work it out Bugaboo. I know you will.” he'd been fiddling with the scarf as he talked and he suddenly realised, “Hey, this is like the black version of my birthday scarf.”

“Uh, yeah I guess it would be.” Marinette said.

She didn’t meet his eyes, and another realisation came tumbling down, “Wait, *you* made my birthday scarf didn't you? That's what Nathalie was paying you for the other day wasn't it.”

“Uh, yes?”

“This is amazing.” He said and meant it.

“It is?” She sounded unsure and he wasn’t sure why.

He tried to explain. “It’s like a present from all my favourite people.”

“Yes. Yes that’s exactly what it is.”

Her answer had come slightly too quickly and he knew she was hiding something, “Nathalie didn't commission it did she? This was a panicked replacement for whatever weird thing my father bought wasn’t it? Did she just offer to buy your present from you?”

“Something like that.” Marinette aged more confidently again.

“They literally run a multinational company together. I do not understand how they’re that bad at birthdays,” He would *never* understand why his father had thought a *pen* was a good present, “but that was really nice of you to get me something when we weren't that close yet.”

“Don't laugh at me?” She asked him, “But I thought it would help me confess.”

“Oh.” He hadn’t known Marinette had liked him for *that* long. If only they could have discovered each other sooner.

“Yeah,” She said with a slight twist to her mouth, “I guess you would have rejected me then?”

“I... Don't know? If I'd realised I could think of you like that earlier then things might have been different. Dating you would have made my crush on Ladybug awkward though.”

“Yeah, that's one way of putting it.”

He couldn’t help imaging it, “I would have been a terrible boyfriend to you. I don’t know that I could *not* have fallen for Ladybug and I would have felt so guilty about it all.”

It would have been horrible. *He’d* have been horrible. He was lucky Ladybug *wasn’t* interested in Chat Noir or things might have been really horrible.

“Adrien?” Marinette asked, looking vaguely disturbed, “Let’s not think about things like that.”

“Yeah,” he tried to put the image out of his head, “let’s not.”

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“And you’re happy with your piano piece for the service?” Nathalie asked at dinner.

“Yeah. It’s fine seriously don’t stress about all of this. It's not your job to run it after all.” He told her. He’d been unsure when his Aunt had asked him but he figured it *did* seem easier than giving a reading which had been her other offer to involve him.

Apparently Felix *hadn’t* spoken at his father’s funeral and regretting it so she’d wanted to ensure Adrien was involved.

“Thank God.” Nathalie said, sounding like she truly meant it and Adrien couldn’t blame her. The whole thing seemed to be becoming quite a production, which he didn’t *really* begrudge since he thought his Maman would have liked it, but there was a lot to organise.

His father looked at Nathalie, “Will you be ok?”

“I think I should be asking you that.” She pointed out.

“I meant will you be alright standing that long?”

The reminder of Nathalie’s health weighed him down. He knew it wasn’t his fault but that didn’t stop him wishing again that he’d been able to stop all this earlier.

“I don't see there’s any way around it.” Nathalie said, sounding far less bothered about it than Adrien felt, “If I have a dizzy spell in church, then I guess I just grab the pew in front.”

“That's not much of a solution.” His father pointed out.

“I can't think of a better one. Unless you want to get me a cane or something. Could you get me a black one?”

“I can get whatever one you want if it'll help. I just don't like the situation.”

“Gabriel. I'm not going to die.” She smiled and took his hand, “I'm not getting worse anymore.”

“But you’re not getting *better* either.”

Her smiled turned a little sadder. “It is what it is. Plenty of people live with chronic conditions and they don’t have you to make it easier.”

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The funeral went better than he’d expected. *He’d* already said goodbye to his Maman, but it was nice to see other people doing so too.

And, if he could watch Marinette getting defensive on his behalf every time someone asked a prying question all day he honestly *would.*

It was *very* easy to see Ladybug in her.

And it was just…impressive.

Even if he wasn’t admitted that last bit to anyone because he thought that probably *wasn’t* an appropriate thought to have at your mother’s funeral.

---

His father was theoretically supposed to be helping Adrien with a tricky part of his newest piece on the piano though Adrien wasn’t sure he actually that helpful, and Nathalie was sat

on the sofa flicking through her tablet.

“Huh.” Her eyebrows rose, “Gabriel look at this.”

He honestly wasn’t that bothered by the interruption. This piece *was* difficult and he’d gotten used to *not* having his father around to see his initial mistakes.

His father took the tablet frowning. “Oh, for,” he started then he seemed to realise Adrien was there and stopped himself.

“It could be worse.” Nathalie said, “It’s not as bad as some of the headlines I anticipated about us.”

“For *you.”* His father said, “It makes me look ridiculous.”

“What happened?” Adrien asked. “I didn't think you two had done anything in public. Not as you know. You.”

“We haven’t.” His father snapped.

Nathalie made a small face of disagreement, and tilted the tablet so Adrien could see.

It was a photo of his father and Nathalie by the grave, which must have been taken by a long lens, when she'd gone to retrieve him, after everyone else had left. He'd had an arm around her waist but she appeared to be trying to push him away with an annoyed expression on her face.

“Um.”

“Things might have backfired.” Nathalie said ruefully.

“I told you that you were overthinking it.” His father said. “Nothing happened that couldn't have just have been between friends.”

“Except we’re *not* just friends, and that’s going to come out eventually. I was trying to protect your reputation. I know how important Emilie was to you. I couldn’t bear for people to think she wasn’t.”

“Well *now* the press thinks I’m sexually harassing my assistant, and that I’m tasteless enough to do it *at my wife’s funeral.*” He looked digested, “*And* they’re brought up everything with Mayura again to suggest that between the two things I’m clearly having some sort of midlife crisis.”

He made that sound ridiculous and Adrien had to point out, “I mean, I think Hawkmoth could be considered a midlife crisis.”

He could also have pointed out that telling your assistant that she needed to make out with you on the Eiffel Tower when you weren’t together probably *was* sexual harassment but he was fairly certain that hadn’t been how Nathalie saw it despite her hesitation.

His father met his eyes, and Adrien thought he was about to explode, but then he stood up and stomped out of the room.

He stared after him. “Is that progress?”

To his shock. Nathalie laughed with a faint tinge of hysteria to it.

“I’m sorry.” She said, “I think it’s a good thing if he’s working on his temper. Unless he’s just forgotten he can’t akumatise himself. Sorry.” She said again. “It’s just I never imagined *this*.”

Adrien wasn’t quite sure which parts of it she was referring to.

He wasn’t sure he wanted to know.

She shut her eyes and her face smoothed out to his normal neutrality. “I’ll go after him and remind him that he’s not taking advantage of me.”

“Is *that* what’s bothering him?”

It kind of made sense with how he finally seemed guilty over Nathalie’s health, if not about anything he’d done to the rest of Paris.

“Probably.” She said. “Though I’m sure he’s concerned about damage to the brand too.”

“Is that going to be a problem?”

“I doubt it. *I’m* certainly not going to be issuing any sob stories to the press, and besides we’re not American. People will probably barely raise an eyebrow.”

---

He thought that Nathalie *might* have slightly underestimated the response given the number of interviews she actually had to turn down.

Even *Alya* had asked him, if she had anything to say for the Ladyblog.

“Your beat is superheroes.”

“There’s not exactly much going on there. I’m trying to investigate what’s up but I’m not getting anywhere.  And anyway, if they are together like you say, then it’s relevant, because I’d have to ask if she’s worried about Mayura, and what all of that was like for her.”

He couldn’t explain how much Nathalie was not worried about Mayura but, “you *know* that wasn’t great for her.”

“So that was her?” Alya said vindicated.

Feeling uncomfortable he admitted. “I wasn’t supposed to tell anyone about that. Please don’t post that.”

“I wasn’t going to.” She said.  But think about it.”

“I *really* think you should get back to trying to get an interview with Ladybug and Chat Noir instead.” He pointed out. That seemed *much* safer than her digging into any permutation of his father and Nathalie and their alter egos.

Alya’s eyes narrowed, and Adrien squirmed.

“You’re friends with Chat Noir.”

“Just friends.” He reminded her.

“Right. Whatever. But you can get me an interview with him? All of Paris is wants to know what’s behind this sudden lack of akumas? Or at least I could get *his* comment on the situation with the three of you.”

“I can ask him?” Adrien said, wondering how he kept getting into these situations, “But even if he’s happy to do it he’d probably have to ask Ladybug.”

He’d definitely need to get Marinette’s approval. *And* agree on what they were going to say.

"Can't he make his own decisions?"

"He probably shouldn't." Or at least not until he was sure he was a better decision maker than his father anyway.

---

“You owe me.” Adrien said when Nathalie opened the door to let him in the house.

“Yes.” She agreed. “Is this for anything in particular though?”

“*Nathalie!”*  His father’s voice rang through the house.

She looked towards the Atelier. “I should probably go. He’s on a call with someone from the company.”

"About you?"

"Strangely enough they didn't tell me what it was about so I'd say so."

"Um, I guess we'll talk later then."

# Chapter 18

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The problem, Adrien thought, with doing an interview with your friend who didn't know you were her friend was that you rather got a sense of deja vu.

Alya held out of the photo of Chat Noir climbing into Marinette's window.

Beside him Marinette bristled, as if she was the cat of the two of them instead of being clad in red and black spots.

"So," Alya said, "Is this how you visit all your friends?"

Adrien effected nonchalance, "As Chat Noir yeah. I don't exactly go climbing in windows without the mask. That might draw a little attention."

"And this didn't?"

"Urgh," he buried his head in his hands, and his contrition was only half faked, then he looked up, "Honestly I regret not just going through the door."

"You could have done that?" Alya asked in surprise, "Her parents would have let you?"

"Of course they would." He said sincerely faking offense this time, "Who do you think I am? No I was trying to avoid people talking, given that it could be dangerous to be my friend," he let himself look embarrassed, "obviously that backfired."

To her credit Alya *did* look a little shamefaced at that. "I'm sure if Hawkmoth was going to target Marinette he would have done so earlier. Besides she's got you as protection hasn't she?"

"And her boyfriend. I don't know if you're heard but his family are *very* into their private security. Honestly I'm not sure that his father isn't going to make it impossible for me to climb in her window." He *hoped* that saying that wasn't a mistake if his father was watching this video.

"I'd heard that." Alya said, "And honestly I think even Hawkmoth should think twice about provoking Gabriel Agreste any further. I've heard that guy bears a grudge. And I don't think any of us know who Mayura would chose if it came to it. But anyway I'm sure Adrien understands your relationship with Marinette. He's a very understanding guy."

"He understands it because there's nothing *to* understand," Marinette interrupted.

"Uh, Ladybug," he tried to stop her, and reassure her he was fine, and he was used to this sort  of thing but she didn't look like she was in a mood to go along with him.

“No, don’t Ladybug me.” Marinette said. “I’m sick of this.”

“Um.” Alya looked between the heroes, “sick of what?”

“People implying all these *things* about Chat Noir. He’s allowed to have friends you know. He’s a real person just like you are and all your viewers are. Just because he’s super attractive and dressed in black leather doesn’t mean he’s some blank canvas for people to project their fantasies onto. There’s nothing going up between him and this Marinette. Or between him and Adrien Agreste. And by the way, both of them are *also* real people who its super weird people to talk about like people do. They’re still only teenagers trying out their own relationships.”

“Um.” Alya said.

“And do you understand how *hard* it is to do everything we do and live our civilian lives too? And then Chat Noir has to deal with *this*? Just because he’s nice to one girl other than me? No, that’s not fair. “

“I don’t think anybody was trying to make things harder for Chat Noir.” Alya offered. “I think a lot of people just want to see him get his happy ending.”

“And he will.” She looked towards him for a moment and the affection in her eyes warmed him to his core, “he deserves it. But there’s *nothing* between him and this girl. Trust me *I* know what it’s like when he’s flirting and what she and he has isn’t that.”

Alya looked a little thrown by this rant from the heroine of Paris, but proving her propensity to take her life in her hands for the story once again she asked, “So who *is* Chat Noir flirting with then?”

Marinette went bright red. “I literally just said people shouldn’t pry into our private lives.”

Instead of being put off by this Alya’s face grew the largest grin he’d ever seen, “Interesting that you specified both of your private lives just then.”

Marinette made an incoherent noise and yanked off her microphone, and stormed over to the window and jumped out of it.

“Um.” Adrien blinked, not having to fake his surprise-they hadn’t discussed all of that, “should I go after her? I mean that kind of sounded like she was interested back right?”

Alya reached over and took his mike, “If you’re still as in love with her as you’ve been claiming from the start,”

“Obviously I am.”

“Then you should definitely go after her.”

“Right,” he stood up and ran his hands through his hair and it shouldn’t really matter because Marinette was already his girlfriend but after that performance he wanted to look like a guy a girl like that deserved. “I’m going after her.”

"Huh." Nino said, "Dude your dad's trending again."

"*Again?*" Adrien groaned, "I don't suppose it could be for something normal like a new collection?"

Nino shook his head and passed the phone over, "On the upside however Marinette's done it he seems to have basically decided she's his future daughter-in-law. I would so *not* want to be you if you're somehow stupid enough to mess things up with her."

"I think he's decided she's going to be the Yves Saint Laurent to his Christian Dior so," Adrien shrugged before he registered the rest of Nino's sentence, "Wait, why would *I* be the one to mess things up with her?"

"You think *Marinette* is going to ruin things?"

"Fair point." Adrien admitted, "What's he done *now*?"

"Just watch it."

Adrien pressed play on the video.

"M.Agreste," the reporter thrust the microphone in his father's face, and Adrien could see the slight flare of panic in Nathalie's eyes in the edge of the frame and he shared it concerned that maybe his father had punched the interviewer in face, "What does your son think about the developments between Ladybug and Chat Noir?"

His father did a good impression of wanting the squash the man under his shoe but all he did was say, "What an idiotic question. I'm sure Adrien is just as delighted for the heroes as everyone else in Paris."

"But doesn't he have a rather more personal connection to Chat Noir?"

The answering glare was *much* more pleasant when deployed on Adrien's behalf than when deployed at Adrien.

"I don't know what you're talking about."

"But,"

"I believe my son and his girlfriend and Chat Noir have all been *very* clear on this matter. Are you too stupid to remember that?"

"No we've all seen their statements but,"

“And surely you wouldn’t *dare* claim Chat Noir sneaking around behind *Ladybug’s* back? I don’t think *I’d* want to annoy either of the heroes. Really it’s all been blown out of proportion. All Chat Noir wanted was from Marinette was a present for Ladybug she was making for him, she’s really very talented you know.”

The reporter didn’t seem interested in what his father thought of Marinette’s abilities and interrupted, “And what about Hawkmoth?”

Adrien worried that would expose some flaw but then his father had hidden Hawkmoth for months. There was no reason he’d slip up *now.*

Indeed any surprise he showed seemed quite natural, “Hawkmoth?”

“Don’t you worry about annoying *him*? You’ve had quite the number of run-ins with the heroes and villains yourself.”

“Hawkmoth’s a coward who’s never come close to beating the heroes and seems to have disappeared off the face of the earth. I-and all of Paris *certainly* have no reason to fear *him*.”

That was a response that he thought possibly *should* get raised in a therapy session if it wasn’t for the fact Adrien had no idea how Nathalie would ever find one who they could be honest about all this with.

“Do you think Hawkmoth will target your dad again?” Nino asked, leaning over and pausing the video.

“I doubt it.” Adrien said truthfully, “It’s not like he was a very successful akuma.”

“Yeah,” his friend agreed, “And even if he’s dating his assistant now I doubt Hawkmoth would like a repeat of that whole thing with Mayura.”

“Yeah, I’m pretty sure he wouldn’t.” He agreed truthfully, because even though it would be less awkward for them now he was pretty sure that it was a story neither Nathalie nor his father would want out there nonetheless. “Is there uh, anything more?”

“Oh yeah some, but like I assume you actually know what’s going on with this part.”

“That’s certainly a brave response.” The reporter says.

“Not really. Now did you actually have anything relevant to ask?”

There’s a beat of silence then, “Did you want to comment on the rumours about your actions towards your assistant?”

For a moment Adrien honestly does think his father about the punch the guy but then he looks to the side and says, “Nathalie did you want to comment on that?”

“No.” comes through clearly through she’s off-screen at that moment. Not that Adrien thinks it’s likely her face would betray much.

“No we don’t have any comment.” His father says, “This interview is over.”

---

Marinette put the game controller down after beating him yet again, “So you know how you said you’d be honest with me if I won again?”

“I’m always honest with you,” then he added, “now.”

She rolled her eyes, “Yeah, yeah kitty. But things *are* going ok right?”

“Yeah, things are,” and maybe it was only in that moment he realised, “Things are good actually.”

His father had actually even talked to him about his mother unprompted last night, and not because he’d needed to confess more of their wrongdoings either.

---

“I'm going to Marinette’s for lunch today,” Adrien announced and waited for Nathalie’s response.

As it turned out all his well thought out defences turned out to be unnecessary because all she said was, “I'll let your father know.”

For all the tension in the house was slowly draining out, like laying his mother to rest had unblocked something, he still wasn’t used to this relaxation of what he could do, “That won't be a problem?”

Nathalie’s shoulder gave the slightest suggestion of a shrug, “So long as you *are* just going to Marinette’s and not anywhere else it’ll be fine. Your bodyguard can take the two of you.”

It wasn't quite a full relaxation but by his father’s standards it was a *lot.*

Especially given that Gorilla was *much* laxer about watching him than Nathalie or his father was.

Not that he was going to tell either of them yet.

---

“So what was it you wanted to show me?”

“Come on, you’ll see when we get there.” Marinette pulled him up to her room and he couldn’t stop blushing even though he’d been there tons of times before.

He wasn’t sure what he was expecting but he knew it wasn’t for her to go out to her balcony and pick up a saucepan that had been sitting out there.

She lifted off the top and make a squeak of excitement. It was utterly adorable.

“It worked,” She said, and held it out to him.

The red liquid inside literally glowed.

“Is that?” He almost didn’t dare ask.

“I said I’d try and do something for Nathalie.” Marinette said, “I didn’t want to say anything until I was fairly certain I’d got it right. Not that I’m sure it’s going to definitely help her-it’s based on a different potion for different Miraculous damage but all the Kwami’s and I are certain there’s power in it and that it won’t harm her.”

“You’re amazing.” He said and he meant it. He didn’t know what he’d done to deserve someone like Marinette in his life. He *didn’t* deserve Marinette, but he was going to try and make it so he did every day of his life.

Marinette blushed, “I’m just doing my best.”

“Yeah, well, your best is amazing.” He took a step closer to her, “Could you put that down for a moment?”

“Sure,” she blinked, “Why?”

“Because I want to give you a thank you kiss.”

“Oh. Yes. I can do that.”

---

“So, um, do you think you can look after it at school, and bring it home after?”

Adrien glanced the time on his phone, “I think we could run it over now.”

“Should you ring your bodyguard to bring the car back then?”

He walked to the window and looked at the long line of traffic below them. “We’re probably quicker walking. If you're ready to run the gauntlet of the paparazzi?”

---

“I think.” Marinette said after *another* camera flashed in her eyes, “That I get the other half of why your dad doesn’t leave the house now.”

---

Bizarrely the gate didn’t open immediately for him, and he met Marinette’s eyes in confusion.

“Maybe they’re out? You told them you weren't coming back for lunch didn't you?”

“It's my father and Nathalie.” He reminded her.

“Ok yeah, that doesn't sound that likely.”

He pushed the button again to no response.

On the third ring Nathalie finally answered sounding somewhat flustered, “Sorry Adrien. I didn’t think you were coming back this lunchtime.”

---

She looked as out of sorts as she’d sounded when she opened the door apologising again.

“It’s fine.” Adrien told her, but he’d been pretty sure she’d had her blazer on and her hair in a bun like usual rather than in a ponytail this morning, “I should have rang and said we were coming.”

“Yes that would have been helpful.”

An awkward silence fell between them, and Marinette had gone bright right again though he wasn’t sure why.

“So what did you two come over for? Did you need something?” Nathalie asked.

“Sort of the opposite.”

“The opposite?”

Marinette held out her travel mug to Nathalie who took it, but seemed a bit lost until she opened the lid and saw the glowing red concoction inside.

“Is this?”

“I can't say it'll cure you. It's not designed specifically for the damage done by a broken Miraculous. But let's just say you’re not the first person in history to suffer from using them.”

Nathalie stared at the mug in her hands as if she couldn’t quite believe it was there. “Do I just drink all of it now or?”

“You can drink all of it now. You'll probably need more but it should be a start.”

“Ok.” Nathalie said still sounding somewhat disbelieving, but she raised it to her lips then stopped, “Sorry. I mean. Thank you. I never said thank you.”

“You can save that for when you know if it's worked.”

“Well, thank you anyway, for trying, and for everything.”

“Shouldn’t we call my father so he knows what you’re doing?”

“That’s unnecessary.” Nathalie said, slightly too quickly.

“But what there’s some sort of side effects? Marinette said she wasn’t sure about how it would work.”

“I’ll tell him later.”

At that point the door to the Atelier opened, “Tell me what?”

Nathalie turned to him and some part of Adrien’s brain noted his cravat was missing though he otherwise seemed perfectly put together.

“Marinette’s made a potion to help Nathalie get better.”

That stopped him in his tracks. “She has?”

Marinette held her hands up in something like surrender, “I’ve tried to. I can’t garauntee it’ll fix everything. It probably *won’t* made her completely better, but it should help.”

“Still. Thank you. We’re in your debt, I know you didn’t have to do anything.”

Marinette glanced back at Adrien, “I don’t know if that’s true.”

“Well, if there’s ever anything we can do for you only have to say.”

“I think you’re already doing that. Just, don’t push Adrien away again. And definitely don’t become a supervillain again.”

“I can guarantee you I certainly don’t plan to do that.”

“Well,” Marinette said, “That’s good then. And I think Adrien and I should leave you two to it. We’ve got to hurry to get back to school.”

They actually had quite a decent amount of time left to get back to school but Adrien didn’t point that out.

---

It was hard to judge on a day by day basis but Nathalie *did* seem to be improving. She didn’t seem to get dizzy when standing so much, or to cough anything like she had been.

She was still committed to quitting her job though. Apparently despite what she’d said earlier again needed their approval she’d gone ahead and told the company.

Adrien still had mixed feelings about that.

It was *weird* imaging someone else in her place.

His father seemed to agree because he’d said at dinner recently that Nathalie hadn’t exactly chosen a good time to announce her resignation, and from how she’d ignored him he assumed it was an ongoing disagreement.

---

“Adrien.” Marinette asked between classes, “How worried should I be that Nathalie’s asking for my measurements?”

“It depends on how little you want to go out to dinner with my family?”

“What.”

“She texted me asking me to ask you to come to dinner with us.”

“With *all* of you?”

“Apparently.”

“*Out of your house?”*

“Yeah I know.”

“*Why?*”

“I think my father’s got annoyed at an article again. You don’t have to go if you don’t want to.”

“I guess it’s a good thing if he’s going out again?”

“Yeah, I mean, I guess it’s not one of his stupider plans in terms of him and Nathalie going public *and* showing support for you and me.”

“I kind of meant, I actually really get now why he stayed in all the time but I don’t think it was healthy?”

“We literally both know that *none* of his coping mechanisms were healthy for like, anyone.”

“Exactly.”

---

“Nathalie?” Adrien asked as she fussed over his clothes, “Are you sure this is a good idea?”

“No.” She said, “But I’m not sure why you still think I’m any good at stopping your father’s bad ideas. And I suppose me and him had to come out somehow. I might as well be forewarned.”

She took a step back, “Well you look very smart at least.”

“So do you.” Although maybe smart wasn’t the word. Smart was what Nathalie looked like normally and in the silver dress she was wearing tonight and with her hair down she looked absolutely nothing like she did normally.

She rolled her eyes, “I feel overdressed even though I know *exactly* the dress what the dress code is where we’re going, and how people dress there and I’m adhering to both. I guess I’ll have to get used to that though.”

---

Despite what she’d said, and despite his father being his father Adrien didn’t really think either of them looked uncomfortable on their way into, or indeed *in,* the restaurant at all.

Or least Adrien was fairly certain *his* reaction to being uncomfortable wouldn’t be to keep making eyes at, and finding excuses to touch his partner.

He swore that they weren’t this bad at home.

In fact he guessed they were acting like *Hawkmoth and Mayura.* Which he knew they *were* them but it was still utterly bizarre to be actually able to see that.

Poor Marinette was having to cope with this *and* seemed a little thrown by all the attention despite having always been fine with cameras as Ladybug though so Adrien put a supportive arm around her on their way in.

---

Adrien wasn't sure if Marinette was stretching things out in revenge for the restaurant. Not that he could really blame her.

"So." She announced. "I've been having to give what I should do about you two a lot of thought."

"We understand that," Nathalie said, "Don't we Gabriel?"

"Yes." His father added.

"And I know you surrendered in the end. And I know that it wasn't easy for you and that despite everything that's happened you still regret not being able to save Mme.Agreste. And that despite everything I don't know if Nathalie's health is ever going to be what it was."

They both silently nodded.

"But I also know that all of Paris expects me to bring them some sort of justice." She added. "And I know that you hurt people and I'm honestly not sure you regret that part."

No one dared say anything.

"But Adrien's suffered enough too. So I'm not going to expose your identities."

"You're not?" His father asked.

"No. Not unless you do something to make me. But I am expecting you to make it up to your victims."

Nathalie frowned and Adrien could see her brain working, "On an individual level?"

"If you can. I'm sure you have a list of who you targeted."

Nathalie nodded.

"Well, the two of you targeted people's darkest moments. I'm sure you can work out what would be the most fitting reparations to make to each of them."

Nathalie glanced at his father, “I’m not sure either of us are much good at emotions ironically enough but we can certainly try, *will try*.”

“M.Agreste?” Marinette asked, noticing his father’s uncharacteristic silence on the matter.

“Yes?” He said like he was coming out of a daze, “Of course we’ll do what you’re asking. In fact I believe Nathalie’s going to have plenty of free time coming up to research a best course of action.”

“Still going to get another job eventually.” Nathalie muttered under her breath.

---

Doing an interview with an actual reporter *should* have made things easier than it was with Alya.

Or at least for him. He knew Marinette babysit for her but he wasn’t sure how close she was generally to Nadja Chamuck.

“So do you two know what’s behind Hawkmoth’s recent lack of attacks? Should people be bracing themselves for something big on the way?”

He let Marinette answer. Ladybug *was* the one in charge after all.

“No,” she shook her head, “I can’t go into details because Chat Noir and I are still working on the situation but though I can’t give away how I know Hawkmoth appears to have left Paris.”

“Left Paris? Do you know where he is?”

“We couldn’t possibly comment on that I’m afraid.” Adrien said.

“And what would you say to people who’d say you’ve been distracted by each other rather than chasing down Hawkmoth?”

Marinette smiled but Adrien could tell it was fake, “I can honestly say we’re much less distracted now we’re both on the same page.”

---

“Good job kid,” The photographer said, “Honestly you are *so* much easier to work with than those last two models.”

“Thanks,” said Adrien, then he caught sight of Nathalie talking to someone he vaguely recognised as a tabloid reporter who’d tried to talk to him a few times at the edge of the shoot. “I should, uh, maybe go see what’s happening there.”

“Isn’t it her job to keep them away from you not the other way round?”

“It’s kind of more complicated than that, sorry!” He excused himself.

He got to Nathalie just in time to hear her say, “No I’m not worried about that at all. In fact I see no reason to think Mayura won’t be very happy with Hawkmoth rather than being any threat to our relationship.”

“Are you saying you *know* something about Hawkmoth and Mayura’s disappearance? Shouldn’t you tell someone? The Police? Ladybug and Chat Noir?”

“Ladybug and Chat Noir are completely aware of everything I know on the topic,” she said completely straight-faced. “But I really don’t have any more time to talk, as Adrien has places to be.”

For once he actually didn’t really but he certainly wasn’t going to say that.

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“Seriously though,” Nino said, reclining back on Adrien’s sofa, “Do your dad and Nathalie know something about Hawkmoth and Mayura?”

“Trust me.” Adrien said. “You do *not* want to know.”

Nino turned to look at him better and whatever he found on Adrien’s face made him go, “OK I won’t ask then. But if Hawkmoth’s jealously over whatever happened with your dad and Mayura is why they’ve left Paris for their honeymoon or whatever then that’s actually hilarious.”

“Is *that* what people are saying?”

“It’s some people’s theory.”

“Please tell my father that at dinner.”

“Adrien, I’ve barely managed to get unbanned from your house. I’m not being banned *again.* I’m on like perfect behaviour the whole time I’m here-no loud music, perfect manners, proper snobby Academy French with no slang, and everything *all* for your sake, and you’re trying to get me banned?”

“Hey I’m not trying to get you banned!”

Nino looked at him over the top of his glasses clearly unconvinced.

“I think he might appreciate the topic being raised.”

“Yeah *you* can do that. He *probably* wouldn’t throw you out for it.”

Adrien laughed, “Yeah he wouldn’t want to incur Marinette’s wrath for that.”

Nino didn’t join in with his laughter but then he wasn’t exactly in on the joke.

Chapter End Notes

For a story I've been thinking of as mostly done for a while this chapter was surprisingly difficult to bring to an end!

End Notes

may or may not continue this tbh

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